

NIKI MACKEY

THE
DUE
DATE

You shared
everything
for nine
months

But you
don't know
her at all



NIKI MACKAY

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DUE DATE



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First published in Great Britain in 2023 by
HEADLINE PUBLISHING GROUP

This Ebook edition published in 2023 by
HEADLINE PUBLISHING GROUP

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Cataloguing in Publication Data is available from the British Library

ISBN: 978 1 0354 0454 4

Cover images: houses © Magdalena Russocka/ Trevillion Images;
windows and foliage © Miguel Sobreira/Trevillion Images;
women and tree © Shutterstock
Cover design by Lisa Horton

HEADLINE PUBLISHING GROUP

An Hachette UK Company
Carmelite House
50 Victoria Embankment
London EC4Y 0DZ

www.headline.co.uk

www.hachette.co.uk

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Niki Mackay studied Performing Arts at the BRIT School. She holds a BA (Hons) in English Literature and Drama, and won a full scholarship for her MA in Journalism. A lifelong avid reader, she wrote her first novel in 2017. She also writes under NJ Mackay.

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You shared everything for nine months. But you don't know her at all.

When Ali meets Rebecca, she feels an instant connection. Both pregnant, with babies due the same day, Ali can't wait to share the highs and lows of motherhood with her new friend.

Rebecca is everything Ali wishes she could be – beautiful, confident, wealthy. But Ali senses in her the same loneliness she's been feeling since moving to the suburbs. Maybe they can help each other, and Ali won't feel so alone anymore.

Then their due date comes and goes, and Ali hears nothing for weeks.

Worried about her friend, Ali tracks her down and is relieved to find Rebecca safe and well. But relief turns to shock when Rebecca denies ever meeting her . . . or ever having been pregnant at all.

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With love for my sons, Elliot and Eddie; you changed everything.

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Prologue

2010

She stares down at him. His body is misshapen, left leg flung out sideways at an almost jaunty angle, head turned too far to one side, eyes wide open, staring, glassy.

There are noises outside, the frantic sound of people rushing from the house to the patio and panicking. Screams reach up, carried on the stiflingly warm night air. She steps back from the edge of the balcony, back into the room she'd been asleep in just, what – minutes . . . probably only seconds ago? Before everything shattered and fragmented; her hopes and dreams, falling down around her like jagged broken glass.

Her teeth start chattering, and the rest of her body follows suit, a terrible dance starting as a quiver in her head, a shudder in her shoulders, taking over the rest of her. A sound escapes. 'Shh,' says her friend, getting up now, coming towards her, crawling on hands and knees. She is frowning, serious.

She clamps her hands to her mouth but the sobs explode out between her fingers, her warm breath a sharp contrast to her cold, frostbitten digits.

'Stop.'

'I . . . I . . . c-c– c-c-can't.'

'You can.'

She shakes her head, the world spins as the insides of her brain slip around in her skull like soup.

'You can.' Again. Firm. Strong. 'Breathe in, with me.'

'C-c-c-c-c-can't.'

'Yes, you can.' Hands, familiar, pressing into her shoulders. The fingers digging in hard, not hurting, not quite, but almost. 'Look at me.'

Her eyes meet her friend's, hands clenched like claws, talon nails pressing

into her cheeks. Her friend takes them in hers, her voice soft, low, soothing. 'Breathe in, one . . . two . . . three . . . and out, four . . . five . . . six.'

They get to a hundred. Her heart has slowed, her legs are like jelly, but she feels steadier, like she can, at least, stay standing; her arms are slack now, hanging by her sides, her breath loud and long.

The music that had been blaring has cut to silence, and they hear footsteps on the stairs. Each one feels like a death knell.

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PART ONE

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Now

I stab the knife into the flimsy brown masking tape and run it across the width of the box. It makes a pleasing sound and a puff of air escapes to freedom. The baby rolls inside me. I sit back on my heels, lifting up the last top I own that fully covers me and look at my stomach shifting, shapes protruding through skin that looks as thin as the tape I've just cut through. The top is damp with my perspiration, the heat making my large, ungainly body even more difficult to bear. A faint brown line marks my protruding, fit-to-split belly right down the centre. It's called a *linea alba*. Dan looked it up in one of the many books he has come home brandishing like wondrous gifts and read aloud from, awed by all that my body can do.

My phone rings, startling me. I drop the knife which nicks my swollen ankle on its way down. A bright pinprick of blood rises immediately. 'Shit.' I lick my finger, press it against the tiny mark. As soon as I pull my hand away the spot bubbles up again.

Mum flashes on the screen. I'll leave it. I don't need to pick up every single time she calls. It keeps ringing for an appallingly long amount of time.

I grab it at the last moment. 'Mum, hi.'

'Interrupt you, did I?'

'No,' I say through clenched teeth as a bead of sweat worms its way down my still-bared belly. I pull the top back down, pressing it against the wetness, feeling it sink into the material. I am leaking from everywhere, like a large, damp porous thing. 'I'm just finishing unpacking.'

'Why on earth are you still unpacking?'

'I haven't had time before now. Neither of us have. We've been working.'

She makes a noise that could be a guffaw, or a sigh, or an exhale. 'You're on holiday now, though?'

‘Maternity leave, Mum. I’m on maternity leave.’

She laughs. ‘Holiday, you mean, you’re not due for almost a month.’

Inside the box are more boxes. Plastic ones full of, I swear to God, everything Dan has ever owned in his life. I pick one up, take off the lid: school books, for goodness’ sake. I close it. I’ll just leave these in his office, perhaps that way we can avoid another ‘discussion’ about his hoarding.

‘The baby might come early,’ I say, hoping against hope that that’s not true, not least because Dan is due to be away with work next week.

‘You work from home anyway; I’m not convinced you really need to give up for six months.’

This is a new favourite of hers. She has been appalled at the amount of people who now have flexible working arrangements and absolutely sure that we are all, in fact, sitting at home bone-idle, conning our poor long-suffering employers and laughing whilst we do it.

‘I’m still in meetings all day, Mum,’ I say, standing up, phone pressed between my shoulder and head. Knees groaning at the heft of it. The tiny spot of blood already congealing and surprisingly irritating for such a small wound.

‘Ha,’ she says and I swallow down a million retorts, waiting for the long lecture on all the hard work she has done over the years. I hear the doorbell ring in the background. ‘Hang on, Alison.’ A clattering, the sounds of her footsteps in the hallway. Her voice, cheerful now. Then, ‘Alison, I must go, Nick’s popped by.’

I roll my eyes and am about to say *Okay, bye*, but she’s already gone.

Bloody charming. I look at the boxes, at the floor which needs a good sweep. Our bedroom isn’t much better. I’d foolishly washed the bedding as it was a good drying day so now I have a messy living room, an office with no furniture, a nursery, a miniature kitchen and an unmade bed.

Sod this.

I go out for some fresh air, but outside is almost worse than being inside the poky little cottage. The heat is oppressive and sends a glimmer of worry through me as I contemplate all the ways these persistently high temperatures are wrong in England, and here I am, bringing a child into it. I press a hand beneath my belly, lifting it slightly, feeling a momentary relief on my pelvis and bladder. By the time I get to the lake, I am so grateful to sink onto a bench under a shady tree that I could cry. It is quiet here now, but it

gets busy at lunchtime, people spill out from an industrial estate not far away with sandwiches and blankets, making the most of the summer that threatens to suffocate me. Later it will be flooded by school children on their way home. Just a few short years ago I'd have enjoyed this moment – a day off, the sun out – with a cigarette, perhaps a can of fizzy pink G&T, at least a coffee. I'd given up all of those two short weeks after we'd got married and decided to start trying for a baby, back in the days when we lived in London proper, in a crappy houseshare admittedly, but in a vibrant, buzzing area. I'd always been able to work from home occasionally but then, I was mostly in the office. Often by choice. I liked my job, got along well with my colleagues and felt like I was doing work that mattered. Since the pandemic, my boss, Joanna, allowed us to choose how much we came in, which had enabled Dan and me to buy a place further out of the city. We'd saved and saved and saved to be able to afford it and, here we were. Out in the calm, subdued suburb I grew up in. On the water, a beautiful swan floats past, followed by smaller, greyer ones – cygnets, they're called, aren't they? She looks unruffled by motherhood. Unperturbed. Quite the opposite of me before I've even got started.

'Bloody awful to be so enormous in this heat.'

I turn quickly with a frown, which drops when I see a tall woman with dark hair and a belly to rival my own grinning down at me. She points to the seat. 'May I?'

'Please,' I say. 'There's not enough shade.'

She lowers herself with a groan I immediately sympathise with, and I find myself suppressing a smile. 'Look at that haughty cow.' I look around and see that she's glaring at the swan. 'Bet she just popped them out and carried on gliding through the water.'

I laugh, really laugh, my annoyance at Dan's inability to part with anything he's ever touched and my mother's judgemental voice pushed away. 'I was thinking the same thing.'

'Well, you would, wouldn't you? In our situation.'

This, this is what I've been longing for. I'd imagined it back when I didn't realise that, despite both being professionals with degrees and decent salaries, owning a property and having a child would sink us into almost instant poverty if we lived anywhere within commutable distance to London. I'd imagined that I'd give up work early on in my pregnancy, join an NCT group and be part of a close-knit circle who hosted intimate get-togethers in

our beautiful kitchens. Instead, Dan and I couldn't both be in our galley kitchen simultaneously and NCT classes were an extravagance too far. To make matters worse, I was the first of my work friendship group to have a child and as my pregnancy had progressed and I'd switched to working almost exclusively from home, it wasn't just the physical distance between us, it was the life distance too. Whilst my colleagues, who were mostly in their early twenties, were busily deciding what to wear to hit the clubs at the weekend, I was out shopping for compression socks in a vain attempt to sort out my Michelin-man ankles. Occasionally one of them would remember to ask how I was getting on in the group chat, but more and more I felt I had little to contribute and even less to gain. Joanna had children but they were all grown and had left home. Plus, she was my boss and we didn't really talk about personal matters.

'Is it how you thought it would be?' I ask, genuinely curious.

'God, no. Beyoncé has a lot to answer for.'

'Ha. I hear you.'

'What's your worst bit?' she asks, hands resting on top of her bump which is higher than mine.

'The weeing,' I admit.

'All bloody night and, sometimes, in the day before you make it where you need to.' She shakes her head.

'Yes,' I say. 'Do you think we'll go back to normal?'

'Christ, I hope so. Though I suppose then we'll get woken by a screaming infant.' She shrugs. 'So exhaustion is the constant state now.'

I sigh.

She winks at me. 'But at least we'll be able to have wine then.'

'Oh God, yes.' I can almost imagine the taste of a dry white Chardonnay. The feel of it and the heft of an adult glass in my hand. 'Bliss.'

'When are you due?' she asks, head tilting to my bump.

'August the third.'

Her eyes widen. 'No way.' I'm stunned for a minute – does she think I'm lying?

'That's the date they've given me . . .' I say.

'Me too!'

'Oh,' I say, realising now why she was so surprised.

'We'll be mums in arms.' She beams, holding a hand out to me. 'I'm Rebecca, by the way.'

‘Alison . . . Ali. It’s so nice to meet you.’

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I would have loved a sister. When I was a little girl, I'd devoured *Sweet Valley Twins*, then later *Sweet Valley High*. So many of my problems, I'd thought, would be solved by having a diligent, caring twin. One like Elizabeth, of course, though I couldn't profess to be even half as fun as Jessica. Now, I find myself again wishing that I had a few good friends at the same stage as me, or if not quite there, at least starting to think about it. I think of Izzy, wondering what she would have made of my pregnancy, wondering if in fact she knows. I push the thought aside. It doesn't matter, she won't be involved.

Dan picks up the wine glass. Swilling the liquid around the bowl of it, he takes a sip, savouring the flavour. I resist the urge to kick him under the table. Instead, I force myself to smile whilst I sit opposite him, a neat, white tablecloth and a table full of food between us. I'd told him about the park. 'So we're due on the same day, would you believe!'

He smiles. 'Unlikely that will actually happen.'

I frown slightly and tell him, 'I know that, it was just nice to meet someone in the same boat as me.'

He says, 'Yeah, sorry, of course. It's cool though – like, what are the chances?'

'Well, exactly. So then we went to Rosita's.'

'The café in the park?'

I nod. 'She says she's there most days.'

'That's nice.'

'I know, maybe we can hang out once the babies are born, they might be good ones that sit happily in the pram while we drink coffee and chat.'

He laughs. 'You've got it all planned.'

I feel my face heat up. I must sound like an exuberant child: '*I made a friend I made a friend.*'

He reaches across the table, takes my hand in his and squeezes it. 'It's

good, Ali. You're right, it'll be nice to have company. I'm sorry work's so busy.'

'It's fine.' I force a smile. 'It's a new job and, you know, we definitely need the income.'

He sighs, runs a hand over his face. 'We really do.'

A faint glimmer of concern pushes a funny feeling up in my chest. I see years ahead of us, of this. I adore my job; it's varied and challenging and I've done well. I now run the marketing and communications department for a small charity. Straight out of university, I'd been so excited when I'd initially interned there, later becoming a member of staff. 'It will never pay the big bucks, but it's my small chance to make a difference in the world.' I'd meant it too, I still do, but the money isn't amazing and is unlikely to increase by much. I'd joked that I would never earn enough to even start chipping away at my student loans. But things that seemed charming in our twenties when it was just us, living off noodles and full of hope, just seem a bit shit now. With our mortgage, another mouth to feed and the uncomfortable possibility that I might be better off unemployed.

Dan had loved my fresh-faced idealism once. Now, I fear, he's just worried that my pay cheque might not cover nursery fees and, after looking into it, I knew he was probably right.

'I'll ask Joanna for a raise,' I say, 'after my mat leave is finished.'

He nods. 'Not a bad idea, or you could look at retraining. Teachers get all the school holidays, remember?'

I force another smile, nod my agreement, but just the thought of it makes me feel panicked. He gets my plate, puts another slice of frittata on it, the eggs like greasy, congealing rubber. The baby rolls in my stomach.

'Don't neglect your relationship,' Mum had told me. 'You've lucked out with Dan, you don't want to give him any excuses.'

I make an *mmm* sound, keep smiling and murmur, 'Thanks for cooking.'

'Of course, I'm worried,' he says, his brows knitting together, giving me a glimpse of how he might look in old age, 'that you won't eat properly while I'm away.'

I laugh. 'I'll be fine, I can cook for myself, you know,' I say, keeping my voice playful.

'Yeah, no, I know,' he says. 'I've ordered a Tesco shop for the morning after I leave.'

'Right,' I say, my voice tight.

‘Sorry.’ He grins. ‘I’m fussing, aren’t I?’

He is, and it drives me mad at times, but it comes from a nice place, I remind myself.

‘You’re away for three days, Dan.’ He’s heading to his company’s office in France to finish a software installation project that he ended up inheriting after the last guy in the role left suddenly. It is very much Dan’s chance to shine. ‘I’ll be fine. I’ll eat well, even if it won’t be as nice as the food you make. Better still, I’ll watch *Friends* on repeat without you moaning.’

He smiles properly now and I feel a momentary triumph. ‘Are you looking forward to some solo time?’

‘I *will* miss you,’ I say. ‘But I’m about to not be on my own for quite a while.’

‘That is true.’

‘I’ll message Rebecca too, see if she wants to meet up. Maybe invite her over.’ I hadn’t got her number, I realise, but she said she walked at the park most days.

‘That sounds really great, Ali. And when I’m back let’s go for dinner, just the two of us. As you say, we’re going to have company soon.’

‘That’s a good idea,’ I murmur.

‘How about Friday night, could you book somewhere?’

I nod, though the thought of it, and the reality of how much things are about to change, hits me like a slap in the face.

He’s asleep within minutes and I waddle through to the baby’s room, which now has a new single bed in it that Dan had put together last night, ‘for when you’re nursing’. I’ve eaten too much and no matter what position I try to lie in, I can’t get comfortable. I give up, propping cushions behind me, perching my laptop on my knee. I go to Izzy’s Facebook page, scroll through her friends list and click on Max. He’s changed his profile picture, and as always when presented with a new image of him, I am startled. He looks the same: wide dark eyes, broad smile, hair still long, but shorter than it had been back then. I scroll through his page, which is mostly set to public. Him at Glastonbury, at gigs, in the middle of a field with his arm slung over her shoulders. She is, as ever, impossibly beautiful, stick thin. I go back to her page. Scurry through the information. Nothing new. Nothing less than outstanding. There are more pictures of her and Max. The baby shifts and I feel a different kind of sickness.

‘You couldn’t sleep, huh?’

I jump, shutting the lid, startled, and make myself smile at Dan. ‘It’s so hot.’

‘It is. Can I get you some water?’

‘Please.’

When he heads to the kitchen I open the laptop, click out of Facebook and shut the tab, opening Disney+ instead.

He’s back, handing me a glass with ice cubes that clink; I take it gratefully, pressing it to my cheek, between my too heavy breasts. ‘Almost there, Ali.’ He reaches out a hand, pushes aside my hair which hangs lank and damp around my face.

‘Yes.’ I smile, tears springing to my eyes at his tenderness. ‘Thank you,’ I half whisper.

He frowns. ‘What for?’

‘Being so nice. Getting up, checking on me, bringing me water.’

He laughs. ‘Of course. My job, Alison Cooper, is to make you happy.’

I put the laptop on the table beside me, the glass next to it, ice sweat beading on the outside and slipping down. I reach out my hand, cup his cheek. ‘I don’t deserve you,’ I tell him.

‘You do, of course you do.’ He leans forward, pressing his lips to mine. Soft, gentle, familiar. He is, at his core, extremely sweet, my Dan. And loyal and cheerful even when things are tough. Even when *I* am tough, which is more often than I’d like. I married him for these qualities. We met at the start of my MA at a London university after a summer where I felt like everything had fallen apart. I’d been sad and lost, falling, and he’d caught me. He pulls me close now; I move my incredible bulk into the familiar spot where I fit just beneath his shoulder. ‘I love you, Dan.’

‘I love you too.’

I'm just here for a walk and some fresh air, I tell myself, but I find my eyes scouring the park, looking around the lake as I move, slow and laborious. She'd mentioned that she came here most days, 'just to clear my head,' she'd said, and I felt like I knew exactly what she meant. I'm leaving, worming my way through throngs of adult-sized youths in stiff blazers with floppy hair. That means it's after three and I've been here almost two hours, the sun beating down on me, high and oppressive.

'Ali?'

I turn, and there she is. I feel an overwhelming sense of . . . relief?

I grin like an idiot on a first date. 'Rebecca, fancy seeing you here!'

'Fancy. Are you in a rush?'

I glance at my wristwatch, my skin puffed up on either side of it due to water retention. My ankles are the same around my socks, the compression stockings now utterly useless; I've solved it by living only in flip-flops.

'No,' I say as though my life is bursting full of plans. 'I've got an hour or so.'

'Join me for a decaf?'

'I'd love to.'

She insists on paying and returns to the table with a tray of mugs and two muffins, each one almost as big as my face.

'Say you will? I'll feel like an enormous pig otherwise.'

I wouldn't normally, my mother's voice rattling around in my head about being careful. 'You're not actually eating for two adults,' she'd said last time I visited and had reached for a second biscuit.

'Oh, go on then.'

She takes a bite and groans with pleasure. 'There is no better combination in the world than sugar and fat.'

I laugh, taking a bite of my own. We eat in silence for a few minutes but it's comfortable. The air around us is filled with the hollers and hubbub of

the teenagers slinking out of the local school which sits just the other side of the park. Rebecca follows my gaze, which is on a gaggle of them. 'Oh, to be young and carefree again, eh?'

My teenage years weren't exactly what you'd call carefree, but I laugh and nod anyway.

'Although it's not all it's cracked up to be really, is it?'

'Being young?' I ask and she nods. I say, 'I don't think anyone's that good at it until it's too late.'

'What, and you're the size of a house and about to be in charge of someone else's youth?'

'We must be mad.' I screw up my nose.

She laughs. It's a nice sound, musical almost.

'So you grew up around here?' Rebecca asks.

'I did, yeah. I left to go and study though,' I say quickly, my fear of being thought of as parochial making the words sound slightly panicked. 'I came back to my mum's to do a master's. I had a bit of a shitty break-up that kind of threw me.'

'That's tough.'

I smile. 'It wasn't my best.'

'But, you've got a lovely husband now?'

'I do, yeah,' I say, and I do. Dan is lovely. 'What about you?'

'My husband's alright.'

'No, I meant . . .' But she's grinning and throws me a wink.

'Oh.' I smile ruefully, realising I'd missed the joke. 'Duh.'

'I also grew up around here. Want to know something super-tragic?'

'Sure.'

'I actually live in the same road I grew up in.'

'Oh wow.'

'Sad, eh?' She screws up her nose at me.

'Not at all,' I say, meaning it and feeling less like an unadventurous fool for finding my way back to my hometown. 'It's a good place to live and raise kids.'

'Well, yes.' She shifts and says, 'God, it's too hot to be this size, isn't it?'

'It's too hot to be *any* size,' I agree. 'How are you feeling, heat aside?'

'Okay some of the time and then dreadful. I've been getting Braxton Hicks, have you?' I shake my head but I know what they are. Dan had told me, reading a passage from one of the endless baby books.

‘Are they painful?’

‘I mean, considering they’re meant to pale in comparison to the real show.’ She grimaces and I swallow the last clump of my muffin, the tangy blueberries tasting sour as I contemplate it.

‘It’s a design flaw, isn’t it, birth?’

She nods. ‘I’m still toying with electing for a Caesarean.’

‘Can we do that?’

She flushes. ‘Well, I can.’ She waves a hand around. ‘We have private health-care through my husband’s work.’

‘What does he do?’

‘Something dull in law. Yours?’

‘Something dull in IT.’ I grin.

We chat, time passes, so much of it that we are on our third coffee and the waitress has come over to tell us she’s closing. Rebecca stands, pushing her handbag up onto her shoulder, and as she does so, I see a ring of small round bruises on her upper arm. They look like little blue pearls. I almost ask if she’s alright, but she’s saying something I’ve missed.

‘Sorry, Rebecca, what?’

‘I was saying, I’m sure you have a hectic schedule, but I’ll be here at one tomorrow if you fancy lunch?’

‘I’d love that,’ I say eagerly, too delighted to even attempt to play it cool. ‘In fact, why don’t you come to me? I’m only around the corner.’

‘Oh really?’

‘Yes,’ I say, digging around in my bag for a pen and paper. I scrawl my address, adding my phone number too. ‘I mean, at least we’ll have easy access to a loo.’ I smile, not wanting to admit that I can’t really afford to shout her lunch back but I can throw something together at home for half the price.

‘That is a blessing,’ she says with a grin. Her phone vibrates and she grabs it, scowls at the screen without answering, and murmurs something I don’t quite catch.

‘Sorry?’ I say.

She looks up, startled almost. ‘God, sorry, I was talking to myself wasn’t I?’

‘Um.’

‘No, no, honestly, I do it all the time.’ She waves her phone. ‘I do however need to get going.’

‘Yeah, no, of course,’ I say.

‘I’ll see you tomorrow. Let me know if I can bring anything, yeah?’

‘Yeah, great.’

She leans over, kissing me quickly on the cheek. Leaving a lingering smell of flowery perfume and the damp imprint of her lips on my sweaty face.

I realise as I stand to leave that I don’t have her number, but thanks to Dan’s Tesco delivery we’ll be fine. I find myself cheered up as I walk home, waddling slowly, taking my time. I smile as I turn the key in the lock. Grateful to be in out of the heat, here in our little house in this suburb which maybe isn’t too bad after all.

‘That’s great, Ali.’

‘Yeah, it is, right?’

‘Of course.’ Dan’s voice is warm but distracted. Someone says something in the background, the muffled murmur of an unknown voice. He says something back; I don’t catch the words. Is it a woman? My brain does a quick scan of Dan’s colleagues, arranging them by age and attractiveness.

‘Sorry, Al, I’m wanted.’

‘Oh yeah, going to exhaust the company credit card?’

‘Ha, yeah, something like that.’

‘Right.’ I keep my voice light but my heart hammers. Betrayal, I have discovered, leaves a lingering aftertaste. Bitter and rotten.

‘Love you,’ he says, but is gone before I have a chance to say it back.

I swallow the words, hang up the phone, which immediately starts ringing again. *Mum. No thanks no thanks no thanks.*

‘Mum, hi.’

‘Oh, you *are* there.’

‘It’s a mobile,’ I say for the zillionth time through clenched teeth.

‘You know what I mean,’ she says. ‘But you are home, I take it – it’s dark.’

‘I am allowed out at night, Mum.’

‘Well, in your state and with Dan away, hardly wise.’

‘I’m at home,’ I snap.

‘Well, good.’

‘Yes, what’s up?’

‘Can’t I ring just to say hello?’

‘Of course you can.’ I press my eyes shut, feeling the beginning of a tension headache creeping around my forehead.

‘Well, I was going to see if you needed me to pop in.’

‘When?’

‘Tomorrow lunchtime probably. I’m busy other than that, but with Dan away . . .’

‘I’ve got plans actually,’ I say, feeling a cheap thrill at the words.

‘Oh?’

‘Yes, a friend I made in the park.’

‘Right.’

‘She’s pregnant too, we’re due on the same day.’

‘Unlikely to happen,’ she says with a sort of scoff.

‘Well, whatever.’

‘Oh well, if you’re busy.’

‘I could do the next day.’

‘No, I’m out with Wendy and the girls.’

‘Right then,’ I say. The silence stretches and I use every ounce of mental strength not to say, ‘Oh, don’t worry, I’ll cancel my lunch.’ I can’t anyway as I don’t have Rebecca’s number.

‘Right,’ she says, ‘have a nice lunch then.’

‘I will, thank you.’

I hang up and, in a fit of juvenile rebellion, stick my tongue out at the phone.

I wake up early, my stomach grumbling. I roll over, meaning to get out of bed quietly so as not to disturb Dan, and then I remember – he’s not here. I wait it out, acid and whatever else rolling around the scant space left by the burgeoning child within. I’ve suffered with awful heartburn for weeks now. I read online that it means the baby will have a full head of hair. The pain gets worse, rolling up from the bottom of my bump to the very top. Please, please don’t be contractions. I focus on breathing in and out, my hands clasped around the bottom of my enormous, bulging belly. As I lie there, heart hammering, skin breaking out in a fine, cold sweat, the pain passes, acid washing up my throat. I am, at least, able to get out of bed now. After two cups of unsatisfying decaf coffee I still feel a bit groggy, but definitely better. I manage to clean the house a bit, take in the Tesco’s delivery and throw together a reasonable-looking lasagne and some salad. When the doorbell rings, signalling Rebecca’s arrival, I realise I’m a nervous wreck. For goodness’ sake. I open the door with a smile and there she is, buried behind an enormous, beautiful bunch of flowers.

‘Oh, this is lovely, I love the colours in here.’

‘Thanks.’ My face heats at her compliment. My mother had asked why I’d painted the walls the colour of sludge. But I like the slate grey and had gone for lots of pink to offset it. ‘I did it myself.’

‘No way!’

‘No, really.’ I shrug. ‘It was a wreck when we bought it.’

‘Well, it’s gorgeous now. And what smells so good?’

‘Lasagne.’

‘Oh, so much yes to anything pasta.’

This is the third time we’ve met up. Both of us are so rotund it’s comical, though Rebecca, with her extra height, definitely wears it better.

‘Are you on maternity leave?’ I ask.

She smiles. ‘Actually, no. Promise not to hate me?’

‘Of course.’

‘I haven’t worked a day since I got married.’ She shrugs. ‘I’m a housewife.’

‘Oh.’

‘It makes me sound awfully lazy, doesn’t it?’

‘Not at all, it’s just . . .’

‘Unusual, I know.’ She winces, adjusting herself slightly as she moves, settling onto our white sofa which seems to shrink beneath her girth. ‘As I said, my husband, Joshua, is a barrister.’ Something dull in law is what she’d said. A barrister sounds very impressive. ‘I never really found my thing, so when we got hitched it was an easy decision. Now I suppose I’ll be busy.’

I nod. ‘I suppose you will.’

‘What about you?’

‘I’m in marketing.’

‘Is it fun?’

‘I work for a housing association; we’re a charity so not always fun exactly. Rewarding, I guess.’

‘Wow, that’s so cool.’

I shrug. ‘I like it actually,’ I say, realising it’s true, and that I miss the office already, Joanne who is a good boss, Jeanette our office manager who drives me mad but is actually very sweet. The trio of young women I have mentored into their roles. I even miss dull Damian who takes care of everything financial. ‘Looking at nursery fees, though, I’m not sure I’ll be able to go back to it.’

‘Really?’

‘Really,’ I sigh. ‘I’d hardly be earning anything once they were paid.’

‘Still, if you can do it, it might be good to stay in, if you see what I mean.’

‘Maybe. Dan, my husband, said I should look at retraining.’

‘In what?’

‘Teaching.’ I wrinkle my nose.

She laughs. ‘Not for you?’

‘I mean, I don’t think so. With the little ones, the noise and mess would drive me insane. The teenagers, well. I can’t imagine anything worse, to be honest.’

When I’d started at St Bartholomew’s I’d been young, idealistic and full of hope. I’d seen my own mother as a single parent gain a degree and move us

from housing association accommodation into a house she owned. The one she still lives in today here in Meadsvale.

‘If you like your job,’ Rebecca says, ‘maybe you should try and go back?’

‘It can be stressful,’ I admit. At work, we often seemed to be in dispute with our tenants, and not because we wanted to be, but simply because we didn’t have the funding to meet their needs. We had one building where the lifts were broken ninety per cent of the time. Tenants complained, especially those who had to walk up ten flights of stairs with bags of shopping. The building sat alongside one full of homeowners. *Their* lifts never broke, they had access to a subsidised gym and a direct path to the river. London, the magical city where people from all walks of life had once upon a time rubbed along together, at least on the surface, was openly at war now.

The homeowners who didn’t want other people getting for free what they paid so dearly for. The council and housing association tenants, who were effectively being pushed out of the city, knew this, felt this and resented it. I saw it all from my job and where I had had patience and hope when I started, a decade on, I was jaded and tired. Did I miss it? Not really, not yet anyway, and that in itself made me feel sad. I worked with good people who meant well but our hands were tied, years of austerity and endless cuts had taken their toll and after a pandemic and Brexit, things were only set to get worse.

‘I mean, I do wonder if Dan has a point about me retraining, but teachers are public servants and look how they’re treated. The nights spent standing on our doorsteps banging pots and pans long forgotten and replaced with bitter envy at them for having unions.’ I sigh. ‘Ultimately I just don’t think it’s for me, you know?’

‘Don’t do it then.’ She pats my hand. ‘I’m sure it will work out. Right now, focus on this.’ She points at my belly.

‘You’re right,’ I say, and she is. Tomorrow isn’t here yet. As soon as I sit down the alarm goes for the food. I stand with a groan and Rebecca is there, hand on my arm. ‘Are you okay?’ Her face is screwed up. I force a laugh. ‘Why, do I look awful?’ But actually, the rolling pain of earlier is back and I seem to be simultaneously too hot and too cold.

‘Sit down,’ she says in a voice that brooks no argument. I do, allowing her to pull out the food, plate it up and switch off the oven.

‘I’m so sorry,’ I murmur.

‘Don’t be. Are you alright?’

‘Yes,’ I lie through clenched teeth, not wanting to scare off the first real friend I’ve had since . . . well, Izzy. ‘Honestly, you know how it is.’

She sighs. ‘I do, I really do. The end of pregnancy is genuinely ridiculous. Eat, you’ll feel better.’

I manage a few mouthfuls, chewing slowly while my insides feel like hot soup sloshing around. I stand to clear the table and the room spins.

‘Sit,’ she says again, taking over, clearing plates, wiping the side and bringing me a glass of water. ‘Here.’

‘I’m so sorry,’ I repeat, panic building now.

‘You look very pale.’

‘I’m probably tired. I didn’t sleep well, with Dan being away.’

‘Ali?’

Everything sort of blurs. I go to stand and feel a wetness between my legs. Rebecca looks at me open-mouthed. ‘Shit.’ It’s so comical I almost laugh, but I look down and see blood pooling on my wide grey maternity skirt. ‘Oh my God.’

She piles me into the back seat of her car. I sit on a plastic bag, pads that I’d bought for afterwards nestled between my legs, panic making my heart race and my palms sweat. ‘I’m sorry,’ I say for the millionth time.

‘Stop,’ she says. ‘I’m just glad I was here. They said an ambulance might be a few hours.’

‘Yes,’ I say, as another spasm of pain tightens my stomach. I grip the headrest in front of me, my hands clenching on butter-soft leather. ‘Oh God, your car,’ I say, looking at it, realising that this is a far cry from the shit tin I drive.

‘It doesn’t matter,’ she says.

It probably only takes us fifteen minutes but time seems to slip and slide. She leaves me for a moment, car door open, then there is someone in a uniform helping me into a wheelchair and Rebecca tells me she’ll park and come in.

By the time she does, I’m in a cubicle with a smiling, calm nurse who pats my hand and measures various things.

Rebecca sits next to me and says, ‘Times like this I wish I still smoked.’ And I manage a chuckle I didn’t think I was capable of.

‘So,’ I say to the nurse, ‘is the baby coming?’

‘Not yet, no, but I would say soon.’

‘Soon today?’

‘No. In the next week, I reckon.’

‘Is it . . . okay?’ I ask the question, realising now that I am scared of the answer. I feel warm fingers grasping mine. I turn to Rebecca and smile in gratitude.

‘I think so, yes. We’ll keep you in overnight and keep an eye, but the scan looks fine, baby looks well, your vitals are alright.’

‘Then what was . . . you know?’

‘Probably your mucus plug dislodging, but these aren’t contractions. Just a warm-up.’

‘Jesus,’ I say, finding it hard to imagine that these are pre-pains rather than labour pains.

‘Do you want to call Dad?’ the nurse asks.

‘Yes.’ I pause, thinking about his fussing. ‘Actually, no, he’s miles away and not due back until tomorrow afternoon.’

The nurse frowns. ‘Still . . .’

‘But there’s no point worrying him, is there? If he can’t do anything.’

‘Well . . .’

‘She said she doesn’t want to,’ Rebecca says, voice firm, ‘thank you.’ Smile sweet but dismissive as she turns away from the woman and faces me. The nurse goes, frown still in place.

‘I *will* tell him,’ I say quickly.

Rebecca waves a hand. ‘You’re quite right, if he’s not going to make it back right now anyway.’

‘Thanks,’ I say, adding, ‘He worries, and he can’t do anything, which will make him worry more.’

‘Anyone else I should call?’

‘My mum,’ I say with a sigh.

‘You don’t sound keen?’

‘No, well. She’ll find a way to blame me.’

‘Shit, that bad?’

Her profanity makes me smile despite the situation. ‘Yeah, she can’t always help it, I think. Mums, you know.’

‘Yeah. Well, no, actually, my dad raised me but we had our moments. Parents, I guess. Let’s hope we do better. And let’s leave it with your mum then.’

‘Sorry about lunch.’

‘You have nothing to be sorry about.’

‘I’m so grateful, Rebecca, that you brought me here, but if you need to get on, I’ll be okay,’ I say, not knowing if I mean it but also wanting to give her a way out.

‘I’ve got nothing on. And I’m hardly going to leave you here on your own with Nurse Misery.’

‘Thanks,’ I manage, tears springing to my eyes.

‘Hey. It’s fine.’ She squeezes my hand again.

‘So, on the topic of parents, let’s discuss things we won’t do to our babies. I’ll go first – I will not make them eat vegetables they hate. You go.’

‘Um . . . I will not criticise their appearance. Even if, in retrospect, getting a pixie cut in my teen years definitely was the wrong choice.’

‘Ha! I will not make them equate good grades with happiness. And I will not favour their sibling.’

Rebecca blinks, considering this. ‘Will you have more, do you think?’ she asks.

‘I don’t know. I mean, we probably can’t afford it, but then I worry about an only child being spoilt, you know?’

‘I’m an only.’ She grins.

‘God, sorry.’

She’s laughing. ‘Don’t be, and honestly, I *was* spoiled rotten.’

‘But you turned out alright.’

‘I like to think so. You have siblings then?’

‘One. A brother, Nick.’

‘You’re close?’

‘Not exactly. We get along okay.’

‘But your mother favours him?’

‘Yeah,’ I admit.

‘Maybe being an only makes that easier.’

‘You might have a point there.’

There are a few beats of silence which, I realise, again are not uncomfortable.

‘Where was your mum?’ I ask her.

‘She died, when I was little.’

‘Oh wow, that’s . . . I’m so sorry.’

‘Yeah, pretty crappy, right? Where was your dad?’

‘Sowing his wild oats, according to my mum.’

‘Yuck.’

‘Yeah, just what every child loves to hear.’

‘I feel like ignorance would definitely be bliss in that scenario.’

‘What about your dad?’ I ask her.

‘I’m amazed he managed to produce me, I’ve rarely seen him without a shirt and tie.’

‘Hopefully your mum did,’ I say, and we both break into giggles.

The day passes, various people come in and poke and prod me. Dan texts saying things are hectic but how was lunch? I manage *Fine* with a smiley face, feeling awful but determined not to worry him. It’s a white lie, a good lie, if there is such a thing. Evening creeps in, Rebecca is told to go home. I overhear her outside the paper-thin curtain. ‘You are?’ the doctor asks.

‘Rebecca Dalston.’

‘And your relationship to Mrs Cooper?’

‘She’s my friend.’

‘And you’re sure you’re fine to collect her tomorrow?’

‘Yes, of course.’

She comes back in, hitching her beautiful burgundy bag, which I suspect is a real Mulberry, over her shoulder. ‘I’m getting the boot.’

‘Thanks for everything,’ I say and then, ‘My mum could collect me. In the morning.’

‘Yeah, but she sounds like a bit of a nightmare.’

I grimace. ‘She is.’

‘I’ll come then,’ she says, standing and squeezing my shoulder.

‘Thank you,’ I say again.

‘Of course. What are friends for?’

When Dan finds out he is beside himself, with fear, worry, guilt. I realise fairly soon that I probably should have told him. I say I'm sorry a million times but he won't hear it, '*I'm* sorry, Ali, I should have been here.'

'There's nothing you could have done,' I say, which is true.

'But it could have been the baby coming.'

'It wasn't though and, even if it was, you wouldn't have made it back in time. I didn't want to freak you out.'

'Yeah, I guess. I appreciate that.' He chews his lip and I know he's just being nice. I'd known as soon as I told him, how badly I'd messed up. How I might have felt if he'd kept something so big from me. Doesn't matter if my intentions were good, the only defence I have is that I was super stressed--out and not thinking clearly.

'I should have told you,' I say, my voice small. It's Monday, his fifth day at home and the billionth time we've had this conversation, with him reiterating that he is in this with me, that we are a team and he should be treated like he's part of it. His initial anger has turned to worry and it's starting to make me anxious. He's not left the house since he got back, barely leaving my side and pre-empting my every need no matter how minor. He is, I think, treating me like spun glass.

'I understand why you didn't call.'

'Do you?'

'Yes, of course. But you still should have and straight away.'

'And I will if anything like that happens again, okay?'

'Okay.'

'Lucky that Rebecca was here.'

'Yeah, it really was.' He reaches out, squeezes my hand. I'm upstairs in our bedroom, flicking through the nothingness that is daytime TV and scrolling on my phone. He has taken over our tiny downstairs and all day his voice and his colleagues' voices waft upstairs, tinny through his laptop.

‘I don’t need to go back into the office this week.’

‘Okay, brilliant,’ I manage, forcing a smile. Not wanting to tell him that his newfound ramped-up anxiety is seeping into me like a migraine taking root.

His face softens. ‘I’m probably driving you mad, aren’t I?’

I laugh. ‘Not at all.’ Though I can’t help thinking that, actually, Rebecca with her calm, firm voice and unruffled exterior had been exactly what I needed and this suffocating concern was exactly why I’d not rung straight away.

‘We still on for dinner tomorrow evening?’

He frowns. ‘Are you well enough?’

‘To eat?’

‘To go out.’

‘Well, you can drive.’ I smile. ‘It will be good to get out. I booked a restaurant Rebecca recommended.’

‘Okay, cool.’ He smiles his soft smile and his phone buzzes. ‘Shit, meeting.’

‘Go,’ I say.

He leaves the room and I resist sighing with relief.

My phone pings, I grab it and find myself looking at a picture of an extremely swollen ankle captioned *The glamour never ends!*

Lol, I type back.

Did daytime TV get any better?

Nope. There’s only so much Escape to the Country I can stomach.

Sounds dire.

Do your ankles hurt? I ask her.

Yes, and my pelvis when I walk. It’s grim!

Can’t believe people do this more than once.

Me neither, has it put you off the sibling thing yet?

Has a bit, yeah. My poor body might combust a second time round.

Lol. Has Dan calmed down? I feel guilty for a moment, at having shared my frustration with Dan with someone I’ve met a handful of times. But I feel like I know Rebecca. Like I can trust her.

Yeah. I feel bad though.

Your intentions were good.

Still. I can see his point.

Just spoil him rotten for a few days. Bake a cake?

Shit at all things baking.

Buy one then?

Good plan.

Cake always is!

My phone rings. Mum. I leave it, leave it, leave it . . .

‘Mum, hi.’

‘Oh, you *are* talking to me then?’

‘Dan said he’d spoken to you. I haven’t been feeling great.’

‘Hospital, he said, you were bleeding?’

‘Yes.’

‘But everything is okay?’

‘Yes, I think so. They said the baby will probably come soon.’

‘Good.’ I wait for a barbed comment to follow but nothing comes.

I say, ‘Sorry I didn’t . . .’ at the same time she starts talking. We both laugh. ‘You go,’ I say.

‘Just, you know, if you need anything. I don’t like to drive but I would, if you or the baby needed me.’

‘Oh.’ Tears spring into my eyes and I blink. It must be hormones; I’m a bloody mess at the moment. Anything can set me off, I cried at *EastEnders* last night. ‘Thanks, Mum.’

A silence. She sort of coughs then says, ‘Oh, I saw Martha Jenkins the other day.’ Just the mention of their surname makes me feel queasy. The baby shifts and I adjust myself on the bed. ‘Oh, did you?’

‘Yes. She said Izzy’s doing marvellously.’

‘Oh really?’ My mum had been adamant that all the Max stuff would eventually blow over and Izzy and I would be friends again. It had never happened and I knew it never would.

‘Yes, in the process of setting up her own business.’

‘Great.’ I manage the word, though it feels like a lump of vomit stuck in my throat.

‘She always was a go-getter.’

‘Mmmhmmm.’

‘She asked after you.’

‘Did she?’ Heart thud thud thud.

‘Yes, I said you hadn’t exactly set the world on fire work-wise but were expecting my first grandchild any day now.’

‘Right.’ *Hadn’t exactly set the world on fire.* Her momentary kindness of

earlier fades away. I find I'm almost holding my breath waiting for her to mention Max.

Her voice goes muffled for a moment. 'Sorry, Alison, I need to dash.'

'Cool.'

'I'll pop over at the weekend.'

'Brilliant,' I say, already dreading it.

'Maybe I'll bring Nick, if he's free.'

'Even better.'

I hang up, the lunchtime news droning on in the background, and open Instagram. I switch from my own profile to my randomly named one and go to her profile. Izzy Jenkins. No updated stories. The last time had been over a week ago, a picture of her and Max at the top of the Oxo tower, champagne flutes held aloft. His hand resting on her tiny waist. Triumph dripping from every aspect of the image. She has updated her grid. I click on the post.

'I've had the best time @hazePR but it's on to pastures new! Me and my #workwife @bronwyn99 will be starting our own venture and are delighted to be continuing to work with key accounts who we have special relationships with – watch this space for more news soon about @IBdynamics.' Above the caption is a picture of Izzy and another woman with dark, perfectly layered hair and brilliant white teeth. Both of them are beaming.

Work wife. It's such a stupid expression, isn't it? Izzy has been at Haze since she graduated. Starting as an unpaid intern, as only the well financially supported can, and rising fast to a key account manager. I wonder if Bronwyn has been there that long too. I imagine them both buzzing round London, being effortlessly beautiful and having a fabulous time. I hurl the phone onto the bed and pick up the TV remote, giving in to Netflix.

Rizzo's is a bit of a drive and, of course, in a much better part of town than where we live. The kind of little enclave you'd have no reason to visit unless you were local. I look at the houses as we pass through – beautiful, sprawling buildings, some with gates and long drives. Lushly green trees, that I imagine blossom with gorgeous pinks in the spring, line the streets. This is where Rebecca lives and I drink it all in hungrily. Dan keeps glancing at me, so I make myself smile and say, 'I'm fine, really.'

He smiles back but it's forced. He's probably shattered himself. I reach across, squeeze his knee and say, 'It's good to be out.' Ready to put the week's bickering's behind us and hoping he is too.

'It is, and nice round here, eh?'

'Yes.'

'Whatever her husband does pays well,' says Dan cheerfully.

'Obviously,' I say, trying not to be jealous. In my job, I know exactly how lucky I am to have a roof over my head, let alone one we own. But I'd be lying if I said I wasn't envious of these big houses, waiting and ready to be filled with children who will have the best of everything. People like to say money can't make you happy, but poverty pretty much guarantees misery. After my parents split up, Mum worried over every penny. I can still see her pale, strained face hunched over stacks of bills, a stark contrast to my super-wealthy best friend, Izzy, who was only at the same crappy comp as me because her parents were champagne socialists. I think of her business now, her triumphant smile. 'Bronwen99', her work wife. Urgh.

'Rebecca said Rizzo's is reasonably priced though,' I tell him, wondering why she treks halfway across the borough to walk in my local park. We pass plenty of green spaces here. Most, I'm sure, are far superior, though I'll admit ours is not too shabby and part of the reason we'd chosen our little cottage.

'I'm sure it will be lovely.'

And it is. A small, intimate restaurant run by an Italian man with slick--backed hair and a broad smile. I tell him, 'My friend Rebecca Dalston recommended this place.' Delighting in the word 'friend'.

'So kind,' he says, adding, 'I haven't seen her for a very long time.'

'Maybe she's not getting out as much,' I say with a smile.

'Oh?' A woman comes over and speaks to him in Italian before I have a chance to respond. He frowns at her, then smiling again now, says to us, 'Please excuse me, I'll send your waiter right over, and do say hello to Rebecca. Tell her Antonio hopes to see her again soon.'

The food *is* lovely, and not too pricey. The conversation is easy; we both relax for once. Dan doing impressions of his boss, making me laugh so hard, I struggle to eat.

He reaches across the table, takes my hand, squeezes it. 'It's good to see you laugh.'

'Haven't I laughed much recently?' But I know the answer. Of course I haven't. With each passing day, week, month, the reality of this, the permanence of it, has almost floored me, this past week in particular where the stern-faced nurse's words whizz around my mind: 'The baby will come any day now.' Everything, all of it – impending motherhood, my much-loved job that I may not be able to afford to return to anyway, Izzy's shiny, Insta--perfect life. Worrying about what kind of mother I will be has of course thrown up memories of my own childhood. A time when my mum was hurt and raw from an unexpected divorce, while my dad moved on quickly enough for her to know an affair had been involved. It's not a unique story, of course, and Nick seemed to grow up mostly unfazed by it all, but I had tuned in to my mother's concerns, her stresses. Anxiety is second nature to me now, and I often find myself felled by a kind of undefined panic. I'm usually good at hiding it, but recently the mask has been slipping.

'I've been worried about you, and I feel like I'm not around nearly as much as I should be.'

'It's not your fault,' I say automatically, because it's not. In an ideal world, I'd have a tribe, a crew, a loving family populated by women keen to share their experiences and guide me. In an ideal world, Izzy and I would have been there for each other, the way we'd always said we would be in what seems like a different life. I push the thought away.

I'd really thought when I met steady, safe, reliable Dan, that he'd be all I needed. That when I fell pregnant, my own little family would complete

me, and maybe it will, but pregnancy has also brought up new things to worry about. Things I hadn't even considered. I brighten up. 'At least I'll have Rebecca to hang out with, I suppose it might make rhyme-time easier.'

He frowns. 'What the hell is rhyme-time?'

I giggle again and tell him 'I think we sing or say rhymes, to the babies.' We finish the pizza, eat dessert and leave, hands pressed together and smiles all round, the summer air far less awful now at 10 p.m. than it is during the day.

At home in bed, he reads aloud to me from one of the books, this one a wretched thing about 'getting baby on a routine'. He stops mid-sentence and says, 'I think we might be better off without some of these.'

'I couldn't agree more.'

He rolls over, propped up on his elbows, studying my face. 'Ali, I've been driving you mad, haven't I?'

'Well . . .' I manage.

'I so want everything to be . . . well . . . good. I want us to be prepared.'

I sigh. 'I'm not sure you can really prepare for this sort of thing.'

'You're right,' he says. 'Of course you are.'

I think about it long after he is asleep and after I've got out of bed and sat myself on the sofa, watching as the thin, pretty pink morning light starts to peek in behind the blinds. I had felt prepared; I had felt ready. When Dan asked me to marry him, I'd thought, everything will be okay now. When I'd found out I was pregnant I'd figured, people do this all the time. As my body grew and my life started to change it had all begun to feel different, scary, the baby a looming thing I couldn't imagine. I squeeze my eyes shut and try to focus on my breathing – inhale, 1 . . . 2 . . . 3 . . . 4; exhale, 1 . . . 2 . . . 3 . . . 4 – and I must fall asleep eventually, because I am woken by an awful tearing pain.

The pain comes in waves. Cramps that build hard and fast to an unbearable crescendo. We are at home and I am in the throes of it, for what could be minutes or hours. I slip in and out of myself, time shuddering around me. A slippery, unreal thing that moves slowly and fast, remaining just out of reach. Dan has several muted telephone conversations, sitting next to me as I writhe, first on our freshly made bed, then on the floor, his eyes flicking from me to his wristwatch, mouth moving as he counts minutes which seem get shorter and shorter.

Finally, he says, 'We are ready to go. The contractions are getting closer together.'

In the car, the small suburb rushes past, a glimmer of lights and empty roads. We have no problem parking at the hospital, no problem getting in. Someone makes a joke about choosing the right time to have the baby; I don't laugh.

A midwife pops in and out, young and smiley. I am having the baby; terror hits me in one of the few moments between agony. We are left in a waiting room. Me panting, my head thrumming with fear every time the pain abates and the thoughts force their way in. Dan is murmuring words I can't keep up with. The pain increases, I lose time again. I have a disjointed feeling of having been one place, the waiting room, and now being somewhere new. I am on a bed, in the delivery room. A place I have visited in daylight hours, a quick tour full of reassuring smiles. It seems like somewhere else entirely now. The midwife changes. The murmuring voices around me get louder, faster. They sound worried. I fall into a sort of fitful sleep and wake up hearing Dan: 'She must be exhausted.'

I am. I am so exhausted and it is *so* hot in here. Daylight seeps in, someone injects me with something, a mask is pressed to my face and I inhale; grateful, relieved. But the injection slows things even more.

I sleep again, waking to a darkened room, fresh pain and the first midwife

back again, smiling. ‘Are you still here?’

She and Dan exchange smiles. I hate them both.

The injection wears off. ‘One last try,’ she says to me, ‘before we’ll need to intervene.’ *Intervene*. I think of Rebecca, sighing as she wondered whether a Caesarean would be best. Yes, I want to tell her, do not do this. No one should ever do this. Though it is too late now and I don’t want last-minute panicked surgery. One last go, I muster all my strength and do as I’m told, breathe, move onto all fours. *Focus*. As if I have room for anything other than . . . this.

Time melts again, the world around me blurs, I feel like I exist only in this single space. This hospital room, with people wafting in and out, the strong smell of bleach stinging my nose, my husband’s concerned face grimacing as I grab at him, his hand, his shirt. My body soaked, liquid pouring down my thighs. An unspeakable, awful agony like someone has lit a match and dropped it between my legs. A wet sound, then a squawking like I imagine a baby pterodactyl would have sounded once upon a time. Millennia ago. Am I dead? I wonder and maybe ask my husband. But Dan sort of laughs, tears streaking down his face. Something is pressed from him to me. A wet greasy feel on my chest and a nuzzling at my breast. A sharp pain, but small, nothing like what I have just been through. Nothing I can’t handle, though I want it to stop. I want to shut my eyes and sleep for a hundred years. Instead, I look down at a small head, fuzzy hair.

‘Ah, she’s hungry.’

She.

‘A girl?’ It comes out thick, my voice raspy, throat dry, the word scraping like glass from my chest and outward.

‘A girl.’ Dan nodding, eyes glistening. ‘Our beautiful daughter.’

Daughter.

The word presses in on me. Nausea pushes up from my sore gut, pain still burning down there, registering anew. The sharp pull of her at my breast. I sleep again, or pass out. When I wake, it is dark. I am alone in a single bed with metal bars at its sides. I roll over and alongside me in a cot is a tiny, teeny little person wrapped tight in a yellow blanket that we had ordered from Amazon in what feels like a different life. I squeeze my eyes shut. I don’t properly remember leaving home. Don’t remember picking up the bag we’d packed so carefully. Sounds float around me, other women murmuring. Babies, one whimpering. I open my eyes and staring back at me is her.

A small, tiny girl. In the dim light her eyes look black and I feel a shudder of fear, before she starts screaming her head off.

‘Your mum and Nick are here,’ Dan tells me. His eyes are glued firmly on the baby. ‘God, isn’t she gorgeous?’ he says for the millionth time. I nod, but I don’t know if she’s gorgeous exactly. She’s incredibly loud for such a small person; every time she squawks, milk leaks out of me and I feel a spike of adrenaline-laden anxiety.

‘Do they have to come in now?’ I ask, hearing a faint note of panic in my voice.

Dan smiles. ‘It’s her first grandchild.’

I sigh, nodding. ‘And we’ll be going home later?’

‘Yes, they just have to do a few last checks.’

‘When?’ I add, ‘It’s so hot in here.’ It is. The heat is made worse by the low-grade fever I’ve had for the past day. ‘Nothing to worry about,’ the midwife had said as though adjusting to weakness would be my new normal, which, I suppose at least for the next few days, it will. Dan helps me plump pillows and sit up. I wince as pain registers down below. ‘All right?’ he asks and I nod even though I am not.

‘Okay, I’ll get them.’

I take deep breaths after he’s gone. The baby makes a snuffling sound. I glance at her. Sleeping soundly, she has dozed on and off all night, waking up several times to be fed, once with a full nappy. I’d had to call the midwife for help and she’d laughed. ‘Do you not know how to change her?’

‘I’ve never had a baby before,’ I’d snapped, my incompetence feeling like a new burden. I couldn’t even wipe the thick, gloopy shit off of my daughter’s arse. How the hell was I going to manage once we were home? Worse still, once Dan went back to work. I push the thought away, re-focusing my mind on the face peeking around the curtain. My mother, eyes searching round, settling on the baby.

She comes in, followed by my brother who leans over Mum as they both peer down at her.

‘Fucking hell, sis,’ says Nick and that actually raises a smile.

‘She’s lovely.’ My mum’s voice is thick with emotion. I look at her in surprise. She catches my eye, smiles, leans over and squeezes my hand. ‘Well done, you.’

I blink back tears, her unexpected kindness too much.

Dan comes in, the baby wakes, the faint murmur followed by a bellowing yell and a loud fart.

Everyone laughs. My mum says to me, 'May I?' gesturing at the baby.

'Of course,' I say. Relieved not to have to hold her. Relieved too that it was gas rather than hunger that woke her. I feel the pads on my chest fill with milk nonetheless, my breasts heavy and sore.

My mum is in the only chair with the baby clasped to her. 'Shh,' she coos, though the child isn't making any noise. Seemingly content there in my mother's arms. She must have held me like that once. I can't imagine it. We are not a tactile family. Bar the odd awkward hug, we hardly touch each other.

'She looks like you,' says Nick, frowning in concentration as he peers down at her.

'Do you think?' I ask, thinking what a stupid thing it is to say. She looks like anyone, with her pink wrinkled skin and dark small eyes; she hardly looks real to me.

'Yeah, you had fuzzy hair like that.'

'Did I?' I find I'm genuinely curious.

'You did,' Mum says now. 'She is very like you, Alison, you were also a beautiful baby.' She says this with a happy smile and I smile back, waiting for a jibe that never comes.

I feel something then, a pull towards the baby girl, a glimmer of hope that I may be up to this after all. 'Thanks, Mum,' I whisper.

Our home is under siege. I'd said that to Dan last night and he'd laughed. But he, of course, cannot feed her. He wakes up in the night with me but within seconds he'll be asleep again, snoring softly, not a care in the world, while I sit for hour-long feeds with our tiny, squawking, as-yet-unnamed daughter clutched to me. At three in the morning I scroll through the images on my phone, picking one where she looks quite sweet. I send it to Rebecca with a cute heart face emoji.

I go back to sleep in the spare room where me and the baby spend fitful nights that drift into cranky days. When I wake up, well before I am ready, Rebecca has messaged back. *OMFG. Congratulations, she is scrumptious.*

You soon! I say; she sends back a shocked face. I want to see her. Want to say to her, birth was awful please come and visit. But, I also don't want to terrify her. Though she'd mentioned private healthcare, an elective C-section. Easier perhaps? Probably shorter than the almost twenty-four hours it took me to bring a baby into the world.

Instead, I manage, *Coffee soon?*

Defo, can't wait to meet her and see you.

'What about Joni?' Dan says to me now, breaking into my thoughts. I scowl at him. 'Like Joni Mitchell,' he adds.

'No, it sounds old-fashioned.'

He sighs. 'We have to call her something.'

'Charlie?' I suggest.

He grins. 'Charlie, short for Charlotte?'

'I guess,' I say. When I was a teenager, after Dad announced that he was moving abroad for a bit, Mum got a rescue cat in an attempt, I suspect, to cheer me up. She was called Charlie. A skinny black thing with a too-long tail. She wasn't a kitten but a half-feral rescue. She had a reputation for viciousness and would often swipe at Mum and Nick. She never went for me though. She used to spend most of her time curled up on my bed on top of a

large piece of soft, lilac lace I'd bought for a sewing project I never got round to. For some reason, she liked the material. It softened over the years and eventually disintegrated, long after Charlie was gone and just as I was leaving for university, vowing to never return to that house. Little did I know then that I'd be back again in no time at all.

'Charlie,' Dan says again, looking at her. 'Yes, it suits her.'

And it does. Charlie, my daughter.

Today, we have a visit from the community midwife. I am on a strict diet of codeine and paracetamol, which has kept the pain just far enough out of reach that it hasn't consumed me, and I'm also on antibiotics to avoid infection. The doctor at the hospital was keen to tell me that I'd had an 'almost perfect, trouble-free birth'.

I hate to imagine what a troubled delivery might look like. The aftermath of this has left me sore, feverish and frightened to sit for too long or go to the toilet. Add to that the waking up every two hours to feed my ravenous child and I am like the walking dead.

I wake with a start to the doorbell ringing and realise that I've fallen asleep sitting upright on the sofa, the baby, Charlie, at my feet in her little basket. My eyes flick fearfully to her but she remains sleeping for now. I'm trying to stand up when Dan says, 'I'll get it.'

A few seconds later he's back in the living room with a smiling, round-faced midwife who says, 'Hello, Mummy.' As though I no longer have a name of my own. I try for a smile back which quickly becomes a wince and she says, 'Still a little sore?' with a sympathetic head tilt.

I nod. Dan says, 'Tea?' looking from one of us to the other.

'Not for me,' she says. I shake my head.

The midwife says, 'I need to check your wife, could we leave you here with the little one?'

'Of course.'

To me, 'I'll need you lying down, shall we go to your bedroom?'

I walk up the small stairs stiffly, her behind me. Our bedroom looks like a bomb was detonated in it and I murmur, 'Sorry about the mess,' moving aside milk-sodden muslin cloths and stacks of nappies.

She makes a tutting sound and says, 'No need to apologise. The early days aren't easy.'

To which I respond by feeling ridiculously grateful that she said it out

loud.

‘Onto the bed and bottoms off,’ she says, not unkindly, though it is the last thing I want to do right now. I manage to lie back, eyes squeezed shut, while she peers at the mess between my legs, cold fingers prodding the area. ‘Do you feel tender?’ she asks.

‘Yes.’ The word escapes through clenched teeth on a gasp.

‘Have you managed to go to the toilet yet?’

I shake my head.

She makes that tutting sound again. ‘Not easy, but it will be better once you have. I’ll leave you some fibre sachets which will help. All done.’ She pats my knee. I dress, she washes her hands. ‘How is your mood?’ she asks as she comes back in.

‘What do you mean?’

‘We check anyway with all new mothers, but I see you have a history of depression.’

I laugh but it catches. ‘History is probably a stretch.’

‘You were on antidepressants for almost a year, according to your records.’

I swallow, remembering that time when all I wanted was to feel nothing, when I’d clutched at that prescription like it might save my life. It hadn’t even touched the sides. ‘I had a difficult year,’ I say, thoughts of Max and Izzy springing to the forefront of my mind. I blink as if I can unsee the past. As if I can ever forget.

‘I’m sorry to hear that,’ she says and sounds like she means it.

I nod, not wanting this conversation. ‘I’m fine now,’ I manage.

‘Good, but do go easy on yourself, a new baby is always an adjustment. Especially when it’s your first.’

First? I cannot imagine putting myself through the horror of childbirth a second time. I am baffled by the women who claim to have forgotten the pain as soon as they held their child. My body feels like one large bruise and the entire thing is so firmly etched in my mind I don’t think I’ll ever forget it.

‘Right, shall we go weigh baby and give her a look over?’

‘Sure.’

I send Rebecca a screenshot of Charlie at 3 a.m. while I'm up feeding her for what feels like the millionth time. I don't expect a response but my phone pings. *She's proper cute!*

Thanks – why are you up?

Couldn't sleep – endless weeing. With a facepalm face which makes me smile. *Are you up for a call?* she says.

Yes, I type back immediately, closing the lid on my laptop, pleased to see Izzy and Max's smug faces disappear.

'Hey,' I say.

'Is she asleep?'

'Almost.'

'What's she doing?'

'Looking at me. Well, I think she is, though apparently she can't see from the crib to where I'm sitting.'

'That's wild. And a bit creepy.'

I smother a whispered laugh, aware of Dan sleeping just metres away in our tiny house.

'It is,' I say, smiling.

'So how many times does she get up?'

'Like three, maybe four.'

'That's not too bad?'

'Well no, but it can take her an hour to feed.'

'You're breastfeeding?'

'Yes.'

'I don't think I will.'

'Really?'

'Yeah, I don't fancy it.' Just like that. I hadn't even considered whether I fancied it or not; the midwife had said, 'Breast is best' and that was that.

'It's actually quite difficult,' I admit. 'Like, I figured it would be easy,

nature's way and all that.'

Rebecca makes a scoffing sound. 'Nature is fine for looking at from a window on holiday.'

I do another smothered laugh. 'Rebecca!'

'Well, we've upgraded lots of natural things, haven't we? Like, if nature's so great, why build houses?'

'You've got a point. Which leads me on to childbirth.'

'It's awful, isn't it?'

'Terrible.'

'I've elected for a Caesarean, two days before our actual due date.' Charlie had been almost three weeks early.

'I wish I had.'

'If you ever do it again . . .'

'Can't see that happening.'

'Fair enough. One child is plenty, isn't it?'

'I think so, the health visitor said I might change my mind though.'

'I hope you told her to sod off!'

I laugh. But I hadn't, of course. I'd smiled politely, wanting her to leave and not bring up antidepressants again.

'Are you swamped with visitors?'

'My mum and brother. Dan's parents live abroad.'

'Are your friends all having babies?'

'No,' I say. Then add, 'Actually, I don't have many and I fell out with my best friend a few years ago,' wondering whether that comes across as me being a right sad case.

'That's shit,' she says simply, and I find myself nodding. Charlie's eyes are closed now, her soft baby breaths lengthening.

'She slept with my boyfriend.'

'What a bitch.'

'I mean, they're still together, they were probably more suited to each other, looking back and, you know, Dan's great.'

'Still, I'd have been livid, and fucking heartbroken.'

'I was,' I say, my voice small.

'With friends like that, Ali.'

'I know, right? I haven't been close to anyone since, to be honest. I mean until you.' Cringing as soon as the words are out. I must sound so needy.

'And I'm not a bitch. I mean, not like that anyway,' she says, seemingly

unfazed, which makes me feel relieved and warm inside. Close, I'd said, and she hadn't disagreed.

'I know.' And even though I've only known her a matter of weeks really, I feel like I do.

A silence, but not uncomfortable. 'What's she doing now?'

'Sleeping. Do you want to see her?'

'Yes!'

I switch the call to video and turn it on Charlie, her perfect little cupid's bow mouth huffing and puffing slowly, eyelashes fanned over her cheeks.

I hold the phone there for a minute then turn it to me. Rebecca is wide-eyed. 'Wow, Ali. She is bloody beautiful.'

'Thanks.' We say goodnight and I hang up the call brimming with happiness. My circle of friends is non-existent, I miss work terribly and Izzy's absence stings more than ever right now. Once upon a time we'd hit every milestone together and this was one I'd thought we'd do side by side. But if she ever does go for motherhood, it will be with Max. I push that thought away. It doesn't matter any more. Charlie has met Mum, Nick and seen health visitors and midwives, but showing her to Rebecca feels like sharing something precious, the seeds sown over long walks and shared experiences growing into a true friendship.

‘I just think it’s weird that she hasn’t messaged back,’ I say, stifling a yawn.

Dan smiles at me, head leant to one side. ‘You’re exhausted,’ he says kindly. It bugs me. Talk about stating the bleeding obvious.

‘Of course I’m exhausted, I spend most of every night and day as a living milk machine.’

He leans down, kisses me gently on the top of my head, leaning back to do his tie, looking at me with intense scrutiny. ‘It’s great that you’re feeding her yourself, Ali. I’m so proud of you.’

I nod, blinking away tears. Unable to say that rather than his pride, what I really want is for him to tell me to stop. Or better still, I wish that I could be more like Rebecca and tell him and everyone else I wasn’t going to breast-feed because, actually, I just didn’t fancy it. In this momentary fantasy, Dan would then respond by jumping in the car, heading to Tesco’s, stocking up on formula and doing several nights in a row where I can sleep. Sleep is the new fantasy, I realise. I’ve had bouts of insomnia before. After Max left me with a shrug and a weak apology, heading off into my so-called best friend’s arms, I’d felt his absence like a physical thing. Walking around the bedroom in my rented student house where he’d spent almost every single night, wondering what I’d do now. What I’d do without him. That dread had worsened when I was hit with the far more awful thought: what would I do without *her*? My best friend since infant school, the girl who knew me inside out, who I loved, admired, who I did everything with until I didn’t. I’d thought then that I’d had it bad as I lay wide awake, my smashed heart beating in the dark, the pain of both betrayals biting at me like a kitten nipping at my ankles. But by the third or fourth night, I’d sleep, exhaustion taking over, plunging me into rest. Then a prescription for heartache that knocked me out more than I needed.

Now there is no rest.

My mother had told me to ‘try and nap in the day when she does’. In a

snappy, heated exchange where she'd reminded me that my dad hadn't lifted a finger, that she had been on her own with me and five-year-old Nick to see to at the same time.

I have tried to take that advice though. I've lain next to Charlie whilst she snuffles in her crib, me under a blanket, my muscles aching with numbing fatigue. My head racing at a hundred miles an hour. The first week and a bit was fine, in large part due to Rebecca. She'd call when I needed it most, make me laugh when I didn't think it was possible. I moaned about my mum, Dan, my shitty ex-best friend. I realise now we speak mainly about me, rarely about her. Have I put her off? Was I being self-obsessed? I try to tell myself there's a very good reason she hasn't been replying to my texts the past few days: she's probably having a baby! The date for her Caesarean has been and gone. But I can't help worrying and worrying, my mind spinning at 2, 3 a.m. If I have drifted off, it's been far too late, far too close to the bellows of my small but dominant daughter demanding her next feed.

'Our due date is past now,' I say to Dan, trying to make him listen, to understand.

'Well then, she's probably in hospital, Al. Think about it, she was messaging you back until, what – a few days ago?'

'Nearly a week, Dan,' I say, adding, 'and calling. *She* called *me* mostly. She read a message two days ago in the morning. The others haven't got two ticks. I don't think they've even delivered.'

'See?' he says. 'She's in the hospital, you said the signal was patchy, didn't you?'

'She's in a private hospital.'

He smiles. 'Maybe they force her to turn off her phone and get some rest. I bet they keep women in for longer too.'

I nod, that makes sense. 'You're probably right.' I manage to smile.

He's picking up his briefcase. 'You sure you don't want your mum to come over?'

'And babysit me?'

'And keep you company. It's a big thing, Al, your first day alone.'

I force a chuckle. 'I'm not alone,' I say, and realise the words land like a faint threat.

When he's gone, I feel an immediate rise of panic. As if sensing it, Charlie wakes up, not with bellows this time but a sort of soft, easy coming to. I

watch her, she stares back or, more realistically, looks in my general direction.

‘It’s just you and me,’ I tell her.

I make coffee, take a photo and send it to Rebecca captioned *Still on the decaf!* I watch and watch, checking precisely every two seconds. They’re still unread but my messages have now delivered. Charlie’s noise increases, I feed her, change her, put her in her swing. It’s a stupid thing that Mum had bought for us that I’d almost sent her away with. It’s big, ugly and makes an irritating whooshing sound. It is also, so far, the only way I can get Charlie to sleep in the daytime. Once she’s gone, eyes shut, moving backwards and forwards, I rush around wiping sides, washing up, taking a quick five-minute shower where I leak milk but realise that the stinging sensation between my legs is starting to lessen at least. Finally, I slump down on the sofa, contemplating whether turning the TV on might wake her and wishing I’d left it on low before she went to sleep. I wish Dan was here. I think I am frightened of this new life. This odd responsibility where me, a woman with a busy job, full of daily purpose and a list of tasks which get pleasingly ticked off as I go along, has been depleted to this: a feeding machine, hanging on to my sanity by a gossamer thread.

I pick up my phone, check my messages. Rebecca is on two blue ticks!

She’s seen and read them. I head to the kitchen, dial her number and listen to it ring. It disconnects. No voicemail or anything, just dead.

Has she cut me off?

Hey, I type, are you OK?

Unread. But she’d checked in, read my messages. That was good, right? Though she hadn’t taken my call.

I message Dan, *Rebecca has read my messages but not responded . . .*

Bet she’s recuperating in that fancy hospital with the baby!

I reckon you might be right! I ping back. A message with a breezy tone I don’t feel at all.

I sit on the sofa, scrolling through my phone feeling ever so slightly better.

I’d been worried, I realise. That perhaps something had happened to her or the baby. I’d also been plagued by thoughts of those little bruises on the top of her arm, her status as a housewife which, whilst in some ways seemed idyllic, could also denote a lack of independence?

Not that I’d got that impression of her. Quite the opposite in fact. She’d struck me as supremely confident, chatting easily with the staff in the café,

smoothing over any cracks in our conversation.

My mother was right about me when I was younger; I had struggled to make friends. Had often felt at a loss as to what to say, what questions to ask, how to respond to ones posed to me. I had always felt somehow lacking, as if I was a flimsy, rubbish second child always outshone by my older brother. Worse still, I had worried that my entry into the family had been the catalyst for my parents' split. Awkward, is how you'd describe me, in stark contrast to Nick who is easy-going and chatty. I'd not felt that with her, Rebecca. I'd felt funny and charming too because, I suppose, she put me at ease.

Messages unread and not showing as delivered.

Dan must be right. I bet she's still in the hospital. I feel a swell of excitement, hopefully soon she'll be home and we can go back to walking in the park, this time pushing our children along in their overpriced buggies. I haven't been out on my own with Charlie yet and the thought of it fills me with dread. But, I'd be able to make it to the park. I'd definitely go if I knew I'd be meeting my friend at the end of the short walk, and I bet Rebecca will be out and about straight away. I bet she's not terrified of everything.

Dan looks as tired as I feel. We are at Mum's house. She's buzzing about, laying the table, bringing out serving bowls full of roast potatoes, over-cooked cabbage that smells sweet and off all at once. Nick is at the head of the table swilling red wine and cracking jokes with Dan about football. Charlie is asleep in her small Moses basket. My mum's cat wanders over every few seconds to peer at my daughter and I'm amazed by the heart-thumping fear this engenders every time she does. People talk incessantly about the overwhelming love they feel for their newborns. I haven't had a rush of feeling exactly, though I haven't admitted it to Dan, Mum or anyone else for that matter. But I have moments where I'm enamoured by her. Normally when she's sleeping, which seems an awful thing to tell anyone. When she's awake, I feel terribly tense, as if I'm going to get it all wrong. I *do* feel a strong sense of duty. I *have* to protect her, at all costs. I must assume that, by now, Rebecca has had her baby. I wonder if her feelings are as complicated as mine. I would be honest with her, because I think she'd understand. It's been almost two weeks now though since I first called her. I've tried several times since and her phone has gone straight to voicemail. The last message I sent remains unread.

'Are you okay, Alison?' My mum.

'Yes. Just . . .'

'The cat won't hurt her, love,' she says, squeezing my shoulder. My eyes well up. It's the tiredness. I am an emotional wreck. Any tiny, insignificant act of kindness can send me over the edge, particularly from my mother from whom I am more used to criticism.

Charlie wakes up before we get to pudding and I excuse myself, heading to the living room to feed her. I'm close to drifting off sitting up, despite the sharp pinch of the baby sucking, when I hear someone say, 'Knock knock.'

Dan. He pokes his head around the door as I'm finishing, then comes over, taking Charlie and hefting her up to his shoulder, gently patting her back.

At the door he calls out, 'All clear,' to my mum and brother. Nick plonks down next to me on the sofa, wine glass in hand. I can smell the tannin from here. Mum says, 'I'll get you a glass, love?'

I nod. 'Yes, please.'

'Should you?' says Dan.

I feel a stab of annoyance. 'Half a glass will be fine – besides, I've just fed her.'

'I won't drink either,' he says. Something he's started to do since she's been born, despite seeming oblivious to it during my pregnancy.

'Here you go.' My mum hands me a glass. I take a sip, delighted to be drinking something that isn't juice. I want to text Rebecca a picture, an impulse I've had several times over the past few weeks, but Mum is going on about Nick's new job, which apparently is extremely impressive. Something to do with hedge funds. My brother is the proverbial blagger, a tongue as smooth as silk, but lazy underneath his superficial charm. He's had a lifetime, of course, of my mother doting on him.

'Might be time for you to think about settling down, Nick,' says my mother, who whilst currently bowled over by Charlie, will no doubt be beside herself the day Nick produces offspring. If he ever does.

Nick makes a snorting sound. 'No, thanks. I mean, the baby's cute and everything.' To me.

'Thanks,' I manage, the sarcasm lost on Nick.

'But, I like to be free.' He shrugs.

I put my glass down. 'I'm just nipping to the loo.'

In the bathroom, I splash cold water on my face, pressing an old familiar towel that has been here since I was a child to my damp skin.

Freedom. Such a small, easy thing to take for granted. I feel the lack of it now like a manacle around my legs. I pull out my phone, I'm still on unread. Even if she'd stayed in hospital after the birth, she'd surely be out by now? And I knew she'd read other messages and just not responded. Something's wrong, I can feel it; she wouldn't have just ditched me. Whatever Dan says, we have a connection. I hit dial, press my mobile to my ear.

'The number you are trying to reach is no longer available.'

I frown at it. Try again. Same thing.

A knock on the door and I jump, my phone dropping from my hand to the bathroom floor with an appallingly loud clatter.

‘Al?’ Dan’s voice, soft, concerned.

‘I’m fine.’ The word comes out sharper than I intended. ‘Give me a sec.’

When I step out into the hallway, he’s there, eyes soft and full of worry. The feeling of being unable to breathe gets worse. I swallow thickly.

‘Charlie’s fussing, maybe she’s hungry again?’

‘I just fed her,’ I say, incredulous.

He grins. ‘She’s growing fast.’

And she is too, arms and legs plumping out, a soft wedge of pink fleshy cushioning building around her as I shrink into a puddle of nothingness. Despite having just given birth, I seem to be losing weight rapidly and have seen the appearance of bones jutting out from my collarbone and across my hips. I’d have been delighted by this once, but coupled with the tiredness, I fear I am just starting to look gaunt.

Mum is now firmly focused on the minute details of Nick’s career, nodding, oohing and ahing, whilst announcing that Nick has ‘always been clever’. Which is true, and in my mind I hear ‘unlike you’, though she’s never said it aloud of course.

Not a terrible day overall, but I find exhaustion starts to set in anew, probably hastened by the wine, which has gone straight to my head. I’m glad when we get in the car to go home.

I look in every local Facebook group I can find for a Rebecca Dalston, remembering the name she'd given the po-faced nurse at the hospital. I spell it in different ways, but whilst there are a fair few Rebecca and Becky Dalstons, none of them are her. Nothing on Instagram or Twitter. It's three in the morning. I've just fed Charlie who is now sleeping soundly whilst I, a madwoman on a mission, scroll furiously.

Rizzo's, I think and head to the Facebook page for the restaurant. I scroll through the list of the 250 people who 'like' this page.

Nothing. I scroll through the photos people have tagged of themselves, with their broad grins, brandishing cheesy garlic bread like a prize. Nothing, nothing, nothing. Then . . . a photo. A single picture of a group of incredibly good-looking people, holding champagne glasses high in the air, beaming, perfect white smiles jumping out of the screen. There she is. My heart beats a little faster, I enlarge the image. Shorter hair, more highlights and her face is slimmer, but it is definitely her. I look through the tags. Hers comes up in bold black rather than clickable blue. *Rebecca Dalston*.

Bingo.

She's not on Facebook, it seems, or if she is, she must be set to private. I google her, but the list is long and sprawling. I search again, adding our London suburb, and she is on the third page.

An obituary, five years ago, for a Martin James Dalston. A well-loved local man and a renowned barrister. I scroll down. He leaves behind a daughter, his sole heir. The article mentions that Rebecca had lost her mother at the tender age of five. I feel a stab of pity for her. I wonder if she kept her surname. I hadn't seen a wedding ring on her finger, but I hadn't been wearing mine either. We had both laughed at the gigantic, water-retaining state of our respective digits.

Rebecca Dalston, following in her father's footsteps, is also a barrister and took over his practice upon his death.

A barrister? She'd said she was a housewife.

Perhaps it was a new arrangement? The housewife bit. I type in her name and 'barrister', which brings up a long list of cases. Some as recent as eight months ago. She'd have been pregnant then but in her first trimester. She's still listed as a partner in Dalston's Family Law along with a Gareth Evans. I make a note of his name, copy and pasting it in an email to myself. Eventually I find her LinkedIn profile but the words are starting to blur on the screen. I shut the lid of my laptop, my eyes stinging with exhaustion. I lie down on the single bed and close them, drifting off with a million questions pinging around in my mind.

'She told me it was her husband's money.'

Dan shrugs, jiggling Charlie from one shoulder to the other. 'Maybe she's embarrassed.'

'Why would she be embarrassed?'

'I don't know . . . about inheriting her wealth?'

'But she didn't inherit it, did she? She's a barrister. So even without the family business, she'd hardly have been hard-up.'

Dan sighs. 'Who knows. Either way, she doesn't seem to want to meet up right now.'

I feel my lower lip quiver. He reaches out and lifts a tendril of my hair, tucking it behind my ear. 'I know it's tough, early days with a baby, me back at work.'

'I'm fine,' I snap.

He hands me Charlie, glancing at his watch. 'I'm sorry.' He's frowning now, his face full of concern. I clutch the baby who is at least drifting off and force myself to smile. 'It's *fine*, honestly. I'm fine. You're probably right, I'm just tired.'

'But you're going to go to that sensory play and sing-along thing this morning?'

I nod; he'd been so pleased when he came up with it. After he goes, I put Charlie in her basket carefully in the upstairs hallway by the bathroom door. I shower quickly. I towel my wet hair and brush it back into a ponytail, then carry Charlie carefully downstairs in her basket and open my laptop. At least she can sleep without the swing now, most of the time at least.

A search of Rebecca's name mainly brings up more stuff about the law firm. Buried pages and pages in is an article about a death at a boarding

school in Hampshire. I'm about to read it when Charlie's bellow makes me jump out of my skin.

'Coming,' I say, 'Coming, baby,' as I head over and scoop her up.

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We are not on time. We arrive when the 'session' is in full swing. It is every bit as awful as I imagined. Everything I turn my eyes to is an assault on the senses. Primary colours, competing clashing noises, bells, beeping toys that light up, a fire engine with sound effects. Women, all roughly my age in designated uniform of easy jeans, Veja trainers and dungarees, which look remarkably like Charlie's sleep suits, make silly voices at tiny people. The ones I see first are bigger, boisterous children, running amok like tiny lunatics brandishing rattles and walkers, sticky-looking hands held aloft. My own hands tighten on my pushchair and I think, I can just leave. I don't have to go in, I can at least tell Dan I made it.

'First time?'

I turn to see a woman with short hair and a kind smile.

'Oh. Yes. I was just thinking it might be a bit much for us.'

She peers into the pushchair. 'Your daughter?'

'Yes,' I say, my face heating at the reality of it. Those words people keep saying to me which feel far too big, far too all-encompassing to make sense. *Your daughter. Mine.* I am a mother.

'Don't worry, the under ones are through here.' She points to an adjoining room. 'Take her out and pop the buggy in the pushchair park.' I look behind me, seeing row upon row of prams of various sizes, all laden with things. The accessories associated with such tiny people never fail to amaze me. 'Okay, thanks,' I murmur, taking the bag off the back of the buggy, hitching it up my shoulder and picking up Charlie, who is wide awake and gurgling.

'She seems a contented little thing,' the woman says, smiling. 'First one?'

'Yes,' I manage, not adding, 'only'. Even though I want to. You're not meant to say that, especially when you are blessed with a 'contented' one.

'Is she a good sleeper?'

'Not really, I'm up every three hours.'

'That's not bad, she looks quite little still.'

‘Almost a month,’ I say. ‘At first it was every hour.’

‘Yes. They are ravenous to start with. I’m Sara, by the way, I work here.’

‘Ali. Nice to meet you.’

I follow her into the room, which is low lit and half the decibel level of the main area. Like the chillout room of a nightclub, I think, suppressing a smile.

‘Hello, ladies,’ Sara says. ‘This is Ali and . . .’ I stare at her blankly. ‘Your daughter?’

‘Oh, yes – Charlie,’ I say, then laugh for no reason.

What I notice during the hour I manage to endure of sensory play is that all the other women there seem to know exactly what they are doing, and that when I attempt to crack a joke about being high from lack of sleep, no one laughs. I’m reminded with awful clarity of what it was like being at school before Izzy befriended me. The other children laughed easily, were included in jokes I struggled to understand, and played games I struggled to play. Later, as a teenager, I was uncomfortable in my own skin, prone to saying the wrong thing. I learned fast that the easiest thing was to say nothing at all. Izzy, in contrast, was outgoing and popular and I hid behind her. Now I walk back from the little church hall, pushing Charlie ahead of me, replaying the stupid things I’d said today and the blank stares I’d gained from the other mums.

By the time we get in, she is asleep. I park the pushchair in the hall, make sure my phone is on silent and settle onto the sofa. I open my laptop, going back to the article I’d started to read earlier.

Tragedy struck our town last weekend when teenager Oliver Harrington, a student at St Marcus’s boarding school, died by misadventure at a house party. The party was hosted by a day student from St Marcus’s sister school, Oakwood. Both schools are prestigious institutions with good reputations and have been a bedrock of our town for many decades. High-profile students include Mike Samuels, the son of Miriam Samuels MP, Rebecca Dalston, daughter of barrister Martin Dalston, who defended the Stockton poisoner in the eighties, and Oliver himself, whose father was a well-known record producer. Spokesmen for both schools have shared their utter devastation and send sincere condolences to Oliver’s family who have asked for pri-

vacy during this difficult time. Police are continuing their enquiries, though DC Humphries reported no foul play is suspected.

I google St Marcus's and Oakwood, beautiful red-brick buildings nestled in the heart of the English countryside. Chocolate-box perfect. I can imagine Rebecca somewhere like that. She'd obviously been born into wealth, her ease and charm perfected at the school, which looks fairy-tale perfect. I allow myself a short fantasy, where it was I who attended that school, learning how to oil conversations and get ahead. Not having to live in the constant shadow of my brother, unwavering in his cheerfulness, always bright, always the favourite.

My phone rings, vibrating next to me. Mum. I grab it with a whisper, 'Hello.'

'Is the baby sleeping?'

'Yes,' I hiss. 'Hang on.' I stand, phone crunched between ear and shoulder and push the living-room door to.

'She's a good sleeper, Dan says.'

'He's not up in the night,' I say more sharply than I'd meant to, thoughts of privileges I didn't have still front and centre in my mind. 'But from what I can work out she's not too bad, no,' I say, softening my voice.

'Your dad never got up either,' she says and I brace myself for the incoming tirade or a further barbed comment which comes almost straight away. 'Left me to it and honest to God I don't think you slept for more than forty minutes at a go.' She sighs and I harden myself for more, but instead she says, 'Still, it's tiring for you just having to get up at all.'

I narrow my eyes at that but murmur, 'Yes, it is a bit.'

'Maybe I could nip over, sit with her for a while one day this week, you could have a nap or go and get your hair done or something?'

I start to say no, then think about Rebecca's unread messages, the lies about her husband and being a housewife. Though maybe she is a barrister and a housewife? Both things are possible? No, they aren't. One cancels out the other. Maybe she had just quit and was tying up loose ends.

I think of the awful, unimaginable possibility that she has lost the baby. If that is the case my presence might be too painful and I'll leave her alone if I can't be there for her. But I have to know. I want to go back to the suburb she lives in, where Rizzo's is, and trace the route from the park to there. It would certainly be easier, and faster, without the buggy.

‘I wouldn’t mind getting out for a walk on my own. Maybe between feeds tomorrow?’

‘Great.’

We firm up a time and she hangs up.

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Dan shifts Charlie onto her stomach on his lap, she makes a wet gurgling sound as he rubs his hand in circles on her back and she sort of snuffles. I smile at her; she really does remind me of my little black cat from yesterday. Of all the things that have assisted in me feeling what I suppose must be maternal pangs for my own child, I'd be loath to admit to anyone that it's because she reminds me of a childhood pet.

'Those noises are cute, huh?' Dan asks.

'Yes,' I say and we pass a smile between us, a small lovely moment.

'So, sensory rhyme-time wasn't for you?'

I shake my head. 'Dan, it was adult, fully grown women singing and doing the actions for "The Wheels on the Bus", which honestly I did not know had actual actions.'

'Actions?'

He screws his nose up.

I mime them for him and he laughs out loud. I find myself grinning. 'The babies were bloody oblivious so it was just us mums, making utter tits of ourselves.'

'I mean, maybe they are taking it in on some level?'

I frown. 'Even so.'

'Yeah, okay. It sounds terrible.'

'This is why I need Rebecca to get home and back on her feet.'

His face falls.

'What?' I say, knowing already that I'm about to get one of his careful lectures.

'Has she got back to you?'

'No, not yet. But like you said, she's probably just settling back into a new routine.'

'What, back into her career which she flat-out lied about? Maybe her husband isn't even a barrister.'

‘She might not have lied exactly,’ I say, thinking about the small faint bruises ringed around her upper arm. ‘Maybe he’s not very nice. Maybe it’s him keeping her from making contact with me.’

Dan’s frown deepens. ‘What makes you think that?’

‘Well, why else lie? Plus, she always seemed to move on quite quickly whenever he was mentioned.’

‘Right.’

‘What?’ I demand.

‘Maybe there was a problem, with the birth, or the baby. Or, maybe she just needs some space.’

‘From me, you mean?’

‘I don’t know but, for whatever reason, she’s not desperate to connect, is she?’

‘We’re friends,’ I say, hating the desperate note to my voice.

‘You’ve just met.’

‘So what? She was there for me when I was terrified.’ He sort of flinches at that and I know he still feels guilty, but that’s not the point now. I tell him, ‘We . . . we made plans.’ I hear an echo of myself from years ago as I followed Max around the little room in my student house. ‘We had plans,’ I’d said to him through a veil of almost constant tears. And we had had plans, to get a place together. To set up home, just as I’d always had plans with Izzy. ‘I’ll be your maid of honour, you be mine.’ Yes. ‘And godmothers to each other’s children.’ Though neither of us believed in God. Max had sighed at me, ‘Plans change, Al.’

He’d said all sorts of things, given me a list of reasons for what he had done: I was too needy, too clingy, I didn’t give him enough space. Izzy had echoed some of them when I’d gone to see her and told her, finish with Max and we’ll forget it ever happened. Trying to show her the friendship meant more than some guy anyway. Even now the memory stings. Is this the same? I hadn’t pushed Rebecca, not at all, she’d been the one who struck up conversation, the one who’d suggested we get together for regular meet-ups. She held my hand while I bled, called me in the middle of the night to look at my new child with wonder in her eyes.

‘You’re right,’ Dan says, voice soothing but not fooling me at all. ‘Her behaviour is strange. I’m sure she’s got stuff going on and I’m sure she will get back to you.’

I nod, keeping a million retorts in. He does this, I think, anger rising – pat-

ronises me.

When we met I'd been a mess, helpless and lost. He'd been steady and patient and I wonder if that foundation is a healthy one or not. If he *expects* me not to be okay, not to manage. I shake my head; that's not fair. Dan's not a dick. I'm tired and emotional. My feelings are hurt about Rebecca and he doesn't understand. Which is fine, I just won't talk to him about it.

'So, your mum's coming by tomorrow?'

'I'm going to go for a walk,' I say quickly, forcing a smile. 'Not too far and while Charlie is napping.'

'It's a brilliant idea, and really nice of her to offer too. I'm so sorry I got such shit paternity leave.'

'It's fine, it's normal, isn't it?'

'It is, but it still sucks. I miss her, and you.'

'I know,' I say, but really I'm keen to get to bed then get up tomorrow and start trying properly to find my friend because, whatever Dan says, and however briefly we knew each other, there is something up and I'm going to find out exactly what.

I didn't sleep well. My head was like a hive of wasps, thoughts buzzing in and out. By the time Charlie woke for her first feed, I was shattered. I sat hunched over her, eyelids drooping but my brain racing. I winded her, nestled her back into her crib and shut my eyes again. It was no use; as 4 a.m. rolled around, I figured I may as well get up and at least have a coffee in peace.

By the time Dan wakes, I'm showered, dressed and have a fresh pot on.

'Did you sleep okay?' he asks.

'Yes, fine,' I say, the lie burning the end of my tongue.

'Oh good. I thought I heard her at about three?'

'You did. She fed then went back to sleep but I figured I might as well get up.'

'Okay,' he says, grabbing a banana from the side and peeling it. 'And you'll be getting out on your own today?'

'Just for a walk,' I say, defensiveness hardening my voice.

'It's a good thing, you need a break. And it will be nice for your mum.'

'Yes, I think so too,' I say, feeling guilty for not telling him where I'm really going. I'm relieved when he goes. I manage to empty the dishwasher, put on a load of washing and make the downstairs look less like a bomb's hit it before Charlie wakes.

By the time my mum knocks on the door, she's fed, changed and happily babbling on her playmat.

My mum's face softens immediately when she looks at the baby. 'Ah,' she says.

I smile. 'She's sweet, isn't she?'

'She really is, yes.'

'I, um, managed to express some milk,' I say, my face heating up at this peculiarly intimate news.

'Well done, Ali,' she says and seems to mean it.

‘She’s not done brilliantly with a bottle so far though . . .’

She waves a hand. ‘Don’t you worry about that, if she’s hungry enough she’ll take it.’

‘Do you think?’

She nods. ‘I switched you to formula pretty early on; it was difficult feeding and trying to get Nick to school.’

‘It must have been a tough time,’ I say.

‘Oh,’ she says and I wonder if she waits for barbed comments from me just as I do her. If I throw them out, unwittingly reminding her endlessly of her failings. It’s possible, I allow. This defensive dance we do around each other. She shrugs. ‘It *was* very stressful. I suppose, looking back, that I didn’t do as well as I could have; even where your father’s concerned, I probably should have tried harder.’ Her eyes flick to me and back to the baby.

‘I’m sure you did your best,’ I manage, though, is that really true? I’d had a lifetime of unfavourable comparisons to Nick. She probably *had* done her best, she’d probably done far better than *I* would have. When Dan gets home, the first thing I always do is hand him Charlie, head upstairs and sink into a bath. Those little minutes of unencumbered time make a huge difference in days that are extremely samey. Days that are structured around someone else’s needs; to eat, defecate, burp and fart even. An odd scaffolding us new mums live under, a tenuous build that seems to crumble and change every time we think we have a handle on it. ‘It’s a phase’ gets said a lot, and ‘she’ll change so fast you won’t believe it.’ Which is true. I think I know her, her routines, her wants and demands, and then they change again. My mum had to navigate that alone but for a small boy with a loud voice and me, colicky, she has said many times; apparently I never stopped crying. It must have been awful, really. I reach across, squeeze my mum to me and ask again, ‘You’ll be okay?’

‘I’ll be fine, you go. I’ll call if we need you, but don’t rush back, okay?’ Her eyes are on the baby, drinking in her little granddaughter.

‘Okay.’

My daughter is just six weeks old and yet as I leave the house I feel like I have forgotten something vital, a limb perhaps. How quickly they embed into our lives, seeping into the fabric of everything we do. We are *so* together, so continuously joined that I am no longer sure where I end and she be-

gins. I stop and buy a latte, allowing myself to enjoy the tiny pleasure of a hot drink not turned cold and I think, it's not always bad, to be apart. To catch your breath. Then the stab of guilt. Is this how it will always be?

I try to clear the thoughts from my mind. Charlie is at home, with my mum. My mum raised two of us singlehandedly. She loves Charlie, anyone can see that. The summer's heat is fading away as autumn pushes in, but the day is bright still, I inhale fresh, clean air, my lungs expanding as I go. It crosses my mind that I could just keep walking. Clear out my bank account, travel somewhere far, far away, never look back. I think of what my mum had said before I left. She did her best, but how hard must it have been? How often she must have felt like this and with no one on hand to take us, my dad busy with work, then busy with his new wife who didn't want children and never allowed us to stay overnight. If I feel this way with one small child, a doting husband and her support, how must she have felt, left high and dry with two of us.

I am at the park now where Rebecca and I had walked along, two large blimps, laughing and joking. Where we should be now, I think, pushing prams.

It takes about half an hour from the park to Rizzo's. Then I am at a loss for where to go next. She'd mentioned a deli she often walked to, Fortunes, I think she'd said. They did the best rosemary bread and bagels to die for. I put it into Google Maps, which tells me I'm mere seconds away. My phone beeps – Dan. *How is it?*

Lovely, I respond with a smiley emoji, my own face heating up from the dishonesty. I of all people know how little lies can grow and grow, making the person on the receiving end doubt their own mind, their own reality. I push the thoughts away.

Fortunes is up ahead, a shop set on the corner of two impressive roads where the houses are set back, far from the pavement, each one with pretty doors and doorsteps. Money is what is on display here. Proper money. Inherited money, I think.

I go into Fortunes, joining a small queue of people who all seem to know each other. At the counter I buy a coffee for almost £6, managing not to ask the girl waiting on me if it is laced with gold. Instead I smile and say, 'My friend recommended this place.'

'Oh?'

'Maybe you know her, Rebecca Dalston?'

Her face breaks into a smile. ‘Oh yes, of course, she used to be a regular, we didn’t see her for quite a while actually, but she’s been back again recently.’

My heart picks up pace. ‘It’s her local, she said?’

‘Yes, that’s right.’

I stand, waiting for more information. When none is forthcoming, I take my paper cup and move away. Frustrated and unsure where to go next. As I stand uncertainly a voice breaks into my thoughts. ‘Friend of Rebecca’s?’ I turn, facing a well-dressed tall woman with a small, frowning child alongside her.

‘Oh yes. Do you know her?’

‘We used to be neighbours. We were three doors along on Alpine Close, the house with the red door.’

‘A lovely area,’ I murmur. Memorising – Alpine Close and red door.

She sighs. ‘It is, yes. We didn’t go too far. We’re on Linwood now,’ she says as though I must know it. I nod as if I do. ‘Nice.’

Then she is moving forwards in the queue, the child tugging at her hand, frown replaced by greed as he eyes up the pastries and cakes on display.

Alpine Drive is the road feeding to the right. Three doors away from the house with the red door she’d said. I am clutching the coffee which I no longer fancy at all, adrenaline taking away my thirst. I think about just binning it, but for £6 I can’t bring myself to. Instead, I drink it in several long, warm gulps, putting the cup in the recycling bin outside Fortunes.

I find the house with the red door. And trace three houses to the left then to the right. The first thing I notice about the one on the right is a large For Sale sign on the outside. I walk up a little paved path which takes me to a navy blue front door with a wrought-iron knocker. An Instagram-pretty doorstep, the kind you can imagine eager parents photographing children on, in blazers and straw hats as they embark upon their unruffled childhoods. Number 6. There is a bell too and I ring that.

One second, two, three . . . and there she is.

‘Rebecca.’ The word comes out like a gasp, full of relief. I find I want to step forward, take her in my arms. I have missed her. My eyes drop to her stomach. Hidden beneath a long tunic, but no baby there. Dan was right. Of course she’s given birth, no one could go that far over their due date and I knew she was booked in.

‘Can I help you?’ She is looking at me, eyebrow raised in question.

‘Rebecca?’

‘Yes.’ She looks over my shoulder both ways down the street.

‘I . . . you haven’t been picking up my calls, I just wanted to check that you were okay?’

She frowns. ‘I’m sorry,’ she says without a trace of recognition, ‘but I don’t think we’ve met.’

I shake my head. ‘You’re Rebecca?’

‘I am, yes. Do I know you?’

‘It’s me.’ I try again. ‘Ali, from the park.’

‘Okay.’ Her voice is dubious, wary. Then, ‘How did you get my address?’

‘I remembered you mentioning the café. Fortunes. I was worried, when you didn’t respond, that maybe there’d been a problem with you or the baby?’

‘What baby?’ The frown deepens.

‘Your baby. We were having babies.’

‘I don’t have any children.’

‘No, well, you must by now? You were very pregnant?’

‘You must be confusing me with someone else. I have no children, I have no idea who you are and, honestly, this entire exchange is rather unnerving. I think I’d like you to leave.’

‘But . . .’

‘Or I’ll be forced to call for help.’

‘Help with what?’

‘Please, just go.’

I think of the mysterious Joshua, her lies about being wealthy due to marriage when, actually, she was a successful barrister, an heiress to a thriving law practice. A sole heiress at that. My eyes flick to her left hand, still no wedding ring and no tell-tale dent like the one I have on my hand when the ring is removed. But, again, I think of the bruises, small and round, the shape and size of fingerprints – Joshua’s? Maybe not the source of her income, but perhaps the source of her pain? Abuse? She didn’t seem the type, but then, what is the type? I read in an article somewhere that ninety-nine per cent of domestic abuse victims are far smarter, and generally more accomplished, than their abusers.

I take a step forward, lower my voice, ‘Are you in danger?’

‘What on earth are you talking about?’ Her voice is louder now, full of irritation. I feel a sort of internal judder, a disconnection from reality, my

brain whirring.

‘Did something happen? With the baby perhaps? Were there . . . complications?’ I can’t think how else to say it delicately. I am like a bulldozer with anything sensitive. My superpower often seems to be trampling hard where angels fear to tread. ‘I mean, I just wanted to let you know that whatever it is, whatever happened, I’m here for you. Like you were for me.’ My voice has reached a new pitch, fevered, high. It is desperate. The same tone I’d used as I sobbed on Izzy’s doorstep and she’d looked at me aghast, horror making her face slack. Later, as Max packed boxes, shoulders tight and hunched, I begged, ‘Don’t go . . . I’ll change . . .’ He shook his head as if I just didn’t understand, didn’t get it, which I didn’t.

‘Rebecca?’ The word is strangled, the hot coffee of seconds ago seeming to burn in my chest.

‘Please leave.’ Her voice is firm; the same tone I’d heard her use when asking gaggles of teenagers to step aside in the park, the same tone she’d taken with the stroppy nurse as she held my hand and quelled my nerves. She steps back, the door closing in my face, and I am left standing, dumbstruck.

PART TWO

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REBECCA

Ten months ago

She holds the stick in her hand, blinking at it. It makes her eyes go funny, the strong blue lines accompanied lower down by the word 'positive' swimming in and out of focus. She'd paid an extra £5 to have the word as well as the lines. The woman in the chemist had said it was a waste of money and Rebecca had smiled politely, nodded and bought it anyway. She'd known. Well, no, that's not true, but she'd suspected. Her stomach had that sort of butterfly feeling for most of each day, accompanied by a faint nausea. Plus, this had been the plan. What they'd been aiming for for . . . not long really. Over a month, but not quite two. This was expected but much faster than she'd anticipated.

She wraps the test in a wad of tissue and shoves it to the bottom of her oversized handbag. Outside the stall, she stands at the sink, meeting her own eyes levelly in the mirror. Nothing looks different. She turns to the side, not even the glimmer of a bump. Her stomach is as it always is. Flat beneath her crisp white shirt. If she took it off, she'd see chiselled, hard--won abs. She'll lose those, she supposes, as her middle expands. The idea of her body changing makes her feel even more queasy. She'd wanted this. Desperately. Had lain awake at night thinking about it many times over the past decade when she'd seen acquaintances paired off and starting families. In her early twenties she'd felt relief not to be them, but after her father's death, as her thirties approached, she'd started to consider it, and then to long for it. And now . . . here she was.

'You alright, Bex?'

Margaret Stanford's voice pulls her from her thoughts and Rebecca tears

her eyes from the mirror. 'Yes, fine.' She forces a smile. Margaret nods, heads into a stall and Rebecca leaves quickly before she comes out and starts talking again. Not that she has anything against Margaret. Not at all, quite the opposite. Margaret has been at the firm since Rebecca was a small child. Which means she can tell when something is amiss.

Not that this is amiss, she shouldn't think like that.

She's at her desk now, bag planted firmly at her feet, eyes on the computer screen ahead. Somehow she gets through the day, relieved when she can finally leave. She spends the train journey back lost in thoughts and memories which feel so far away, so alien now it feels as though someone else might have lived them.

She has a longing for her father, perhaps a sort of primal urge to say, *You're going to be a granddad*. A longing too for the mother she can't remember. Dad would be pleased, she thinks, though he might question the circumstances. Who wouldn't?

She'd lost her way once, a series of events that almost ruined everything. He'd never found out what had happened and she was glad of that. He'd lived long enough to see her follow in his footsteps. Years of inherited knowledge passed down like an heirloom. 'The law,' her dad had told her when she was small enough to long for fairy stories still, 'is there to protect everyone. It's a thing that we have created to keep each other safe.'

She'd loved that when she was a child. Then, after he'd sent her to board at Oakwood and she had felt abandoned by him, she'd hated it. The law is a weapon, she'd decided, wielded by the rich and privileged. Yet still, even in the midst of her resentment, after disaster struck, she'd fallen back into her studies, opened textbooks, looked up cases. Found there was a meditative quality to learning.

She gets in, tired after a long day, and makes a cup of peppermint tea, heading out and sitting in the garden, watching the day fade to night. She'll need to stop working. There's no rush but she doesn't want anyone there to know about this so it will need to be before she starts showing. Will she get lonely, she wonders? Or lonelier than she has been. 'It will be just you and me, baby,' she says to the as-yet-invisible bump. Right now, in this moment, she thinks she could change her mind and not go through with it.

'This was your granddad's house,' she tells the ball of cells that will eventually be a person. Her stomach gurgles and she imagines it's the baby responding, which makes her smile. 'You won't meet him, I'm afraid, or your

grandmother who I hardly knew myself. But such is life.' She pauses, draining the last of the cup, putting it on the table in front of her and pulling the blanket up. It will be spring soon enough. Already, the days are starting to draw out. The sun beginning to warm the air. Already she is in equal measures impatient for the pregnancy to hurry along, and cautious as to how her life will look afterwards.

No, she's not going to change her mind. Not now. She picks up her phone, sends a message with a picture of the test.

Ping goes her phone in immediate response. *OMFG – we're really doing this! I love you so much x*

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Dan is frowning at me. 'You used your "me" time to go and stalk Rebecca?'

'It's hardly stalking!' My voice rises and I hear a tinge of desperation in it.

'Not that that is the bloody point.'

'Did you tell your mum about this?'

'No, she didn't stay long after I got back, plus, what would I say? It's such a strange situation.'

He sighs, slumping onto the sofa, running a hand across his face. He looks tired, I think, dark circles smudging the thin skin under his eyes. He gets up most times when I do, defeating the purpose of me sleeping in another room. He says once he's heard her, that's it.

'Your fixation is becoming a bit weird, to be honest, Ali.'

'My . . . what?'

'It's odd behaviour.'

'What's *odd* is her pretending not to know me, surely?'

'Yes, but for whatever reason she doesn't want to be friends.'

Tears escape before I have a chance to blink them away. Shit. I swipe at my face, pressing the palms of my hands into my cheeks. 'Shit,' I say aloud.

'God, Ali. I'm sorry, I didn't mean to be unkind.' He's standing, coming over to me, pulling me into him. 'Of course it's out of order and really weird on her part, but maybe it's a lucky escape, eh?'

'What do you mean?' I ask, my face now pressed into the soft fabric of his shirt. I bought it for him a few years ago; I bought him several when he'd got promoted, from Pinks. They are lovely, super-soft and label-free. Right now I'm smearing stale eyeliner on this one. I push back, wiping my eyes on the sleeve of my own T-shirt. No work clothes for me, not any more. I don't even need to look presentable for Zoom. I *had* made an effort today though, to go and see my friend who is now denying any knowledge of my existence.

'I mean, she must have . . . problems, I suppose, that you don't know

about, or like I said, it might be an issue with the baby.'

I think about the bruises, her eyes today, flicking worried glances over my shoulder.

'I think she's in trouble,' I tell Dan.

'Well, trouble isn't what you need right now, is it?' He smiles as if that is that resolved. The end of the discussion. But to me it solidifies the knowledge that I can't just let this go. We may not have known each other for a long time, but we had a connection. We were, we *are* friends and friends don't abandon each other at the first sign of trouble, do they?

I had been pregnant once before. Dan doesn't know about it. No one does other than Max and me. And probably Izzy, I realise, the thought of them discussing it hurting even now after so many years. He had been horrified, Max. Not least because, when the test came back, the unmistakable blue line strong and loaded with meaning, we'd just broken up. Or, more accurately, he'd just packed his stuff and left me. He'd asked if it was even his and I'd stared at him, aghast. Then, he was the only man I had ever been to bed with, save a few awkward fumbling encounters with a teenage boyfriend.

He didn't want the baby; he was adamant about that. I had no idea what I wanted other than him. Maybe because of that, I'd have kept that child, hoping that perhaps it would reunite us, make me matter more than the other woman he'd been 'seeing' on and off for the majority of our relationship. Being cheated on would have stung no matter the circumstances, but the pregnancy added insult to injury, that and the disturbing fact I found out shortly after, which was that the other woman was my best friend.

It turned out not to matter what I would have done. I had an early miscarriage. Just as I entered my third year at university. The course I'd once been so excited about, the promise of a good life ahead of me, dripped away like the dead thing that left my body in red droplets, slipping into the toilet bowl, as ungraspable as any love Max had ever felt for me. I grieved that child that never was. 'Just a ball of cells,' Max had said, adding, 'Lucky escape, eh?' Giving me that devilish grin. And for him, I'm sure it was a lucky escape, from a baby before he was anywhere near ready and also, of course, from me.

I suffocated him, is what he said. I was too much. Too needy. Paranoid. Though, in my defence, every single thing I'd been 'paranoid' about turned

out to be justified. Reality, sharp and unforgiving.

I became awful, I know that I did. My plaintive cries of, 'Who are you texting?', 'Where are you going?', 'Whose perfume can I smell?' Even though I knew by then. I recognised the scent, she'd been wearing it for years.

Charlie finishes her feed, head flopping back, little mouth open, a thin line of milk trickling down her chin. She is beautiful and I feel a swell of love for her. I pick her up now and clutch her to me, head limp on my shoulder, her milk-drunk body soft and warm. I had agreed with Dan last night. Let him think I'd dropped the whole Rebecca thing. He doesn't understand it, not at all. Just like he can never understand what it is like to carry a tiny human encased inside you for months, to push them out into the world amid pain and agony. To feel like body and soul have been smashed to pieces and be unsure how to put those things back together. Rebecca was pregnant. We were friends. She does know who I am and I will get to the bottom of this.

Last night, I had outwardly agreed with everything Dan had had to say on the matter. This morning, his soft, concerned voice is doing little other than irritate me. But, instead of feeling a sort of sinking as he leaves for work, the long hours of baby things stretching ahead of me like a wilderness, I am glad to see him go.

'What are you going to do today?' he asks.

'I think Charlie and I will go for a walk, perhaps feed the ducks.'

'I sent you a link to a jungle gym thing.'

'Yes, I saw – maybe when she's a bit older.'

'I thought it might be a nice way to meet some people, make a few mum friends.' *Mum friends*. The phrase makes me cringe a bit; it also strengthens my resolve. I have a mum friend. I know who I want to hang out with.

'You're right,' I tell him and he looks immediately relieved.

'Call if you need me, yes?'

'Of course.'

After he is gone, I feed Charlie, googling Rebecca's name and address on my phone with the other hand. Nothing other than the listing on Zoopla. It became hers by inheritance in 2012. She's my age, maybe a few years older, but even so, in 2012 I wasn't even out of my teenage years. The house where I'd found her was a cool million and a half, at least. Imagine being able to live somewhere like that so young. Still, as my mother was always fond of telling me, money can't buy you happiness. Though poverty will almost always guarantee you misery.

I push the thought away, still feeling the mild, panicked tremor at our future financial instability which is looming. We can't afford a nursery. So the only way I'll be going back to my old job will be if my mum helps out, and whilst Dan keeps saying I should ask her, I don't know if I want to. She was being fine right now, lovely even, but there are years of carefully ignored bad feeling between us. I had made the mistake of telling her that I'd been prescribed antidepressants after Max left me for Izzy. She'd been so worried that I'd tried to downplay it. 'It's just a break-up, no big deal,' I'd said, my words harder and firmer than I felt. Losing my first love and my best friend in one fell swoop was more than just a break-up and it scarred me, the loss. Losing Max hurt for sure, but most of all it was the loss of Izzy. The girl I'd known since junior school, who I'd shared a whole host of memories with. We'd learned to ride our bikes together, studied for GCSEs then A Levels together. She was, I had thought, my friend for life, and if I wasn't wildly popular, well, it didn't matter too much because I had her. Until I didn't and realised that our close, exclusive friendship hadn't allowed much room for anyone else and that I wasn't so good at putting myself out there.

I'd thrown myself into studying, finished my degree and moved back to Mum's to do an MA in London, which was how I met Dan – an oasis in the desert, a calm port in the turbulent storm of betrayal – and for a while everything seemed so much brighter. Mum had suggested a few times that I reach out and get in touch with Izzy, maybe try and smooth things over. But some wrinkles ran too deep to be ironed away.

I burp Charlie who sighs and flops forward like a little old man. I tuck her into her star-shaped outdoor onesie that makes her look like Maggie from *The Simpsons* and put her into her pram.

Once we are outside I realise that it is actually quite warm. I pause to unzip the baby, untucking her arms, leaving her legs embedded in the soft suit. A woman walking past pauses and leans in to look. Something, I have discovered, perfect strangers do all the time.

‘Ah, bless, she’s adorable,’ the woman says with a grin. ‘You must be so proud.’ Then she is gone. Proud? A few people have said that to me. Dan, when I announced I was pregnant, had said the same thing, as though having unprotected sex was an achievement of some kind. But, looking down at her, pretty little thing that she is, I find that I probably am proud of her, of Dan and me for producing her. I was terrified whilst I was pregnant. I had googled various syndromes that might affect me or my unborn child; I just wanted to know all the things that could go wrong, in case they did and then I would at least be prepared. Bleeding so late on had been awful, but made immensely more bearable because Rebecca had been there. Holding my hand. Holding me together.

Charlie, of course, came out perfect. Ten fingers, ten toes, big, bright blue eyes, eyelashes to die for, and a cute heart-shaped face. Beautiful, sweet as honey. My love for her hadn’t kicked in straight away on full blast as other women seemed to profess, but over the past few weeks it has grown steadily, though, I’ll admit, I am still slightly scared of her. The days where she is colicky and my patience is paper-thin feel as though each minute, each second, lasts for ever. The tiny moments where I am alone, in the bathroom, while she sleeps, walking away from my house leaving her with my mother or Dan, I feel like I am a drowning woman popping up for air. Are these feelings normal? I don’t know and do not want to vocalise them.

I am at Rebecca’s house, slightly out of breath from what proved to be a long walk; the air that had felt warm but fresh now feels cloying and thick. I am sweating beneath my T-shirt, my legs clammy in maternity jeans. I could probably fit back into my old clothes now, but I’m scared to try; the

thought of buttons and zips on my pillow-soft tummy doesn't feel quite right yet.

Yesterday, just before Dan had come home, I had phoned the estate agents and arranged a viewing, asking specifically that the owner be out when I came to look. The agent hadn't baulked at my request which, perhaps, is not so unusual. He had said no worries, the owner was often away anyway and was away tomorrow – now today. Where, I wondered, where had she gone? And who with?

I don't risk walking up and peering through the windows. I don't need to; after all, I'll be in there in . . . I check my watch – half an hour.

I go into Fortunes and find myself surrounded by other people. Lots of women, a whole gaggle of them at a nearby table with buggies perched alongside them. I feel a pang as I watch them, talking, laughing, drinking coffee. That should have been me and her.

I check Charlie, who is still soundly asleep.

I order a sandwich while we wait, then Charlie wakes up, announcing it to all of us with a loud bellow. I feed her underneath a muslin cloth at the table. The mum gaggle finishes, pays in a protracted, complicated fashion, each covering their own bill, which involves sums and laughter.

Eventually, it is just me and the bored-looking teenager behind the counter. I order an espresso, wishing for something stronger but grateful for a caffeine hit as the fatigue reaches out to me with long, cloying fingers.

I wheel Charlie into the toilet, splash cold water on my face and scowl at my reflection in the mirror. My eyes are dark-ringed, my hair, newly washed, already a frizzy mess. I rummage around in my handbag and pull out my pocket foundation, swiping it over my face, adding mascara and lip gloss, shoving a chewing gum in my too-dry mouth. Slightly better, but do I look like the kind of woman who could afford a house on this road? It will have to do.

The estate agent seems impossibly young. His hair is set in an impressive quiff, trousers rolled up at the ends, revealing bare ankles and soft loafers. He is sugar-sweet and gives me a huge smile as I walk up, pushing Charlie in front of me. I say, 'Can I leave the buggy here?' as he opens the door.

'Yes, of course.'

I tie her to my body in the contraption that I'd initially scoffed at but which is actually proving to be endlessly useful. It's like a back-to-front

knapsack which she slots into, body pressed to mine. I feel a twinge of pain as she crushes up against my heavy breasts, already starting to refill with her next feed.

‘How old?’ he asks me.

‘Almost two months.’

‘Ah,’ he says and I nod, smiling, though I suspect a man his age has little interest in babies. ‘This would be a great house to grow up in!’

‘Yes,’ I agree, taking in the hallway. It would be. It is a stunning property. My eyes flick to a low radiator as we walk in, covered tastefully, a series of photos along its top. I feel my breath catch in my throat as I take them in.

Rebecca, younger then, with a rounder face, and an older man, her father. I’d seen his pictures in his obituary. I follow the estate agent down the hallway, passing a few small paintings, modern, unusual and tasteful.

The kitchen is incredible. Newly fitted with an old-world feel, large bifold doors giving a view of a garden too big for this close to the city. ‘Wow,’ I say, looking out.

‘I know, and there’s another building at the back of the garden – are you okay to walk over to it?’

I indicate that I am and we head out. The sweat has cooled on my body now and the autumn air creeping in bites me cold and sharp. I wonder if the estate agent’s bare ankles are chilly.

The building is an outside office complete with a toilet. ‘Wow,’ I say again. ‘Does the owner work from here?’

‘Yes,’ he says. ‘Though between you and me, I think she inherited the place.’

‘Has she raised children here, do you know?’ I ask what I hope is a reasonable question.

‘No. I’ve only just taken over this particular sale but from what I gather, she’s single. No kids.’

I swallow thickly. My heart thudding. *Single. No kids.*

I think of us sitting side by side at the lake, watching the birds glide past us, our bellies protruding.

‘How long has the house been on the market?’

‘Literally just agreed it last week, you’re only the third viewing. But I reckon it will go fast. The owner has no onward chain to consider.’

‘So she can sell in a hurry?’

‘Yeah, I suppose so, and I get the impression that’s her preference. She

said she's relocating.'

'Anywhere nice?' As we're leaving the office I see a business card on the edge of the desk: *Rebecca Dalston*, a string of impressive letters after her name. There is an office landline, a mobile number and an email address. When the agent turns to lead us out I put my hand on the card, sliding it to me and slipping it between my daughter's warm little body and my sore, aching breasts.

'She didn't specify, just said further away from the city.' He shrugs. 'She said she was taking a break from work. So I suppose she doesn't need access to London. This is classic commuter belt, isn't it? Perfect for someone like you, young family and all.'

I nod, smiling my agreement, not bothering to point out that hardly any 'young families' could afford a two-up, two-down these days, let alone a sprawling four-bedroom house like this. As we go round I half listen to his patter, far more interested in the decor, the knick-knacks, the books that populate the shelves, and of course, the photos. Some of Rebecca at what I assume are work functions, lots with her dad, a young widower. I imagine her growing up without a mother; did it impact her the same way growing up without a father had impacted me? Sole heir, the articles had said, so no siblings. There are photos of her in school uniform, the expensive kind, straw hat with ribbon around it, stiff blazers, smart shoes. Rebecca through the years: a shiny, pretty little girl; a beautiful, accomplished-looking young woman.

In her bedroom – the master suite, impressive and resplendent, complete with a balcony where you can see most of London in the distance – there is an image in a frame on her dressing table. Her smiling face, pleasantly tanned, sun beaming down on her, her arm flung over the shoulders of a smaller girl who looks to be about the same age. Fair where Rebecca is dark. A friend? She must be a good friend, perhaps even a best friend to hold pride of place here, in the room she slept in. I feel a stab of jealousy and realise I've missed what the agent has been saying.

'Sorry, what?'

'There are another three bedrooms,' he tells me, opening the door on another one, smaller than the master and clearly a guest room. Bed, bedside tables, drawers, a slim wardrobe. 'The other two are empty.'

'Empty?'

He nods. 'Yeah. No furniture even.' He shows me another two good-sized

rooms exactly as he's described. This house, I think, is too big for just her and there are no signs at all that anyone else has ever lived here.

'Be perfect for you with a growing family.'

'It would.' I try to imagine us here, me, Dan, Charlie. I can't picture it though.

At the front door he hands me his card and I take it, smiling, pushing it into the baby bag as I untangle myself from Charlie, placing her little body in the soft blankets and slipping Rebecca's business card into my handbag along with the estate agent's details.

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REBECCA

Five months ago

Rebecca has stopped going to Fortunes, she's stopped going to Rizzo's for catch-up dinners with her team and she's stopped going into the office. Her house is spacious and beautiful, but she finds herself going stir crazy in it on her own.

The thing is, now there is really no question that she is pregnant. Her stomach protrudes and, she notes, the rest of her has thickened too; even her face has filled out and she has almost three months left to go.

Her phone rings. 'Hey,' she says, her voice warm, grateful for the contact, even as she feels the usual flush of anxiety. What mood will greet her?

'Hey, yourself, and hey to our little bundle.' Happy, upbeat. Rebecca feels herself relax slightly.

'Not so little any more. I'm the size of a house and look awful.'

'You do not, you could never look awful.'

Rebecca laughs. 'Thanks, but you haven't seen me recently.'

'And I've said sorry for it a million times.' Voice sharp now; Rebecca's heart picks up pace at the change in tone.

'Yeah, no, I was just saying. I didn't mean anything by it other than, you know, I miss you.'

'I miss you too,' comes straight back and Rebecca releases her caught breath, glad to have the conversation back on track. 'I'll be over as soon as I can be.'

'I can't wait,' Rebecca says, wondering if she means it. Yes, she thinks, of course she does, not least because she's longing for company.

'Me neither. And really, I'm sure you look beautiful, Bex.'

‘Thanks, but I feel like a blimp. I need to get out and walk more, I think.’

‘Be careful though.’

‘Yes, I know,’ she says, her voice slightly harder than she means it to be. ‘I understand,’ she adds, softening her tone. Used to this long, intense relationship and knowing that generally she’ll catch more flies with honey.

‘I’m going to drive across town to Meadsvale Park.’

‘That’s a good idea.’

‘Yes, I know, the woods at the end of the road are far nicer but . . .’

‘No, that wouldn’t be sensible. Even Meadsvale is pushing it actually.’

‘So, what – you’re saying I can’t go?’

‘No. Just . . . be careful.’

‘I will,’ she says, teeth clenched as she feels the strange squirm of the child within and shifts herself on the pale white sofa that she now makes quite the dent in.

‘I know. Sorry. And you’re right, exercise will be good for the baby. And you.’

‘Yes,’ she says, unreasonably annoyed that the baby is being considered first, then chastising herself mentally. That is, of course, exactly how it should be. ‘Are *you* okay?’ Rebecca asks.

That’s met with a sigh. ‘I’ll be better when we’re together again.’

‘Me too,’ Rebecca says, not adding that she’s horribly lonely because – what can be done after all?

‘I’ve got to go.’

‘Okay, take care . . .’ But the call is ended before she finishes the last word.

Dan gets home late. He finds both Charlie and me asleep, Charlie in her basket, me sitting upright on the sofa.

‘Come on,’ he says as I blink into consciousness, my neck aching from the position I’d been in, eyes burning with not enough sleep. He takes my hand, leading me upstairs, tucking me into our bed as one might a small child. He must do the night feeds because I don’t wake until 6 a.m. He comes in, carrying Charlie on his hip, a cup of coffee in the other hand. ‘She only woke up once,’ he says, triumphant. ‘There was enough expressed milk in the fridge.’

‘Thank you,’ I say, my chest sore and full of milk from the missed feed, but the rest of me feeling almost brand new. ‘I must have been exhausted.’

‘Yes, and you don’t need to thank me, I was glad to leave you sleeping. Though I do need to get going now, I’m afraid.’

I frown. ‘It’s so early.’

‘I know but I’m presenting at nine.’

‘Oh yes, of course. Good luck,’ I manage, sipping the coffee, tucking Charlie into me and lifting my top while she latches on. The milk flows and I start to feel the relieved ache as the weight of my breasts becomes less.

After he is gone, I open Facebook, go onto Izzy’s page. There are pictures of her at a large, glitzy event, now the intrepid PR. She always seems to be off somewhere glamorous and wonderful. Max has liked the post and written beneath, *Smashing it!* with a fist bump and a heart emoji.

I put my phone down, focus on feeding Charlie, then I hold her, waiting for her to drift off. When she does, I shower, dress, do my make-up. By the time I’m finished she’s awake and I try to feed her again, though increasingly she is turning down this feed. They change so fast, my mum had said, and I’d nodded, smiled, thinking, I have a good routine, thanks. But she’s right. It seems that as soon as I’ve settled Charlie into any sort of pattern, she disrupts it almost immediately.

I express the feed while she coos on the playmat. I put it into a bottle, lid on. I'll probably have to stop in Fortunes for her lunch, but I'm sure the waitress I've sort of befriended will heat it up for me.

Nicole, her name is. I've got to know her quite well over the past week and a half as Charlie and I are there most days, Charlie cooing in her pram or a highchair. Me, eyes glued to Alpine Close, waiting, waiting, waiting.

Dan has asked a few times now how I'm finding the days. I've told him I've found a local café where lots of mums hang out with their small ones and he's held on to that as good news. Great news even. I'm not at the point where I've had to fabricate names and people yet, but I feel like it's looming. I'm careful to pay in cash while I'm there, though every time I take money out, it makes my heart pound and my palms sweat, the quickly dwindling amount bringing a rise of anxiety, and this is while I'm on full maternity pay. When I met Dan, I had several maxed-out credit cards. Half the reason our little cottage on Sandcross Lane is in his name is because of my appalling credit. After the whole Max and Izzy thing, I hadn't started drinking or smoking or anything. I hadn't even rushed headfirst into ill-advised romantic entanglements. I had started ordering things I didn't need online.

I didn't wrack up serious damage but it was enough to tip me into poor credit and a period of having to watch every single penny. It's sorted now, Dan helped me set up payment plans and covered them more than once when I couldn't. I'm glad to be free of debt, but I can see how easy it would be to step back into that cycle. Often at three in the morning, I find myself googling clothes I don't need, clicking fast on secret purchases that I hurry to collect from lockers outside our local Morrisons. I end up returning ninety per cent of the things I buy and honestly could save myself the hassle by just not doing it.

'Do you want another coffee, Ali?' Nicole asks. I turn to her with a smile and almost say yes then a blur of red catches my eye outside. That distinctive Mulberry handbag that I'd admired on more than one occasion. 'No – thanks, though,' I say, standing in a hurry, quickly checking Charlie's straps and rushing outside.

'Rebecca,' I call, as I draw up close behind her. She turns round, half jumping out of her skin, pressing a hand to her chest.

'Sorry,' I say, ever so slightly out of breath, a reminder that months on, my body is still not fully recovered from the arduous task of childbirth. 'I didn't

mean to startle you.'

'You again, are you . . .' She looks around us, eyes searching furtively. 'Following me?'

I laugh. 'No. Of course not. It's just you recommended Fortunes, remember?' I'd decided to just act normal, not make a big thing out of the last time I saw her. Hoping this might be an opportunity for her to tell me what the hell had been going on. I didn't want her to think I was angry about it. I wasn't. I was concerned.

Her frown deepens. 'I'm sure I asked you when you turned up on my doorstep to leave me alone.'

'But . . .'

She takes a step closer, a frown making her face look hard and threatening. I instinctively pull the pushchair back a step.

'I have no idea who you are or what you want, but if you keep harassing me . . .'

'Harassing . . .' The word comes out in a sort of strangled laugh.

'Yes, this is harassment.' Her voice is firmer now, stronger, gaining certainty. 'And if I see you again, I will not hesitate to call the police.'

'Rebecca,' I say, my voice thin and forlorn as she walks away. Back ramrod straight, head held high. Her hard-heeled boots clattering on the pavement. 'Rebecca . . .'

But she is gone. I stay there, standing mute and stupid for seconds . . . minutes? Remembering the time I stood at the window of my tiny room in my crappy student houseshare, watching Max walk down the road, a spring in his step as my world crashed down around me.

By the time I get in, Charlie's faint whimpering has turned into loud, tragic bellows. She is hungry, I have missed her feed by half an hour. The bottle of expressed milk was probably only half a feed at best.

I grab her from the pushchair, my own face damp and cold with the tears that had come as we'd walked back. I slide off my shoes, wriggle out of my coat, settling us both onto the sofa. I clamp her to me and she drinks so hard and so fast that the usual sharp but bearable pinch is agony and I pull her off, snapping, 'Stop it.' She responds by nuzzling in again.

When she is finally latched on I pick up my phone, dragging my handbag to me. The number on Rebecca's business card is different to the mobile number I have. I call it now. Her voice, more serious than I'm used to hear-

ing it but without the white-hot rage she'd shown me earlier. 'I won't be taking work calls for at least the next six months. Please do phone directly into the office in my absence.' I scramble in my bag for a pen, writing the office number on my hand in red biro. Then I dial it.

'Hello, Dalston's Family Law.'

I look down at Charlie suckling, oblivious to my distress, eyes closed, long, pretty eyelashes pressed against her chubby, silk-soft cheeks.

'Hello. I was wondering if I might pop in for some legal advice?'

'Yes, of course. Can I ask what it's regarding?'

'Um, sure. My husband and I are, um, considering divorce, I'd like to talk over my options. Please,' I add, guilt flooding through me at the lie.

I get booked in for Monday morning. I give the name Isobel Jenkins, which gives me a moment of supreme satisfaction that wears off almost as soon as I hang up the call. Charlie fusses, I swaddle her tightly and put her in her swing. When she is finally asleep I go and stand outside in our garden, taking in huge lungfuls of fresh, clear air. I tell myself to inhale, exhale, count my breaths, and I feel my body at least softening, even if my mind is still a hard whirring stone, intent on beating me to death.

It had crossed my mind initially that perhaps Rebecca had a twin. That was possible, wasn't it? But it was her in the articles; she'd lied about her job, or at least withheld the truth. Was she lying about being married? No wedding photos in that house. Not a single one.

It wasn't mistaken identity; of that I was sure. I may not have known Rebecca long, but I recognised her mannerisms. Plus, she had answered to Rebecca. She lived in the right area, had the same bag. It was her, obviously. The woman I'd sat and had coffee with. The woman who'd fast become my friend. I hadn't imagined it, of course I hadn't. Though my brain slips slightly, taking me back to the days, weeks, months after Max and Izzy when my grip on myself, my grip on sanity, had felt slippery at times. I'd been doped up to the eyeballs, of course. A fat prescription of antidepressants and sleeping tablets doled out after a perfunctory ten-minute appointment. They were handed to me to treat a chemical imbalance no one could check for or prove. Modern medicine as ill-equipped as ever to treat that terrible reality of the human condition – a broken heart.

I call my mum.

'Hello, Alison.'

'Hi, Mum.'

‘How are you?’

‘Okay here.’

‘And that gorgeous baby?’

A smile I wasn’t sure I was capable of spreads across my face, standing out here in the peace of the garden, baby monitor attached to my belt, through it the soft, rhythmic sound of her breathing.

‘She is still gorgeous.’

‘Ah,’ my mother says and I imagine us sharing the same feeling down the phone line, my tiny daughter pulling us closer in a way that nothing else ever has.

‘When can I see her again? And you, of course,’ she adds hastily.

I’m still smiling when I say, ‘Actually I was hoping you might be able to watch her for an hour or so on Monday?’

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People don't realise it, but a prolonged lack of sleep can kill you. I am wide awake. Outside, it is dark. In the next room, my husband snores softly. A few feet away from me, Charlie inhales and exhales, her delicate, fragile chest rising and falling. Every half an hour I kind of doze off and come to in a panicked start, rising to check on her by the faint glow of the night light. On my 3.30 a.m. check I can't tell if she's breathing or not and fear rushes around my body making my heart pound. I rummage about in the drawer next to my bed, pulling out a compact and holding the mirror above my daughter's face. She snuffles in response and I am weak with relief. The imprint of her breath pressed against the small glass circle. I stand for I don't know how long, hand limp at my side, the pressed powder, unused since I bought it, a reminder of my working life when a full face of make-up was required every day.

She is fine, Charlie. I tug the baby monitor off the wall, taking the portable half downstairs with me, closing the door and putting the TV on a low volume. It's no use though, nothing on the screen distracts me. I flick through Netflix, but there's nothing there that will send me off to sleep. I curl up on the sofa anyway, pulling a large furry throw off the back of it, wrapping it around my body. I'm pumped full of adrenaline that rushes through my veins like a train. My heart pounds so fast I swear I can't catch my breath. I sit up, taking in jagged, deep breaths of air until my pulse slows and I can breathe properly again. Every time I blink it feels like my eyelids are opening and closing over grit.

I put the kettle on, open my laptop and sit down. At some point, my body must give up because that's the last thing I remember as I feel warm fingers on my shoulder and I jump up, hands raised in . . . I don't know what.

'Ali?' Dan's face is folded in concern, a deep crater between his eyes, which I suppose one day will become permanent.

'Charlie?' I say, clutching for the baby monitor only to find it's by the sofa.

I am sitting at the little table where we eat our meals. ‘Dan?’

‘Ali, are you okay?’

‘Yeah, no.’ I rub at my face. Everything kind of aches; even my skin feels sore. ‘Sorry, I couldn’t sleep.’

‘You were asleep at the table.’

I press a hand to my cheek, which feels tender to touch. My laptop sits in front of me – open on my secondary Instagram account. I must have been looking at Izzy or Max, though my memory feels vague and uncatchable. I shut the lid. ‘Where’s the baby?’

‘Sleeping still. Ali, this isn’t good; if you don’t get some rest you’ll go mad.’

Mad. I hate that word so much. I force myself to smile at him. ‘I’m fine. I got up to feed her then my brain sort of kicked in.’ I laugh, trying to make light of my awful state of my mind in the dark, small hours when it feels like I might be the only person in the world.

Dan has a long-planned football match with some of his mates. ‘I can cancel,’ he says.

‘No,’ I insist, ‘you can’t. I’ll be fine, honestly.’

‘Are you sure?’

‘Yes,’ I say, forcing a smile.

When he’s gone, I shower and drink half a pot of coffee before Charlie wakes at seven thirty, her hungry bellows stretching across the landing and grabbing me.

‘It’s okay, baby,’ I say over and over as I get her small, warm body from the crib, my hand cupped beneath her bottom. I change her, feed her and get her dressed for the day.

Tomorrow, I’ll go to Rebecca’s law firm. I don’t know why, but surely I’ll be able to learn something. I go over my story in my mind, imagining myself smiling, shiny – ‘Hi, I’m Isobel Jenkins.’ For a second I imagine that’s the case and wonder how she feels. If Max makes her happy. If the new business is as challenging and exciting as it looks. People only ever put their best selves forward on social media, of course, but Izzy has always had a way of sailing through life, unruffled by its challenges.

I put Charlie in her pram, pushing her out of the house, walking mindlessly along familiar roads, until I realise too late that I am heading towards Alpine Close. Towards Rebecca. I am close to the end of her road.

‘Ali?’ I think I am imagining her voice at first and almost just carry on walking.

‘Al?’

I turn around and here she is. Not in a tiny box on a far too pretty to be real grid, not a faint memory tinged with pain, but here, standing in front of me on a street we have walked down together so many times I couldn’t begin to add them up.

‘Izzy.’

She’s now looking down at the buggy, her eyes wide. ‘Oh my God,’ she says and I almost smile. Her familiar voice speaking those familiar words. We’ve said them to each other so many times about so many things.

‘So beautiful, it is a girl?’ Her eyes reach mine, eyebrows raised, a small twitch at the corner of her mouth which tells me she’s nervous. Because that’s how well I know her, inside out and back to front. As well as I know myself. Or knew.

‘Yes. Charlie,’ I say. My voice is surprisingly calm despite the sleep-deprived thoughts whirling around in my brain.

‘Oh wow, like your cat.’ I wince; is she mocking me? ‘Congratulations.’ And now she is smiling properly, eyes crinkling at the sides.

I nod, lips pressed together for fear of the poisonous words that might come spilling out of me.

‘Your mum said you were expecting.’

I nod again.

‘And married too?’

‘Yes. Dan, I met him . . . well, just after I came back to London.’

‘I’m happy for you,’ she says, her voice so warm it makes my insides judder.

‘Mum said you’d set up a business?’

She frowns. ‘Yes, well, I figured working for myself might be better than working for someone else. It’s a hard slog though.’

‘Just you?’

‘Oh no, with a colleague of mine from Trace.’

‘And you’re still with Max?’

Her face flushes then and I feel a moment’s petty pleasure. I force a tight smile. ‘Well, anyway.’ I put my hands on the pushchair and move, walking away.

‘Ali?’

I think about carrying on, just walking. But curiosity wins out and I pause, turn. Our eyes meet. Hers shiny, mine hard – I hope – but maybe not. Maybe they show the memories I still have of her. Of us. Maybe she sees written all over my face the pain she'd caused, that had diminished me even further, from the girl who happily lived in her shadow, to no one at all.

'What?'

'I never meant to hurt you. *We* never meant to.'

'Right.'

'But you're married now, you have a baby. Surely you know that you and Max weren't really suited?'

'Whereas you were?'

'Well, yes. If you remember, Ali, I liked him first.'

I make a scoffing sound. 'You pointed out a fit guy across a crowded bar.'

'Yes. *I* pointed him out.'

'I dated him. I lived with him and you . . . you . . .'

My voice trails off. The night we met Max is hazy. Izzy had been visiting me at my uni. We'd got chatting to him and a few of his friends whose names I forget and who I never saw again. Then we'd all gone our separate ways. He to his place, Izzy and I to mine. She had gone on about him, I do remember that, but so what? *Oh wow, that guy is so hot*, is hardly ownership, is it? I saw him on campus a few days later and we hit it off. He did ask after Izzy, my 'partner in crime', but it felt like flirting. It *was* flirting.

'You're right, of course,' she says now. 'And there's no excuse as such. It wasn't . . . good, what we did, but we do love each other, surely that counts for something?'

I narrow my eyes at her. *We love each other*. They must have loved each other a lot more than they loved me. 'What are you even doing here?' I ask.

'Here?'

'Home, here, you live in central London, right?'

'Oh, yes.' My face heats – did Mum tell me this or I did I see that on her social media? 'Mum's, ah, not been so well, so I'm staying for a while. Renting a little place near here in fact.'

'Oh,' I say. 'Sorry to hear that.' I liked Izzy's mum a lot and the two of them were very close, something else I used to envy.

'Thanks.'

'I do need to go,' I say, my voice a little softer. 'She'll wake up to feed soon.'

‘Oh, yeah, no, of course, and really, Al, congratulations, she is beautiful.’
‘Thanks.’

As she walks away, I realise that we are quite far away from her parents’ house. We are, in fact, closer to Rebecca’s house than her parents’ or mine. A mad thought crosses my mind, which I try to dismiss as paranoia, but I can’t shake it. How long has Izzy been back? Is it possible she *knows* Rebecca? She’s staying near here, after all, and Rebecca is glossy, confident – just like Izzy. I imagine Izzy poisoning my new friend against me, just as she did Max. I picture the two of them, sniggering about poor friendless Ali who can’t take a hint. It’s crazy, I know, and yet . . .

I stand still, contemplating this, my hands clasped to the buggy as red-hot jealous thoughts pulsate round my brain.

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REBECCA

Four months ago

It is a blazing summer and, Rebecca thinks, the first one she's ever spent the entirety of in England. Not that she has, yet. The summer isn't over; it's barely getting started. That thought makes her pause, pressing a swollen hand to her aching lower back, feeling sweat pool beneath her breasts, which are held up in a concrete-style maternity bra. Sweat also pools in the crack in her bum. Pregnancy, she has decided, is not glamorous. In fact, she'd go so far as to say, it is a fairly disgusting state to be in. Though she'd be lying if she didn't admit, at least to herself, that the greatness of it, the enormity of housing a growing life, definitely outweighs the physical horrors. She's sleeping well again and that has helped her mood, but without work to distract her, her brain has gone into overdrive. Every mistake she's made, every bad decision, driving herself crazy with what ifs. Could she have got here, to this place she wanted to be so badly, a different way? An easier way? Well, the answer is obviously a resounding yes. And Rebecca is used to having it easy. Accustomed to the many privileges that money could buy. Not just money, but knowledge and education too. She'd had plenty of step-ups at work via her father's connections. She was good at what she did, great even, and had been an excellent student, but she had also inherited well, holidayed well, done everything well.

Except marriage, of course, that was the part of the dream she hadn't exactly got right. She'd been alone for most of the pregnancy but finally, last week, the company she'd been longing for had arrived at the house. She'd been giddy with excitement; words scribbled in hasty texts and spoken softly in middle-of-the-night phone calls were finally, finally going to be

face to face. It hadn't ended well though. In fact there had been an argument that had gone on for a whole day. Her hands reach up to touch the ring of bruises on her arm as she remembers it. Hot anger volleyed back and forth. Then tears and finally the sorrys. On both parts. It's a stressful time, she knows that, thank goodness it's coming to an end. They'd agreed to stay apart for now, until it was safe, but it won't be long now.

She sits on the bench, wondering if soon she'll get to a point where she daren't sit in case she can't get up again. The thought makes her smile.

In front of her a tiny boy bobbles along towards the water. He is in a puffy coat that makes his arm stick out to the sides despite the reasonably warm weather. He is also on some sort of lead, reins, she thinks they're called, held by a blonde woman whose eyes are only on him. Behind the woman a tall man has his hand pressed into the small of her back, his eyes also on the boy. The boy throws something from his hands, seeds, she guesses, and squeals in delight as various birds waddle out to devour them.

He's adorable. The parents are adorable, swapping smiles now with each other. The boy repeats this a few times, grabbing handfuls of food from a bag the man holds out. Five, maybe ten minutes. The man swoops the boy up, smothering his little face with kisses, and the woman watches the scene softly. As they pass Rebecca the woman's eyes catch hers and she beams, eyes going from her belly to face. 'How long have you got?'

'Two months roughly,' Rebecca says. Her voice comes out croaky and she thinks it's probably because she hasn't used it properly for . . . days perhaps?

'Ahh,' the woman says. 'You'll love it.'

'Yes; thanks.' Rebecca places a hand on the top of her bump and feels a responding wriggle from within. She has spoken to the baby but she uses a sing-song hushed tone with them. Is it a sort of madness, she wonders? Is she really talking to herself?

'See you,' the woman says, the man nodding and the toddler boy yelling, 'Bye bye,' with a hand clench that makes them all laugh. Then they are gone and she is here, alone again. Alone as usual. The baby squirms. 'Okay,' she tells them, 'not completely alone.'

She gets up, ungainly but who cares, and heads to her car. She's not much prone to melancholy, a practical person by nature, but she feels wistful after seeing the little family.

Back in the house the silence feels deafening and ominous. She switches the radio on but finds she can't really focus. Her mind wandering back to the happy little family, the beautiful tableau that she feels such a rush for. She herself hadn't had that growing up, her mother a distant memory. Her father loving but often bewildered. She's in the process of packing things now, moving paperwork into boxes which are going into storage. She comes across a thick pack of old revision papers and smiles at the memories they hold.

'Your daddy is very clever,' she tells the bump, hand resting beneath it. 'Whatever else, he has always been smart and you will be too, my darling.'

She's anxious. She knows that, recognises the feeling from days long gone. Anxiety for Rebecca hits her stomach first every time and she's unsure at this point how much of her nausea is hormonal and how much of it is mental.

She had wanted this, God knows she'd longed for a child so much that, at times, it was an almost physical pain. Now, she finds herself worrying needlessly about all the things that might go wrong. Which isn't like her. Rebecca prides herself on her calmness. It makes her impenetrable and in demand in her working life. She is cool, unruffled, not easily spooked.

In the dark, lonely hours of the mornings now though, she finds she is not so brave. Not so stoic.

She picks up her phone, looks at it, thinks of sending a message. But what would she say? *I can't sleep. I'm lonely. I'm scared.* The message would perhaps be answered if it was actually received, but it carried risks.

Ones she can't afford to take. Ones *they* can't afford to take.

She puts it down. She has to stay strong, to stick to the plan. She must do this part alone.

‘Where are you going?’ Mum asks me.

‘Just to look round the shops, not that I can afford anything.’ I laugh, picturing the stashed bags of clothes which I need to return. I’ll make another trip for that.

‘I remember those years,’ she says and I check her face for a dig, but she’s still smiling at Charlie while she says it, and making cooing noises.

‘She’s getting much better with the bottle,’ I tell her.

‘That’s brilliant news, Ali, and means you can take a welcome break, eh?’

‘Thanks, Mum,’ I manage, meaning it.

She frowns at me. ‘Are you alright?’

I blink, forcing a chuckle. ‘Yes. God. I think so, just exhausted,’ I tell her, and that much is true. I am a wreck. The fatigue is like nothing I’ve ever experienced, thick and full, making me erratic and punch drunk.

‘Should you really be going out? I can always take her for a walk, or to mine even. You could sleep.’ For a second, maybe two, I consider that, the thought of swapping my clothes for soft flannel pyjamas, slipping under our heavy feather duvet and pulling the blankets up over my head. I could forget all about Rebecca Dalston, Max and Izzy, and just focus on this, my little family. It is so seductive, so tempting, but . . . those bruises on her arm, her face when she saw me before she denied who she was . . . she *had* recognised me, she knew full well who I was, which meant she was definitely lying. About something so fundamental, so obvious. But why?

I think again of Izzy. Of course I’ve already trawled her social media for signs that she knows Rebecca and I found nothing. But this doesn’t prove anything; they are practically neighbours after all. I push the thought away; this isn’t about Izzy, it’s about Rebecca. What if she’s in trouble? What if she lost the baby? As the awful possibility crosses my mind, I know I can’t let this rest. Whatever’s going on, I have to help, because that’s what friends do, isn’t it? And she was the first friend I’d had since Izzy, a reminder of

how much I missed that sort of companionship.

‘I’ll be fine,’ I tell Mum with a too bright smile that makes my cheeks ache.

I feel almost as if I’m heading off to work and I try to picture that. Charlie being, what . . . six months old? Nine maybe if we could eke out the money?

I put the address for Rebecca’s legal practice into my satnav and as I start the descent into London I wish I’d got the train. Tiredness makes the busy, rage-laden and rain-lashed roads even more treacherous. I’m relieved when I finally park, though my relief turns to horror at the cost. I use one of my own credit cards, mentally trying to add up how much I’ve spent this month, but my sums feel incoherent and slosh around my brain like soup.

I’ll deal with it later.

The practice is inside what must once have been a beautiful house and has a cosy, comfortable feel. It’s quiet, just myself and the receptionist in the waiting area, and I find myself settled into a too-soft sofa which I struggle to get up from when a lawyer, who introduces herself as Ruth Anderson, comes to collect me, warm smile in place, firm handshake given. ‘They’re almost too good to leave, aren’t they?’

I look at her quizzically.

‘The sofas,’ she says.

‘Oh. Yes,’ I manage with a stilted laugh.

‘Come through, Mrs Jenkins.’

‘Izzy, please.’

‘Izzy then.’

She is calm, smooth, gives me a spiel about knowing how difficult this must be for me. I nod along in agreement.

‘So what seems to be the issue?’

‘I think he’s cheating.’ My voice catches on the last word. I am not having to act now. The pain of it still as fresh as if it had been yesterday rather than seven years ago.

‘With my friend,’ I add.

‘Oh goodness. I’m so sorry.’

I nod. Go through the dishonest story that a horrible part of me hopes could be Izzy’s if she and Max get married, which, according to Facebook, is looking likely.

My free half-hour is coming to an end. Ruth pauses, head tilted in sympathy, and says, 'You have a good case, Izzy, and I'm certain that we can make this as fast and hassle-free as possible.'

I nod, wondering if now with no-fault divorces being quicker than ever, their business is at risk.

She tells me their fees and I manage to keep my face expressionless and impassive though they are shocking hourly rates. 'Can I think about it all?' I ask her, pleased when my voice remains calm and steady.

'Of course, please do. These aren't decisions to be taken lightly.' She tilts her head slightly, a perfect expression of sympathy and one she must make dozens of times a day.

'Thank you,' I manage. My heart picks up a little and as we stand and I'm about to head out I say, 'Oh, by the way, I couldn't help noticing the name Rebecca Dalston on the door?'

'Yes, she owns the firm. Do you know her?'

'Well, I did, many years ago. We, uh, went to school together.'

'Ah, you're an Oakwood girl too, are you?'

I nod, excruciatingly aware that neither my voice, clothes nor manner scream the sort of education that Rebecca had. But Ruth seems to accept the lie, and why wouldn't she? 'Is she in today?' I ask.

'Oh, no, I'm afraid not.' She lowers her voice and says, 'Between you and me, she's not overly involved. There's even talk she might be selling.'

'Oh?'

'Yes. Quite the surprise, to be honest. It was her father's practice and well, if you know Rebecca you'll know how close they were.'

'Yes. With it just being the two of them, I suppose they would be. Is she still in London, do you know?'

'She's in the suburbs, but actually in the process of relocating to Sussex, big changes. Not sure what caused it. I've not seen her for a long time and was just glad to find out I'll be being handed over if she does sell, so I'll get to stay here no matter what. Which sounds horribly selfish, but it's a lovely place to work. Despite the nature of our business,' she adds at the end, as if remembering who she's confiding in.

'She never married, did she, or had children?'

Ruth gives me a rueful smile. 'No, she always joked this job was enough to put her off for life!' I force a chuckle at that. No wealthy husband, she is not a housewife, her colleagues knew nothing of her pregnancy. Did Joshua

even exist? 'It's not for everyone, is it?'

'No, probably not,' I say, then ask, 'When did you last see her?'

'Oh wow, I mean it must be a year almost, maybe ten months or so, a while.'

'That's a long time.'

'Yes.' She smiles and I feel I'm at my question limit now. Ten months ago. She would have been pregnant but not showing. This confirms to me what I already knew. Rebecca had been pregnant, but she'd gone to great lengths to hide that fact.

'Shall I message her, say you popped in and pass on your details?'

'Oh. No, no, thank you. I'll drop her an email myself at some point when things settle down. I'd rather you didn't at the moment. It's a delicate situation with my husband.' Not that Rebecca knew me as Izzy Jenkins, but she might put two and two together. My heart hammers as I think about how I bumped into Izzy just seconds away from Rebecca's house. Coincidence? I wasn't sure. I shouldn't have used her name, I think, though it's too late now.

I leave the office on shaky legs, my lies making me light-headed. But I have found things out. Rebecca had left her business; she was in the process of leaving her house. She'd been planning this for ages and it looks to me like she had hidden her pregnancy. But why?

By the time I get to my car, I collapse in the front seat. Shrugging out of my jacket, I see the wet patch blossoming on my chest. Charlie. My baby will be hungry by now, and I'm here pretending to be a woman I had once loved and now hated, trying to track down someone I thought was my friend who I seemingly know nothing about. I drive home, jumping at every beep and jeer as I go. My mum answers the door and I promptly burst into tears.

I'm woken by the ringing of my phone and come to with a start, grabbing it frowning, my thoughts thick and gloopy. I'm at home; I'd come in, I remember crying, Mum hugging me. I had fed Charlie then Mum had sent me to bed. I'd gone, telling her I'd never sleep, I couldn't sleep, but I must have.

'Hello?'

'Izzy?'

'Yes.'

'It's Ruth Anderson.'

'Oh,' I say, panic washing over me. 'Is everything alright?' I ask.

'Yes, I just wanted to let you know that you left your umbrella here yesterday.' *Yesterday*. I flick a glance at the alarm clock. 8 a.m. I have slept all evening, all night.

'Right.' I pause, then say, 'I'll, er, come and collect it sometime soon,' though I have no intention of doing so. The stark realisation that I shouldn't have been there had settled over me like a cape on the drive home. The one small lie leading to bigger lies. Dishonesty, deceit, the polluters of happy relationships. I should know.

I mumble a goodbye, hanging up just as the bedroom door creaks open.

Dan.

'Ali?'

'I overslept,' I say.

'You did; I think you must have needed it.'

I nod, swallowing thickly, hands pressed to my forehead, memories of confiding in Izzy about Max: 'He's changed,' I'd told her. 'I don't know what I've done.' 'I'm sure you haven't done anything,' she'd said, knowing full well that was the case, knowing exactly what the matter with him was.

'Are you feeling unwell?' Dan asks me now and I am pulled back here to this moment with this man who treats me like I'm spun gold even when I

don't deserve it. Who was exactly the breath of fresh air I had always needed.

I shake my head and the room spins. 'Actually, I've got an awful headache,' I tell him.

'I'll bring you up some paracetamol.'

'Is Charlie okay?'

'Yes, she's fine, your mum's going to come over again this afternoon and help you out. Last night on her way home she says she got some ready-made formula. I'll bring the baby up for a feed now but you need rest. I'll do the night feed tonight.'

I start to shake my head; articles about the perils of formula-fed babies and large print pamphlets with 'BREAST IS BEST' in aggressive capital letters springing to the forefront of my mind.

'I will,' he says firmly.

'What if she won't take the breast again?' I ask.

He shrugs. 'Then she'll be formula fed.' And the possibilities of that sit before me like a dream. The late-night shopping, drinking decaf coffee at 1, 2 a.m. Perhaps without the disruption, there'd be no more lying awake cooned in guilt about the odd glass of wine, the lack of vegetables, the junk food I'd consumed during the day. Plus, I'd be free to be out for more than forty minutes at a time. I'd be free to sleep for six, maybe even eight unbroken hours once in a while.

'Okay,' I manage, everything hitting me. The stupidity of my actions, going into Rebecca's practice pretending to be Izzy. My search for the truth making me lie to Dan and my mum.

I feed Charlie, Dan watching from the mirror as he does up his tie, smooths down his hair with wax. Looking at me head tilted, concern etched across his face. 'I'm okay,' I tell him, 'just tired.'

'I'll book some time off,' he says.

'There's no need.'

'I know, but you're exhausted.'

I can't argue with that; I am bone-achingly tired. I say, 'I think you were right about Rebecca.' My voice trembles slightly.

'Oh?'

I nod. 'She's not picked up my calls and I can see she's read some of my messages.'

He sighs. 'I'm sorry. People can be strange. It really is best left alone.'

I swallow thickly, all of the exhaustion, all of my fears bubbling to the surface. The way this is now bleeding into other areas. The carelessness of giving Ruth Anderson my actual phone number, leaving my umbrella behind. Driving when I wasn't ready for it.

I take a deep breath and tell him what I've done, going to her house, confronting her, looking round, turning up at her business, though I don't add that I pretended to be Izzy, or that I'd seen Izzy, glossing over it with, 'I popped into Rebecca's work.' To see if they'd seen her. His face registers various stages of shock as I fill him in on my activities over the past month.

When I am finished, he looks at me open-mouthed. 'You've been stalking her?'

'No.' I pause. 'I realise it must sound like that.'

'Yes it does, Ali, because that's what you've been doing.'

His voice is stern, still low, but for Dan, angry and rising. A tone he never takes with me. A tone he never takes with anyone to my knowledge. Fear creeps up the back of my neck like long, thin fingers. I take Dan for granted, I suppose. His steadiness, mild manner, his dedication to me. I blink. 'I wanted to be friends with her, I thought we were friends.'

'Well, she obviously doesn't feel the same,' he snaps.

I don't want to fight. I'm too tired.

He runs a hand over his face, ruffling his hair, which responds by sticking up in tufty curls. He sinks into a chair alongside the bed. He looks tired too, I think. And he must be. We are both adjusting to this new life, this new person for whom we are completely responsible. He always takes everything in his stride, always seems so secure. It hasn't occurred to me that he is probably struggling too. He's a good man, a nice man. He may not be all fireworks, hot dates and film-worthy romance like Max was, but all of that, it transpired, was just for show anyway.

'I *am* sorry.' I'm crying in earnest now, as though once I've started I can hardly stop. I reach for a box of tissues on the bedside table, pulling the last one out and soaking it through immediately, rubbing at my disgusting snotty nose and sodden cheeks.

'Here,' he says, holding out a pocket pack of Kleenex, extra soft.

I force a smile. 'Thanks.'

He sighs. 'So you've approached her twice?'

'Yes.'

'You've visited her firm?'

‘Yes,’ I say, tears stinging my eyes. ‘I pretended to be a potential client. They offer a free half-hour consultation.’ I swipe a hand across my face, the full embarrassing impact of it all hitting me.

‘God,’ he murmurs. ‘And you viewed her house?’

‘Yes.’ My voice is barely a whisper. The words spoken aloud make clear how bizarre my behaviour has been. But, then, so has Rebecca’s.

‘She denied knowing me, Dan. Why would she do that?’

He shrugs. ‘Who knows?’

‘It is weird though, isn’t it?’

‘People can be weird!’ He’s almost shouting now.

‘Wouldn’t you want to know why?’

Another sigh, another hand run over his face. ‘Honestly?’

I nod.

‘I don’t care. I’m sorry for you that someone you met, someone you bonded with and felt shared your situation has turned out to be a flake. I know that what happened with your ex and your old friend must have been tough.’

‘I’m over that,’ I interject with another lie, but surely not the wrong kind. He holds up a hand to that. ‘I don’t push you on it, Al, but your mum has told me you and Izzy weren’t just friends, she’d been your best friend for most of your life.’

I open my mouth to refute this, but he leaps in.

‘I understand that girlfriends are important, particularly at this time, but as far as Rebecca goes, you need to write her off. I don’t care if she’s lying, only how it affects you and as a result, us. No good can come of pursuing this. *We* have a baby. *We* are a family. We need to look to our future, plan that and make friends with people whose interests we can share. I know that you are probably missing Izzy despite what you tell me.’

I laugh. ‘I mean, she completely betrayed me. What’s to miss?’

‘I know, and that’s shit, but making friends with someone else who has already hurt your feelings isn’t the answer.’

I nod my agreement, holding back any smart answers that push to the front of my mind and threaten to spill out, adding to the bad feeling between us. I am relieved that his anger at least has dissipated. ‘You’re right.’

‘Whatever is going on for her, and it sounds really complicated, it’s not your problem. We have our own stuff to deal with.’

I nod again and my neck twinges, the hard muscles groaning in complaint.

I find I have low-level back ache about ninety per cent of the time. I think it's from holding Charlie to feed. I definitely haven't relaxed into motherhood, and Dan makes a good point. This continued obsession, as he has referred to it, probably isn't making my transition any easier.

'What if she's in some sort of danger, like an abusive relationship?' I try.

'Then hopefully she has people who can help. Certainly from what you've told me she has financial means.'

'You can't buy your way out of problems.'

'Not entirely, but she'd have more options than most and you said she's selling up, moving away. She probably just wants a fresh start. Maybe that's why she cut ties with you, clumsily I admit, but people behave oddly when they're under stress.' He shrugs.

Clumsily? She denied knowing me, denied having been pregnant. I'd seen no signs at all of a baby at her house. It's not clumsy, it's strange.

'I know, but . . .'

'No,' he says, the word firm and fierce. I look at him wide-eyed but his face is set in grim lines. 'This is madness, Ali. You must be able to see that?'

'I mean . . .'

My voice trails off. 'I just want to know what I did to upset her.'

'Who knows, probably nothing. But she's made it clear, Ali, that she doesn't want to talk to you, she doesn't want to be friends.'

'But . . .'

'No. No buts. You need to stop this. It's . . . it's obsessive.'

I blink at him once, twice. Trying to grasp on to my retort. Trying to think how to respond.

'Promise me you'll stop this,' he says.

'Dan . . .'

'Promise me.'

'I promise,' I say, my voice barely a whisper.

REBECCA

Three months ago

Probably, she ought not to have struck up a conversation with the woman at all. But it had made her smile, seeing someone else in the same ungainly state as herself. As they had chatted Rebecca was reminded of what she had missed so much during the past months, that feeling of sisterhood that only a woman could give. Especially now she's expecting a baby, due the same day as Ali's. Rebecca had told her when she'd be back at the park then had panicked, showing up late and telling herself that she'd go to another park next time. But she had seen Ali and she couldn't resist speaking to her again. It'd been too long since she'd had any kind of human connection.

Now she was meant to be going to her house for lunch and she shouldn't, she really, really shouldn't. But, oh God, she wanted to. That was the truth. She'd liked Ali, felt relaxed in her presence, laughed for the first time in months. She'd fed Ali a fairy-tale version of her situation, of course. Enough facts to make it believable, including the name of the father.

When she was chatting to Ali she'd let her imagination run riot and now, before her, like a tempting cream cake when you're on a diet, was an alternate reality where the two of them sat on picnic blankets, babies resting between them, sharing information on feeding and sleep schedules and everything else.

She shuts her eyes, holding her face up to the warm sun, basking in her garden in a glorious glow. When she is with Ali, Rebecca thinks, she is a version of herself that she'd like to be. Living life the way she wished it had turned out. The Rebecca who has struck up a friendship with Ali is a Mrs, married to her long-term sweetheart, a man she fell head over heels with

when she was young still, a fresh-faced student full of hope and promise. That much at least is true. Though even that girl was haunted, even she was hiding things.

Her phone beeps and her eyes snap open.

Tried calling, where were you?

Sleeping she sends back straight away. She hadn't been asleep at all. She'd been waddling along next to Ali, laughing and joking as though she had no worries at all. *Sorry*, she adds and then *x*.

Maybe leave your phone on loud. I can't often manage a phone call.

You're right, she types. *I will, I wasn't thinking. I'm so tired x*. That isn't a lie. Making a person, it transpires, is an exhausting business.

I know, not long now xx.

Not long at all. Mere weeks until her baby is due, until Ali's baby too. Then she will have to move on, let go of this version of Rebecca, because the reality is far more complex than she can tell her new friend. It is a dangerous house of cards that could topple at any moment.

The morning passes in a blur, the thrum of my anxiety like background music. My mum arrives just after one, laden with three different types of formula.

‘You didn’t need to,’ I tell her, eyeing the shopping bags that equal a freedom of sorts.

‘No, but it’s best to try a couple, just in case.’ My mum pats my hand. ‘You being exhausted isn’t going to help, is it?’

‘I suppose,’ I say, aware that I sound like a petulant child. Aware too that, despite our differences in the past, since I have had Charlie, my mum seems to be coming through for me in a way I’d not really imagined she would.

‘You should go rest while I’m here.’

‘I’m not tired,’ I snap.

‘Alison,’ she says, voice firm, ‘rest.’ I go reluctantly, annoyed at being treated like a child even as I’m a bit grateful for it. I’m unlikely to sleep but I flick on the small TV in our room thinking I may as well lie down for a bit. I can hear my mum murmuring downstairs, her happy sing-song voice carrying up to me. At some point I must drift off because I have a series of awful dreams. In them Izzy is pushing Charlie along in a pushchair. I bump into her on the high street outside The Body Shop where, once upon a yesteryear, we had shopped together for coconut body lotion and pink-cherry lip balms.

‘Why have you got my baby?’ I ask her and she smiles.

‘She’s mine and Max’s.’

I’m about to protest when Rebecca comes out of the shop, pushing an empty pushchair and handing Izzy a basket of toiletries.

I come to with a start, unsure for a moment where I am. Then everything floods back in. Including my confession to Dan. I get up and head to the loo.

In the bathroom, I find my hands are shaking. I don’t question Dan’s loy-

alty to me, his dedication. Not really. I did initially, while I was a hot mess, strung out on the back of the traumatic break-up with Max. I'd left the town where Max and I had studied, I couldn't keep bumping into him, and headed back to my mum's, enrolled in a London university, an easy commute from this suburb where I'd grown up, to do an MA in economics. I hadn't been looking for a relationship, but one had found me. Dan worked in the IT department of my university and for that year when all I did was attend lectures, slide back to my mum's house and study in the library, he was one of the few people I ever spoke to.

I press a cold flannel to my face and immediately feel relief in my puffy, swollen eyes. I brush my teeth; my mouth is furred up as if the words I'd held in, the ones I'd finally let spill out to Dan, had been a long time festering.

I head downstairs, pausing at the living-room door, hear Dan's voice in a murmur. 'I'm keeping a close eye on her, but her mood is definitely low.'

'I've been worried about post-natal depression, could that be it?' My mum.

'I don't know.' A sigh from Dan. 'She's definitely exhausted and she probably needs to meet a few local women with babies, feel a part of something, you know. She's got a bit hung up on this woman.' My heart hammers, indignation rising. I'm not hung up. I'm concerned about a friend; I may have over-reacted but I would hope a good friend would have similar concerns for me.

'You might be right. She got like this after all the upset at university.'

My hackles rise at that. Dan makes an indistinct murmuring sound in return.

'Anyway,' Mum carries on, 'she took it hard, you know, and she was, well . . . not in a great place. I wouldn't want her going back to that.'

'No, me neither.'

'Should I talk to her?' Mum asks.

'Not yet,' he says. 'Thanks, though.'

'Are *you* alright?' she asks Dan then. I find I'm almost holding my breath waiting for him to respond.

'I will be, as soon as she is.' The words hit me like bullets, making my heart ache. My mum's words about Izzy ringing in my head. I'm not over it. Not really. Can you ever fully bounce back from something like that? I had seen a counsellor for a while, at Mum's suggestion. Jackie, she was called. She'd said to me, 'Is it possible that by pursuing unsuitable relationships

you are attempting to almost sabotage your own life?’

‘I lived with someone who was cheating on me with my best friend,’ I’d thrown back at her; prickly words, laced with the bitterness that threatened to eat me alive every morning as soon as my eyes snapped open.

She’d smiled, head tilted to one side, her long, shiny ponytail slipping down her arm. ‘You picked them both.’

I’d sort of guffawed. ‘Izzy and I have known each other since junior school.’

‘Yes, and you said you became friends because she wet herself in class?’

‘So?’

‘Well, she was having a bad time, that’s when you took up with her. But you also said she had lots of other friends?’

‘I was the new girl, remember.’ We’d moved a few towns over, getting to Meadsvale just as I was going into junior school. Mum was able to buy a bigger house, but it meant new schools for us. Nick seemed fine, settling in straight away. I, on the other hand, struggled. Until Izzy.

‘Would you say you were grateful when the incident happened? When the other children picked on her?’

I’d bristled at this. ‘Not grateful she was picked on. And, besides, it didn’t last long. I was just glad to be able to be kind to her.’

‘Still, you’ve said a few times it made you feel special that she “chose” you?’

‘I was glad not to have to spend every lunchtime playing alone.’

‘And you were the only one who was nice to her that day?’

‘Yes,’ I’d said. ‘I know what it’s like to be left out.’

‘By her too, up until then?’

‘After that we were friends,’ I said too quickly. ‘Good friends.’

‘Then Max, you say you were surprised when he asked you out.’

‘I was,’ I said. ‘He was very good-looking, popular.’

‘And initially, you met up, helped him out with some of his essays?’ I’d shut down the conversation there and stopped going to see her. The sessions tended to make me feel even worse. But the sabotage comment had stuck with me; my need to be needed, to be useful, and it echoes in my mind now as I take a deep breath, smile and walk into the living room.

‘Hi, Mum,’ I manage.

‘Hello, love.’

We both smile at each other a bit too brightly. Then we both speak at the

same time, laughing. Dan grins and I find myself grinning back. The atmosphere finally softening.

Dan says, 'She took the first formula offered.'

'Did she?' I ask Mum who nods.

'Yes. No problem. She'll be fine, love.'

'Thank you,' I say.

'No need to thank me. I learned the hard way with you, love.'

'Did you?' I ask, curious now.

'Yes. I was devastated to stop breastfeeding, felt like a terrible failure, especially as I'd managed with Nick with no issue.'

'Must have been hard, with Dad not being round much.'

'It was,' she says and I wait for a barbed comment about how difficult I was. It doesn't come. Instead she pats my hand, blows a kiss to Charlie and says goodbye.

Sleep is fortifying. That's the thing I had forgotten, lost sight of. I slept and slept and slept. Today, Charlie and I have mostly stayed in, she has been as good as gold and I've alternated feeds between breast and formula. Both my mum and Dan seem to be pushing for me to bottle-feed her and I've taken to avoiding my health visitor's calls since I realised we were past her compulsory visits. Really, the pressure to keep breastfeeding is gone.

'You look better.' Dan smiles.

'Did I look rough?'

He grins. 'Never. You looked tired and stressed out.'

I nod. 'I think I was,' I tell him. 'Once I'm up with Charlie, I find it difficult to get back to sleep.'

'How about I do the late-night feed for a few days?'

'Really?' I say.

'Of course. Then you can do the horribly early morning one but hopefully if you go to bed at a reasonable time, you'll have had some rest at least.'

'Thank you.'

'You don't need to thank me, we're a team,' he says and I feel a stab of . . . guilt? For not telling him that I am still thinking about Rebecca, still not ready to give up, for surreptitiously keeping tabs on Max and Izzy despite knowing that it's bad news. That they both made me unhappy; in the end they made me almost mad with pain.

It's 4 a.m. when I hear the baby gurgling. I come to with a start, but am pleased to find I am not weighed down with the fug of paralysing fatigue that has plagued me for so long. I feed her and when she goes back to sleep, I head downstairs to make a pot of coffee. I drink three cups as darkness turns to light and the sun rises. There is a distinct chill in the air and leaves are falling in earnest now. The back of our little garden is a smattering of golds, browns and rust from the big trees that shelter us from the gardens

behind.

I wake Dan with coffee and by the time Charlie is up, I'm showered, dressed and feeling calm, but purposeful.

I walk, telling myself I have no set destination in mind, but as I go I find I am covering the miles between our little cottage and Alpine Close, eyes peeled for Izzy or Rebecca, half expecting to see them both walking along laughing together. 'You are a bit of a fantasist,' Jackie had said once during our sessions. I'd frowned and said, 'Aren't fantasies meant to be about good things?'

'Not always,' she'd said, smiling that knowing half-smile. The streets change from cosy suburbia to more apparent wealth. The sharp bite of the cold I'd felt upon leaving dissipates until beneath my cashmere jumper and padded jacket I find that I am sweating slightly. I pause at the end of Rebecca's road, take off my coat and gloves, tucking them into the baby bag. This will be my last visit, my last attempt at some sort of understanding, and, I suppose, some sort of closure. Dan doesn't understand, of course he doesn't. He has had the same handful of friends since school, gained a few extras at university. His friendships are easy, uncomplicated.

I am about to head to Fortunes when I see a tall, fair-haired man walking up the path to 3 Alpine Close. Past the For Sale sign, and up onto the doorstep. I look down at Charlie who is sleeping soundly. I wheel her into position between two houses across the road from Rebecca's where I have learned I get a good view of the house and have, some days, seen her come and go. Always alone. Is this man an estate agent, I wonder, as I stare at his back, ramrod straight. No. He's in trainers for a start and he doesn't have the look. The door opens and Rebecca appears. I inhale sharply, expecting him to step inside and for that to be it. But instead Rebecca leans back into the house grabbing something, her bag, which she's now hitching over her shoulder. She's pushing past him, physically pushing, a firm hand on his chest moving him to one side. He takes a step towards her, his hand out, grabbing at her arm. I think of those bruises, the faint circles that could well have been fingers pressed hard into skin and leaving their mark. I find I'm holding my breath. They exchange words, though I'm too far to make out what they are. Then Rebecca moves, slamming the door shut behind her. The sound loud and furious, making me jump. They hurtle past me and Charlie and I step back slightly, hiding us from view.

‘Rebecca, please,’ I hear his strangled cry. I can no longer see them. They are obscured by a large unwieldy bush at the front of this house where I hide.

‘Leave me alone! This is the last time I’ll say it.’ She sounds panicked, scared, her voice high-pitched.

The sound of footsteps, but only one set, high heels clacking on concrete. Her, walking away so fast she’s almost running. My heart is pounding, my mouth bone-dry and my palms sweating, grasping the handlebar of Charlie’s pushchair. A loud cry startles me, making me jump and look round. God, it’s Charlie. And then there is a face peering round at me. The man, tall, blond hair, open-mouthed looking from me to the pushchair.

‘Excuse me,’ I mutter and manoeuvre the buggy around him, walking as fast as I can until I break into a run, all the way to Fortunes, where Nicole is smiling and asking if I want ‘the usual’? I nod that I do, knowing this will be the last time. I can’t do this any more. Dan is right, I have become embroiled in this drama that isn’t even mine. Is that him, I wonder, the man she’d mentioned? So what if that is Joshua? So what if he was the one who left the bruises? If she wanted my help, she’d have asked, wouldn’t she? If she wanted anything to do with me, she wouldn’t have pretended not to know me.

I feed Charlie from a bottle, my thumping heart and racing pulse finally subsiding. We sit for an hour, looking at Charlie’s squishy baby book. It has waterproof pages, which is just as well, I think, as she shoves it into her mouth, pressing it between her drooling gums. ‘Come on, baby,’ I say, taking it and wiping it with a wet wipe. ‘It’s for reading not eating.’ She offers me a sort of smile; they have started only recently and, despite my mum saying, ‘Probably wind,’ I’m sure she’s grinning. I find myself smiling back at her, my daughter.

I change her and we head home. No sign of the man, but he had seen me, and he’d seen my reaction. Did it matter? Probably not.

Was he Joshua? I could find no record of her ever being married but that didn’t mean she definitely wasn’t. Maybe a partner, maybe just the father of her baby? Maybe one of those kind of situations that you flippantly announce on Facebook as ‘it’s complicated’.

Whatever the situation, it wasn’t mine to be delving into. That was a close call, made worse by the fact that just last night I’d promised Dan I was done with this. With her. Today had been a mistake and it had to be my last.

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REBECCA

Three months ago

Rebecca sorts through a box of old photos, feeling a wave of misplaced nostalgia as she sees herself, a happy, plump baby, nestled between her father with more hair than she ever remembers him having, and her mother who she hardly remembers at all. ‘You’re going to be a grandmother,’ she whispers to the woman who was taken too soon. ‘I bet you’d have been a great grandmother.’ She sinks back on her heels, eyes glued to the image.

She doesn’t have any family any more. Both sets of grandparents gone before she arrived, her mother cruelly taken before her time, leaving her and her dad. And now he is gone too. She misses him desperately. Her phone pings with a new message and she feels her heart leap into her throat. *Is it today?* That’s it. No niceties. *Yes*, she fires back, quickly adding *x*.

Let me know how it goes, yeah?

I will, of course.

She waits, waits, waits. Hopefully looking for the moving three dots that let her know they are typing. Eventually she sends, *Okay there?*

Nothing; but the message has been read.

The doorbell rings and she jumps, the photo slipping from her hand to the floor. She shoves the lid back on the box and glances at the clock, startled to realise it’s almost one o’clock. How long had she been here going through boxes? It’s all she’s done since she woke up this morning. Once upon a time, she would have been for a run, caught up on life admin and still had time to get some work done.

She forces a smile on her face, though there is nothing she feels less like doing, smooths the front of her cashmere jumper and answers the door.

‘Hello, please do come in,’ she says, aware of the utter exhaustion washing over her.

The agent, who barely looks old enough to be out of school, steps inside, letting out a low whistle. ‘This is gorgeous.’

‘Thank you.’

‘You grew up here?’

‘Yes,’ she says, still smiling, not adding that she hadn’t really. Her and Dad stayed here after her mum had died, then Anita, their housekeeper and Rebecca’s unofficial nanny, had left for Sussex and she’d been packed off to boarding school, returning only during the holidays where her and her father stepped awkwardly around each other. She had grown up at Oakwood, not here.

‘Great area,’ he says.

‘It is, good links to London and all that. Shall I show you around?’

‘Please.’

He follows her from room to room. Eventually they head to the outside office. ‘This is great,’ he tells her. ‘Almost like an extra property.’

‘It could be turned into a granny flat.’ She flinches at the use of the word; the granny her child will never have.

‘Yeah, I suppose it could.’

‘It has a bathroom, electricity. You’d just need to add a kitchenette.’

‘Yeah,’ he says, nodding. ‘You’ll easily get what you had it valued at.’

‘You think so?’

‘I do, yeah.’

‘And would it sell quickly?’

‘Oh yes, without a doubt in this location.’

‘Great.’

They are back in the hallway, Rebecca aware that in her current state she takes up much of the space here. She feels slightly nauseous and thinks perhaps that it is not just the baby but the thought of someone else living here in her house. But that’s the plan, that has always been the plan. Sell this place, take the baby off to live by the seaside. A fresh start, new beginnings for them all. But still, she doesn’t need to decide everything today.

‘I’ll let you know what I want to do.’

‘Oh, okay. I mean, we could deal with everything for you . . .’

‘I haven’t quite made my mind up,’ she cuts in, smiling and ushering him out the door. ‘But I know where you are if I need you.’

She boils the kettle for ginger tea. Her phone buzzes with an incoming text.

What did he say?

That the valuation was about right and it would be a quick sale.

Excellent x

Excellent! She feels a swell of relief at that. She sends a thumbs up back.

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I take a deep breath and head into the children's centre. It's pretty much the same faces I'd seen last time, including the super-enthusiastic woman with the too-wide fringe who grins and greets me as though we are long-lost friends. She's running through the list of 'age suited' activities Charlie and I can take part in and I force myself to listen. Force myself to take note and engage. I am re-introduced and find myself sitting next to a woman called Janine who has a long, thin baby with a serious-looking face.

'That's Arlo,' she says, smiling from him to me. We are in a circle, babies in front of us on various brightly coloured mats.

'He's lovely,' I say, not meaning it at all. He in fact looks like a cross little old man.

'We think so.' She looks at him, all softness and light. I suppose the same way I look at Charlie, who lets out a happy gurgle, kicking her legs.

'A little girl?'

'Yes. Charlie.'

'Arlo, Charlie; Charlie, Arlo.' The woman waves the baby boy's fist, I find myself smiling and I wave Charlie's hand back. 'Pleased to meet you, Arlo.'

We sing nursery rhymes, and I feel like an absolute berk to start with then the babies in the circle start responding, chubby legs kicking, little curled fists making circles in the air and I find that if I'm not exactly enjoying myself, I *am* enjoying seeing my daughter participate in something. After we are finished with the songs, the woman with the fringe comes round taking drink orders. They arrive maybe ten minutes later in enclosed cups. Janine says, 'Slide it open like this to get to the coffee and be warned, it takes at least ten minutes to cool down even slightly.'

'Oh.' I look at it dubiously.

'We get our own sippy cups here, lest we scald the little ones,' Janine says with such reverence I can't help but laugh.

She grins back.

‘Do you come here a lot?’ I ask her.

‘Yes.’ Another woman comes over, baby strapped to her front. ‘Hi, Sarah.’

‘Hey, Janine.’

‘This is Ali.’

‘Hi.’ Hands are shaken, me flinging a damp muslin over my shoulder first. We talk mainly about the babies, their feeding, sleeping and toilet schedules. I stay until the end of the session and by the time I pack Charlie into her pram she’s drifting off.

It’s quiet here at this time of day. It’s real commuter-belt land so weekdays leave the little high street and the back roads leading to our cottage fairly desolate. I walk through the park and hear something snap behind me. I turn and see nothing, but my heart picks up pace. My hands gripping the bar of the buggy become slightly damp. I walk faster and am relieved when I finally get in, shutting the door behind me and laughing at myself. I should probably lay off the horror channel.

I feed Charlie when she wakes up and put her on her mat, little mirrored and noisy toys hanging above her. She watches them, enchanted. I watch her for a few minutes. She is changing so quickly. In the past few weeks she has started to gain some control over her limbs and I see her pudgy little fist reaching for a rattling bumblebee. I’m startled by the phone ringing and dig around in my coat pocket for it.

‘Dan, hey.’

‘Hey yourself.’

‘Are you on your lunchbreak?’

‘Yes, thought I’d give you a quick call, see how you and Charlie got on.’

He wants to ask if I made the playgroup, but really, I suspect, he wants to check that I’m not sitting outside Rebecca’s house like a lunatic.

‘We went to the children’s centre.’

‘Oh yeah?’ I smile at his attempt to sound casual.

‘Yes, we sang nursery rhymes.’

‘God, was it awful? It does sound awful.’

I laugh. ‘I mean, it’s not like my voice is any better at “The Wheels on the Bus” than it is at Dolly Parton.’ Songs I’m fond of belting out when cooking.

‘The poor babies!’ he says.

‘Oi!’ I say light-heartedly. It feels like a long time since Dan and I have

joked together. 'It was good, though, fun even. They liked it, the babies. Charlie made friends with a little boy called Arlo who looks a bit like Mr Burns from *The Simpsons*.'

'You're kidding?'

'Nope. Though then that got me wondering if we're all deluded, us parents, but Charlie is actually gorgeous, isn't she?'

'Yes – like her mother.' My heart warms as I gaze at our baby girl, gurgling away happily. 'I love you,' I say.

'I love you too.'

'I'm sorry.'

The silence stretches for so long I'm about to ask if he's gone when he says, 'I just want you to be happy.'

'I know,' I say, quickly adding, 'I am, I just got . . . distracted.'

'I understand how unsettling the whole thing with Rebecca must have been.'

'Yes,' I say. 'But you're right, for whatever reason, she doesn't want to be friends.'

'It must sting,' he says.

I close my eyes, inhale and exhale. 'Like you said though, it's not like I knew her well.' I'd felt like I had though, and that she knew me too. Soulmates come in different guises, I think, not just romantic partners. Sometimes friendships can be like that too, can't they? We'd clicked. It had felt easy and unforced. That day she'd taken me to hospital had cemented it. For some people, I supposed this must be how all their relationships are. But not for me. I'm introverted, probably slightly awkward, but I long for company. For the kind of intense real connection, the kind I'd felt like I had with Rebecca. I don't say any of this and I know too that my marriage, my family is what needs my focus now. Where I need to be. Physically, mentally and emotionally.

'No, and you've made some new friends this morning?' I think about Janine and Sarah, both of whom I've arranged to meet again for lunch. I hadn't shared that spark that I had with Rebecca with either of them, that almost instant clicking. Like I just knew we'd bounce along together. But they seemed nice and Janine at least had a good sense of humour.

'I think they will be; we're going to meet again,' I tell Dan.

'That's great. I'm so pleased.' And I can hear it in his voice.

'Me too.'

As I hang up, leaning forward to put my phone on the coffee table, I see something on the floor. *Dalston's Family Law*. The business card I'd slid off the desk when I viewed Rebecca's place. I should throw it away. I pick it up, feeling the embossed lettering. I could put it in the bin. I'm not going to contact her. Not going to get involved in her oddness again. I don't though. Instead I slide it into my purse. I'm not quite sure why.

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It's a lovely restaurant and I am immediately on edge, trying to push my wide pram through the narrow gaps between tables and chairs. A few people glance over, one woman smiling from me to Charlie, laid flat in the pram and cooing, oblivious to my anxiety, perfectly happy watching tiny tinkling toys swing from the bar over her head.

Dad is already here, seated at a table in the corner, phone clamped to one ear. He holds a finger up to me in a 'wait a moment' gesture, and finishes a call about golf with someone called Jeremy. He laughs a sort of smarmy laugh and I think, not for the first time, that he looks like a sort of cardboard stereotype of an eighties yuppie.

'Hello darling.' He grins as he hangs up and I find myself smiling back. His charm is, as always, infectious.

'Hi Dad.'

'Oh, and who is this, my goodness.' He leans into the pram. 'May I?' His arms are outstretched.

'Sure,' I say, watching him lift her up and press her to his body, crooking her upright in the curve of his arm. I wonder if he ever held me like that. More realistically the baby-holding practice would have come with his second family, though from what Mum says the latest wife, number three, has 'help'.

'She is a poppet, eh?'

'I like her,' I manage. He throws his head back and guffaws, startling Charlie who sort of shudders, staring up at him, open-mouthed.

Larger than life, my dad, and loud with it. The waitress comes over pretending to fuss over the baby but really being drawn into my father's flirtatious web.

He eats with Charlie remaining on his lap, and I suspect he has done this before. Not with me though, which sends that usual pang to my heart. The bit of me that misses an unrealistic version of a dad that I never

experienced.

He talks, a lot, about work mainly. Updating me on the minutiae of his days. Things I have no interest in. Finally, he finishes eating and settles back in his chair. 'How are you finding motherhood then?'

'Okay,' I say and realise actually, that's probably true. It's been a week since Dan and I had our 'chat'. I've felt on edge for a lot of it, convinced on more than one occasion that someone has been following me. I'd turned fast a few times to look over my shoulder, certain that at least on one occasion I'd seen a flash of bright blond hair disappearing round a corner. I haven't told Dan because to do so would mean bringing up the whole Rebecca issue again and whilst I can't say I have managed to remove her from my mind, I have at least cleansed her from our conversations.

'Are you even listening?'

I blink. 'Sorry, Dad, I missed that.'

His face crumples in concern. 'You're getting enough sleep? I hope that husband of yours is stepping up?'

'He is, Dad, yes. He's been great.'

My dad nods. 'Pleased to hear it. Men ought to take an active hand in childrearing.'

He picks Charlie up, his hands gripping her under her arms, turning her to face him whilst I stare at him open-mouthed. He had in no way taken an active role in rearing me, or Nick, though he and Nick do seem to do quite a lot together these days. Memory for my dad is like the faithful eraser. I almost say something, though what exactly that would be I am saved from finding out by his phone buzzing. He looks at it and sighs, 'It's Chelle.' Wife three.

'Not going to get it?'

'I don't think so, sweet pea. Between you and me we're not getting on so well.'

I feel no surprise at this announcement. My father is good for the honeymoon period, every single time. But then he ruins it every single time by getting married, feeling trapped and eventually sodding off again.

'Right,' I say.

Charlie is wriggling so I reach for her. 'She's hungry,' I tell him.

'Oh.' He transfers her to me and I pull out a readymade bottle, getting it to her just as she's starting to whimper.

'I think she likes you though,' I tell him, and she does seem to, having sat

on him through a whole lunch without complaint.

He grins. 'Do you think?'

'Yes.'

The waitress brings the bill. My dad taps his card without looking at it, telling her to add twenty per cent for being the best waitress ever. The silly woman giggles and blushes. He winks, watching her go. I resist rolling my eyes.

I stand, getting our stuff together. Dad walks me out, leaning down to kiss me softly on the cheek. He reminds me, I think, startled at the realisation, of Max.

Autumn is kicking in good and proper. We seem to have slipped from blazing sunshine to rust beneath my feet, sleet grey overhead, the air fresh and piercing, nipping sharply at my throat.

I am entertaining fantasies of hosts of useful staff when I get that feeling again, and the hairs on the back of my neck prickle, rising with more than the cold, fresh air. The street I'm on, two away from my own, is empty, residential. I find my eyes looking into windows as I go, seeing who is there, which door I might bang on if . . . I am being ridiculous, of course I am. I wonder if this new-found paranoia is a penance, punishment for my own stalking, an inverted mental trick set to ruin the thin slivers of peace of mind that I have carved out. My happy little family unit that I have almost jeopardised before we even got going. But still, I move along a little faster, buggy propelled in front of me, my booted feet starting to pick up pace. My breath sounding awfully loud, pushing a thin plume of warm air in front of my face. I look behind me, eyes frantically scanning the road and pavements. A flash? That glimpse of blond from behind a brown wheelie bin? A cat steps out the other side throwing a lofty glance my way as it goes, nose in the air. Bright red, not blond fur, in contrast to the grey pavement, the grey sky. In keeping with the dizzying array of muted leaves on the little verges.

'I must be going mad, Charlie,' I murmur to my daughter, who stares out at me from beneath impossibly thick lashes.

I get into the cottage, park the buggy by the door. Charlie's eyes are almost closed so I leave her be. Never wake a sleeping baby, nor disturb, poke or prod a contented one. My phone pings, startling me. Janine. *See you at soft-play tomorrow? Sarah and I were going to go for lunch afterwards if*

you fancy joining us?

I think again of Rebecca. The two of us side by side in the park, waddling along bemoaning our soon to be ruined pelvic floors and waiting in wonderful suspense for Chardonnay and coffee. Janine is nice though. Sarah seemed fine. *That would be great!* I message back, adding the smiley emoji which I always think looks quite deranged. Dan will be pleased. I'm about to kick off my shoes and sit when my eyes fall on the changing box. Dammit. Nappies! I knew there was something. When I was pregnant I'd toyed with the idea of cloth nappies, the type you machine wash and reuse. I laugh at the very thought of that woman now. We go through so many, the waste is horrendous, but during these woolly, sleep-deprived months, I feel like I'm ninety-nine per cent adrenaline and I'll take survival as a win. Even if it means disposable nappies. Which run out way too fast and which I have, of course, forgotten to pick up. I put my shoes back on and head to the front door. Charlie is asleep, nuzzled in her sheepskin sleeping bag, her rosebud mouth ever so slightly open.

I push her out and decide that just this once we will grab a pack from the corner shop. They're twice the price they would be in the supermarket but I'll take ease over everything today.

The shop is empty as always. I buy nappies and a packet of chocolate digestives.

She's still asleep as I walk up the path to the cottage and see that the door is ajar.

REBECCA

Two months ago

She hangs up the call to Ali and as her new friend's name fades from her screen so too does the warm feeling she'd had looking at that gorgeous sleeping baby. She shouldn't have asked to see the little one, Charlie; now she wants to meet her. Wants the reality where her child is born and the two become inseparable friends, cousins almost, to be true. She imagines her and Ali next summer, side by side on striped deckchairs, children playing at their feet, sitting up by then, she guesses.

She gets up now with a groan; she'd been telling the truth when she said that sleep was harder and harder to come by. Every movement caused some type of discomfort and she was just so big.

In the living room is a stack of boxes. There is so much left to pack, but these are the last few from the attic. Old things covered in thin layers of dust. She opens a box now and is greeted by a photo of herself, fresh-faced, wide-eyed, next to her Josh, also young and so handsome it makes her heart hurt. They'd been studying for their finals, she recalls, and their friend Victoria had taken it.

She remembers the conversation.

'1983?' Josh had asked, his face screwed up in a perfect expression of concentration.

'1985,' she told him, hiding a smug smile.

He sighed. 'It's okay, you've every right to feel superior!'

'I don't,' she says. 'I mean, I have a better memory, that's all.'

'That's all,' he scoffed and Victoria laughed. 'I mean, literally *all* we're doing here is memorising names, dates and cases.'

‘Yes, okay. I’m lucky.’

‘Not lucky,’ says Joshua. ‘You’re whip smart and you should never apologise for it.’

She met his eyes, felt her face flush with the compliment. *Whip smart*. A funny phrase. Josh always had a very precise way of talking and whilst his memory may not have been quite as good as hers, he too was exceptionally smart.

‘Let’s hope I’m clever enough to pass this exam.’

‘You are,’ he said easily.

She had a crush on him, of course. Who wouldn’t? He was not only intelligent but also good-looking, kind, considerate. What was not to like?

The last boy she had ‘dated’ before her crush on Josh had ended in a bad way and it was that memory, that thought, that stopped her from responding to Joshua’s obvious interest in her.

‘Smile!’ Victoria had yelled and that’s when she’d got this shot on the Polaroid camera she’d been using to photograph relevant passages. ‘Not a bad pic,’ Victoria had said, handing it to Rebecca.

She puts it back into the box now and tries to push thoughts of should have, would have, could have away. Regret, she is learning, is a bitter pill and hard to swallow.

I stand frozen for a moment, my hands clenched to the bar of the pushchair. The door staring at me like a dare.

‘Hello?’ I call.

No answer; what was I expecting? Dan isn’t due home; my mum has a key but would never let herself in, or just turn up without mentioning it first. I’m tired. I’ve just had a stressful lunch with my dad. I was annoyed about the forgotten nappies. I probably just didn’t close the door properly.

I wheel Charlie in, flicking up the brake on the buggy. A glance tells me she’s out for the count and I proceed inside with caution, pulling my keys from my handbag, sliding one of them between my middle fingers.

In my kitchen there is a man, tall, blond, turning fast, meeting my eyes. The flashes of blond this week leap to the forefront of my mind. The ring of finger-sized bruises on the top of Rebecca’s slim arm. The man she’d argued with on Alpine Close.

The keys drop from my hands to the tiled floor with a clatter. I hear myself whimper as I step backwards, tripping on the corner of the rug, landing flat and painfully on the bony bit of my back. I wriggle further from him; he takes a step out of the kitchen area, hands open and in front of him. ‘Sorry, God, sorry, don’t be frightened, please, I . . . I meant to knock but you left the door open . . .’

‘Help,’ I manage in a pathetic whisper. ‘Help,’ I say again, louder, getting up, running back to the hallway, grabbing the baby who lets out a holler at the disturbance. I try to get to the door but the buggy is blocking my way. I am flustered, frightened, panicked. ‘HELP,’ I yell a third time, towards the door.

The man is here, passing by me in our tiny entranceway which isn’t even big enough to be described as a hallway. He sidesteps the buggy no problem, passing by me, too close.

‘I’m sorry,’ he says from my doorway now. Charlie is wriggling in my firm

grip. 'I didn't mean to frighten you; I just want to know where Maddie is.' I stare at him, his words making no sense as my blood pressure rockets. Charlie is still crying, her damp face pressed to mine, her breath hot on my cheek. My legs feel weak and I lean to one side, pressing my body against the wall. Taking a step backwards.

I shake my head; finally my brain jumps into action. I dig into my bag, still slung across my body, now beneath the baby. I get my phone, manage to unlock it and tell him, 'Police.'

'I just want to know where Maddie is, that's all. Please.'

'Help,' I whimper, my voice low and weak. 'Help,' I try again with more force, the volume increasing, as does Charlie's screaming. The man looks over his shoulder, left, right. 'Sorry. I'm so sorry.' He turns, so quickly he almost falls over, his hand steadying him on my doorframe. Then he is gone and I am breathless, shaking and dialling 999.

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Our little cottage is now a hive of frantic activity. There are two police officers, a man with a thin, stern face and a woman with short hair and sharp eyes who introduced herself as DI Gerard.

‘Did you leave the door open when you went out?’

‘It’s possible,’ I admit, adding, ‘Likely even, I keep thinking about that, and I’m almost certain I did. We’d just got in, you see, and I realised I needed nappies. Charlie, the baby, was still in the pushchair, so I figured, we’ll go. I remember opening the door and normally I do check it, you know, give it a push. I don’t remember doing that this time, just being here then out on our way to the shop.’

‘It’s fine, Mrs Cooper. Take your time.’

I’m gabbling, of course. ‘So what I’m saying is yes, it’s quite likely that I left the door open.’ Which would fit as there was no forced entry.

I look around, flustered, my eyes searching for my husband. He’d got here shortly after the police had arrived. I say to him, ‘I’m so sorry.’ Not for the first, nor I suspect the last time in our marriage.

‘You don’t need to be.’ Dan puts two steaming mugs in front of the police officers, plonks himself next to me. I feel his thigh pressed against mine. The heat of him, the safe, solid familiarity.

‘We’re very tired, as you can imagine.’ Dan smiles at Charlie who is nestled in my arms, her little face scrunched up. It makes her look like she is thinking – it’s probably wind.

The male officer smiles briefly. ‘I remember those days.’

The woman leans forward, picks up her mug and sips her coffee, murmuring, ‘Thank you,’ to Dan, who nods. To me, she says, ‘You definitely don’t know the man?’

‘No,’ I say. I swallow, feeling saliva sticking at the back of my throat, the lie caught in a nervous web of my own making. The man was the same person I’d seen arguing with Rebecca on her doorstep. But if I admit it then I’ll

have to tell Dan that, despite my promises to the contrary, I had, in fact, carried on pursuing the truth about Rebecca. That this man who has now invaded our home, who I'm quite certain was following me, must be Joshua. Mustn't he? And Maddie? I'm assuming that is Rebecca's baby. A daughter just like mine. Even in the midst of this surreal awfulness I feel a spike of joy at that. Our twin-due-date babies who certainly didn't arrive on the same day but nonetheless feel to me to be linked. Just as I feel Rebecca and I are linked.

'Very strange,' the officer says then to us both. 'Luckily there is extensive CCTV in this area so we should be able to get some clear images.'

I nod. Dan says, 'What do you think he wanted?'

The officer shrugs. 'Most obvious would be an opportunist robbery. Saw the door open and came in.'

'But he didn't take anything,' Dan says.

'Well, no, he was interrupted before he had the chance, I imagine.'

'Right,' Dan says, sounding unconvinced.

'And all he said to you was "sorry"?' the policewoman asks me, her sharp eyes piercing through my lie.

'Yes,' I say. 'Then he ran out of here.'

After they are gone, with their small pads full of scrawled handwriting, Dan pulls me to him, the baby snug between us. 'Come here,' he says and I feel the heat of his breath in my hair. The firmness of his broad chest beneath my cheek. I blink away tears as my heart thuds. At this tangled mess I've made. The dishonesty drip-poisoning our marriage, our family. 'I'm sorry,' I say. 'I'm so sorry.'

He pulls back, hand on my shoulder, eyes searching mine. 'Hey now. You don't need to be.'

'I left the door open,' I offer, wanting him to at least admonish me over that, even if it's only the tip of the iceberg. A small component of a much larger problem.

'It's an easy mistake to make, but we'll change the locks anyway.'

'Do we need to?'

'Probably not, but . . .' He shrugs. 'It will make me feel better. I can cancel the France trip.' He's due to be away again most of next week. The set-up went well and he has overseen and written testing procedures to make sure UK and French offices are following the same guidelines. He's there to present about it and it really is his big opportunity.

‘No,’ I say quickly. ‘No, I’ll be fine.’ He frowns and I smile. ‘I promise. I can always call Mum.’

‘I don’t mind not going.’

‘If you don’t go, someone else will get the credit for your work.’ Which is true; he needs this trip, *we* need it. It’s his chance at a promotion and a raise.

‘I’ll be fine, I promise, but if I feel at all uncomfortable, I’ll go to Mum’s.’

‘Okay, but we’ll change the locks first, just in case.’

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REBECCA

One month ago

‘We’ve had an offer.’ His voice is pleased, triumphant as well it might be, all things considered and in expectation of the extortionate amount of commission he’d make.

‘That’s wonderful news,’ Rebecca says, not sure that she really means it. He tells her the amount which is in fact slightly above the asking price, and she murmurs, ‘Thank you so much,’ imagining the Alpine Close house, which will soon be completely empty. Much of the furniture is already here at the Sussex house. She finds it comforting, the pieces remind her of her dad. She misses him, still feels cross whenever she thinks of him at the end. It took six long and gruelling months for cancer to shrink him to a shadow of his former self. Throughout, he remained in good spirits, assuring Rebecca that watching her grow up into a woman he was proud of was reward enough for him in this life. She was, she supposed, an orphan, though can you refer to yourself as that when you are a grown-up? Everyone loses their parents eventually. She lost her mother far too young and she wishes that her father had lived to a ripe old age. It seems horribly unfair but he will never meet her child, his only grandchild, but whoever said life was fair? She has spent too much of the past year alone, has had far too much time to think and ponder. She’s found that beneath layers of sadness she is furious at the injustice of having to say goodbye to him in her mid-twenties. He left her wealthy. She sold the flat in London where she’d been a student once and then a trainee. She’s in the house on the Sussex border that had been his mother’s, where he himself had been raised and where his grandchild lies now gurgling contentedly in a beautiful Moses basket. A good

place for a child; sea air, beautiful walks. But, she realises, she misses Alpine Close . . . The estate agent's happy voice in her ear interrupts – 'Are you there?'

'Yes, I'm here. That's brilliant, really. Thank you.'

She loves that place, she thinks, it feels like home. But, she reminds herself as she leans down to pick up the baby, a twinge in the unhealed scar across her abdomen as she does so, this was the plan, had always been the plan. A fresh start.

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Halfway between mine and Rebecca's the grey sky kicks out a thin, reedy drizzle. I pause to fight with the pushchair cover and manage to put it on back to front. By the time I get it right, the rain has all but stopped but she is at least dry. I on the other hand feel the cold droplets sinking into my scalp. I should have worn a hat, but at least I have a coat and gloves, even if said gloves are also now damp. It takes me well over half an hour to cross the suburb from mine to hers. A walk I am familiar with for all the wrong reasons. I had envisioned us meeting at her place for coffee, me awed by her wealth, her confidence her . . . sureness. And yet it is I with the husband, my little family intact, and her who seems to be in trouble. The weekend went far too fast. A locksmith came out and charged an eye-watering amount but, as Dan said, you can't put a price on safety and, after he left this morning, I was glad we'd done it. Not least because neither of us can remember where we left the spare set of door keys, which left me feeling more than a little uneasy.

The first thing I notice as I approach Rebecca's is that there are no lights on and the For Sale sign has been changed to Sold.

Shit.

I push the buggy up the front garden path, press my face to the glass and see an empty room. Completely empty. I fish my phone out of my pocket, scrolling back through old calls until I find the estate agent. I call, asking for the young one with the silly quiff who'd shown me around. I give him my name and he says, 'Ah yes. I'm afraid that house has been sold.'

'Oh,' I say. 'That's a shame.'

'Yes,' he says, though his jubilant voice reminds me that it is, of course, not a shame for him at all. He has probably made an enormous commission.

'I have some similar properties you might be . . .'

'No. Thank you.'

I cut him off, hanging up the phone, heading down the side of the house

and unlatching the gate. I push the buggy in before me and head to the outside office, leaving Charlie parked on the patio. Empty. The rooms at the back of the house. Empty. I try calling her old number again, then I try the one on the card. That rings at least but still no answer.

I am standing, phone in hand, mulling over what to do next, when my phone rings, startling me.

‘Shi— sorry. Hello?’ I manage. ‘Hi.’

‘Ali, hi, it’s Janine.’

Janine? Oh God . . . Janine. I was supposed to meet her and Sarah for lunch.

‘Ali?’

‘I’m so sorry, we were meant to meet?’

She laughs. ‘We were, did you forget?’

‘Yes. God, sorry.’

‘Baby brain!’ she says.

‘Yes, probably.’

‘We’ll be here for another hour.’

‘I’m the other side of town.’

‘Oh, well. Next time then.’

‘Yes, definitely. Next time.’

I’m halfway home when my phone pings. Dan: *I think you’ve got your mums lunch today? Hope you have a lovely time. Just about to get on the Eurotunnel – au revoir for now!*

My phone starts ringing at exactly the same time Charlie starts squalling. She’s been kept asleep by the swaying of the buggy but the second we are over the threshold to the cottage she comes to, appalled and probably hungry. I ignore the phone, though I do check the door prior to opening, definitely locked, and once we’re inside I push it closed, pressing my body to it. I slash the chain across the top of it for good measure.

I pull my daughter out of her nest of blankets, shushing her while I make up a bottle, testing the temperature. It seems to take ages and she becomes more and more disagreeable. Finally, as her screeches reach fever pitch, it is ready and I plug it into her mouth, her eyes widening, shoulders hitching. She drinks as if she is starving.

‘There, little one. There you go.’ I start to relax as she does, the tension leaving her body as the milk hits her little tummy. She goes from rock-hard

outrage to liquid-smooth floppiness in twenty minutes. I wind her, put her on her mat and check my phone. Dan.

I call him back. 'Sorry, I was feeding Charlie.'

'I figured, and today *was* the day you were meeting Janine, wasn't it?'

My heart beats; I'd forgotten all about it of course, but it seems he hadn't.

'Yes, that's right,' I say, blinking as I watch the baby happily waving her chubby arms and legs on the mat. 'We, uh, met for lunch.'

'How was it?' he asks, tone casual but there is expectation in those words.

'Great,' I say brightly. 'I saw her and her friend Sarah, did I say that?'

'The other woman from the playgroup?'

'Yes, that's right.'

'They're nice?'

'Really lovely. Yes.'

'That's brilliant,' he says and there is so much warmth in his voice and something else too. Relief. That I am doing what I'm supposed to be doing. Moving on, making proper friends who aren't going to pretend I never existed.

'How's it going there?' I change the subject.

'It's okay so far.'

'How did the presentation go?'

'I mean, the audience weren't a patch on you.'

I giggle, surprised I have it in me. That I can slip so easily into this comfortable back and forth after having lied directly to my husband. Guilt stabs at my stomach.

'We miss you,' I say, realising that it's true for me at least; Charlie seems happy enough as long as she's changed, fed and held.

'Well, I *am* lovable,' he says.

'You are.' Charlie makes a loud wailing sound. 'She agrees,' I tell him. We laugh. The call ends well. I will phone Janine in the morning, see if I can go and meet at least her tomorrow. Then the lie will only be a partial untruth, a matter of timing.

Charlie and I plod through the week easily enough. We visit Mum on Tuesday, and Wednesday is rhyme-time and sensory play at the children's centre. Janine and Sarah are there and I find myself chatting with them. I leave with promises to re-schedule lunch and think I will actually do it.

On Thursday we are slow to start the day and I think, not for the first time since having her, how odd time is now. The days seem to race by but the hours, minutes, even seconds can stretch and stretch. It's almost ten o'clock and I am only just out of the shower, despite being up since five.

I go to the living room and pick up my phone to text Janine when it starts ringing. Unknown number.

'Hello?' I whisper, in an attempt not to wake Charlie who is napping beside me.

'Mrs Cooper?'

'Yes?'

'It's DI Gerard.'

'Oh, hello,' I say, 'hang on.' I slide out of the living room, into the hallway, closing the door behind me. 'Sorry, the baby is asleep.'

'No problem. Are you home at the moment, Mrs Cooper?'

'I am, yes.'

'Could we pop by?'

'Um . . .' I hesitate. 'Okay, though could you give me an hour, while the baby's asleep?'

She agrees. I hang up the call and realise I hadn't asked why they needed to visit, but now I wish I had. Have they found out about me ringing Rebecca, looking round her house, seeing her argue with the man, Joshua? Who turned up here. Will they tell Dan? I clamp a hand to my mouth, fussing around in the kitchen, putting another pot of coffee on while wondering if more caffeine is a good idea considering my jangled nerves. I do it anyway and have a mug steaming hot with two sugars. I check my reflection,

smooth down my wayward hair, blink at myself. I look fine, if a bit tired.

By the time I answer the door an hour later, I am a nervous wreck.

I lead the two officers to the living room where Charlie, awake now, gurgles happily on her playmat, oblivious to the panic I feel coming off me in waves. I lean forward, touching my fingers to hers, and she sighs contentedly.

‘She’s very sweet,’ says the male police officer. Detective Suni, I think, definitely the junior of the two.

‘Thank you.’ I force a smile; he sips his coffee.

DI Gerard says, ‘We’ve found your intruder. His name is Joshua Hall.’

‘Right,’ I manage, pausing to take a sip of my own coffee, my palms suddenly damp, my heart thud thud thudding. He *was* Joshua. Rebecca’s husband? Not the same surname and I’ve found nothing online to indicate they were married. But it was the name she gave me; it had to have come from somewhere, it had to mean something. I think again about the bruises at the top of her arm. His panicked face, ‘*Where is Maddie?*’ The Sold sign outside her beautiful house in its prime location. A perfect suburb for raising children.

‘You don’t recognise the name?’

I put my mug down, a slight tremor in my hand. ‘Should I?’

She shrugs. ‘It seems he’s gone missing.’

I blink, once, twice. Had I misheard her? ‘What?’ I say. It comes out as a little croak.

‘He’s missing and whilst he’s a grown man and therefore free to do whatever he likes, we have had a little look into it, and it seems his colleagues are all rather worried.’

‘Worried?’ I repeat after her.

‘Yes, quite out of character for him not to show up for work. He’d had some time off recently but that was annual leave. He was due back yesterday, clients booked in, a full day. Never showed. You didn’t know him, then?’

I shake my head and push away the thoughts threatening to spill out of my mouth, afraid of what I might say to the two police officers who are looking at me far too closely.

‘What do you think happened?’ I ask.

‘We’re not sure yet, but we are . . . intrigued by it all.’

‘Intrigued?’ I am an echo. The words reverberate around us. I can’t quite work out what exactly the policewoman is getting at.

‘Well, we don’t know what’s happened to him. Nor why a successful barrister would break into your home, or anyone’s home for that matter.’

‘He didn’t take anything,’ I murmur.

‘Well, no, quite. And yet, you’re sure you don’t know him?’

‘No.’

‘And now he’s missing.’

‘But, as you say, he’s a grown man. Maybe something personal came up.’

‘Like what?’

‘I don’t know. Marital problems?’

She smiles tightly. ‘His car has been found abandoned, he hasn’t been into work and he broke in, or walked in, to your house. As you say, not quite alarm bells ringing yet but . . . intriguing.’

‘And his family?’ I try again, fishing for information.

‘I’m afraid we can’t say much more than that. Though it is obviously curious that he was here, in your home, just days before this . . . unsettling turn of events.’

‘Curious?’

She smiles tightly.

‘You can’t think I have anything to do with this?’ I laugh, a sound that falls flat in their silence though Charlie hears it and gives a responding cry of her own. Too innocent for this terrible conversation.

‘Where were you on Monday around lunchtime? His neighbour saw him leave his house, and that’s the last known sighting of him.’

On Monday I had been standing outside Rebecca’s house, my nose pressed against the windows, taking in the emptiness. I should have been at lunch with Janine and Sarah. I had in fact told Dan that’s what I’d done. The lie swirls around me, so much worse now the police are involved.

‘I was out walking,’ I tell DI Gerard because she, unlike Dan, may well check with Janine and Sarah and they will say I hadn’t shown up. That I had forgotten.

‘Oh really? Where?’

I shrug. ‘Across town and back,’ I say, adding ‘with my daughter,’ because surely people didn’t go out and commit kidnappings, or whatever the hell they think has happened, with a baby in a pram?

‘Did anyone see you?’

‘I was walking with Charlie,’ I spat out. ‘We passed lots of people.’

‘But did you stop anywhere? For a coffee perhaps? At a shop?’

‘No.’ My voice is now little more than a whisper. ‘You can’t possibly think I had anything to do with this?’

‘We’re just exploring a few leads.’ She’s standing now, the words casual, their impact on me not. Detective Suni downs the last of his coffee, then they both hold out their hands which I shake.

I walk them to the door; the woman turns and says, ‘We’ll be in touch,’ the words lingering in their absence, hanging in the air like a threat. I stand frozen for a moment, thud thud thud goes my heart, I shake my head and everything slips and slides. My stomach churns and I run back into the kitchen, leaning over the sink just in time as a stream of thick yellow bile shunts from me into the sink.

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REBECCA

Now

‘I don’t want an argument.’

‘No one wants an argument!’

Rebecca feels a headache pressing in behind her eyes. ‘Then let’s not start one,’ she replies through clenched teeth.

This is greeted with a sigh.

‘Perhaps,’ Rebecca says, ‘you need a break.’ Though why would this be the case when it is she who’s getting up five, six, seven times a night? Rebecca whose body is recovering, the vivid red scar angry, itchy and sore. Her body still soft but changing daily. Not back into what it had been, she doesn’t think it will ever be that again and she’s fine about it. Every single stretch mark, every single pound is worth it. But it is so tiring. For her at least.

‘Maybe you’re right. A change of scene would be good. We could leave the baby with Anita.’

‘No,’ she says, the word coming out fast. She’s had to drive back and forth from here to Alpine Close, stopping overnight more than once. She hates it, being apart from this precious little person. Add to that the stress of Ali turning up. Lies always breed more lies, her father had told her once. They’d been discussing the law and how to drill down to find the truth. One lie, he’d told her, inevitably leads to another and another and another. How right he was, she is discovering in the hardest possible way. Worse still, lies bind you, tie you to another if they are shared.

She forces herself to smile. ‘You go. Get some breathing space. I’ll stay here, honestly.’

‘Is this how it is for ever now; we can’t do anything together?’

‘We have our whole lives to be together.’

‘That’s true.’

‘Babies grow up fast.’

‘I’d settle for sleep and a bit of peace.’ This is said with a frown at the bundle in Rebecca’s arms. She forces herself to laugh as if in agreement. But the truth of the matter is, she loves this child more than she’s ever loved anyone else and that has changed everything.

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I feed Charlie, wind her and put her in her swing. Her eyes close almost immediately and she drifts off. I have the radio playing softly in the background, a talk station where people phone in enraged about various things. I switch in and out of the conversation whilst I wash bottles on autopilot, my mind racing.

Dan phones and I feel sick as he tells me about his day, oblivious to the danger I've let into our lives.

'Dan . . .' I say, ready to tell him everything – that the police have been, that a man is possibly missing, that I may be in trouble. That I lied to him.

'Hang on, Al.' His voice is muffled; I imagine his hand pressed to the receiver. 'I have to go, sorry, we're up again next.'

'Of course,' I tell him. 'Good luck.'

I hang up the phone. Dial the number on Rebecca's business card. No answer. I send a text. *It's Ali. I know about Maddie and Joshua. Get in touch or I'm going to tell the police everything.*

Almost immediately my phone rings. Withheld number.

'Hello?'

'Ali.'

'Rebecca.' The relief is insane. It's as if I've been holding my breath for the past two months and finally, finally I can let the air out.

'Yes, it's me.'

'So you *do* know who I am?' The words are out.

'Yes, and . . . I'm sorry . . . about everything. I didn't mean to hurt you.'

I don't say anything; what can I say? Eventually I ask, 'Are you alright?'

'Not really, no. Look, I can't talk on the phone. Would you be able to visit me? I'm in Sussex.'

'I don't know.' I think about it, chewing the inside of my lip. 'I don't want to bring my daughter,' I say, unsure of what I'm walking into. Unsure how this bizarre situation could possibly be explained.

‘Charlie,’ she says softly, almost tenderly. ‘How is she?’

‘Fine.’

‘And you?’

‘Okay.’ Despite the familiarity she is now adopting, I am determined to give her nothing.

‘Good. Good.’ This is like a parody of the sort of conversations we should have been having months ago. It is jarring having it now, stilted and uneasy. Surreal words exchanged in the face of . . . what? Has Joshua run away? Or something far more sinister? My suspicion is that he is chasing Rebecca and their daughter Maddie, though it sounds like the police may be entertaining other possibilities, like kidnap. Or worse? ‘*We’re investigating all leads.*’ Me. I am a lead. I am a liar in the middle of a criminal investigation. I have lied to my husband. I haven’t told the police the whole truth. I have to get to the bottom of this, to know what the hell is going on, then I can decide what to do next, when I have all the facts.

‘So could you get away, do you think?’ she presses.

‘I’d rather you just told me what’s going on now.’

‘Please,’ Rebecca says and there is a tone of such desperation in her voice that, despite my anger, I find myself softening. ‘I’m not trying to be difficult but a face-to-face conversation would be better. I’d be so grateful, Ali, if you could just give me this chance to explain everything, and I will explain, I promise.’

‘Fine. I might be able to get away for a day, no more.’

‘Thank you. Thank you so much, Ali. I know it’s more than I deserve.’ I don’t respond to that. I do say, ‘Do you know Izzy?’ quickly before I can talk myself out of it.

‘Izzy who?’

‘Jenkins.’

‘I know an Isabelle from school. Isabelle Marriot, but I’ve not seen her for years.’

‘No, that’s not her.’

‘Then no. Why?’

‘It doesn’t matter,’ I tell her and it really doesn’t; she sounds genuinely baffled. That particular concern bursts, floating away like a fairy liquid bubble popping in the air.

‘When can you come?’

As much as I want answers, I can’t drag Charlie into this. It will have to

wait until Dan gets home, late Friday night. 'Saturday will be the soonest,' I tell her. That's two days away; what if the police come back before then? 'It really would be easier if you just told me what's happening now, Rebecca.'

'I know, I get that, but it isn't a conversation for a phone call. I'm sorry, I know it's unfair but I really would prefer to talk in person.'

I sigh but find myself agreeing nonetheless. Curiosity winning out alongside my own desire to see her, despite everything. 'I'll text the address. Please come, Saturday. I'll be there all day, okay?'

'Okay,' I manage. 'Okay.'

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REBECCA

Now

Rebecca hangs up the phone, her face drawn, pensive and thoughtful, her mind whirring as she takes in this unwelcome twist.

‘Well?’

She turns to the voice, blinking at her companion, who says, ‘What does she know?’

‘I’m not entirely sure yet, but more than I would like.’ Her words are tight, laced with annoyance.

‘No need to bite my head off!’

‘Sorry. I didn’t mean to snap.’

That gets a pout. ‘Fine.’ It is said in a way that lets Rebecca know that it is anything but.

Rebecca says, ‘I didn’t want to talk about it on the phone, I need time to think and also I want to see her reactions.’

‘Yes, I suppose you’re right.’

‘I’ve asked her to come here.’

‘Is that wise?’

‘Do you have a better idea?’ Rebecca snaps, and her friend seems to shrink. She is reminded, not for the first time, of how small she is; her diminutive size had always made her seem so much younger than her years. Had always made Rebecca feel protective towards her. ‘I’m sorry,’ she says again. ‘I think it’s the best of a bad set of choices. Given everything.’

‘I suppose.’ Her lower lip trembles.

The call has unsettled Rebecca. How much does Ali know? ‘You’re not keeping anything from me, are you?’ she asks. Her friend had been away,

only returning back earlier in the week. She'd needed rest, she'd said, a chance to recharge. Rebecca had been pleased of some space and not pressed the matter.

Her friend frowns. 'Oh, that's just fantastic. Now you don't trust me?'

'Sorry,' she says, hearing the exhaustion in her own voice. Rebecca sits next to her, putting an arm across her shoulders, pulling the smaller woman close. 'Come on, everything will be okay, you'll see.'

'You promise?'

'Yes,' she says, her voice surer than she feels, her mind thrumming with all of the things that could make this situation go from bad to worse. Things which, it seems to her right now, are legion. She squeezes her eyes closed, willing back a headache, not missing the fact that the other woman has evaded the question, that in this cloying arrangement where secrets are like currency she can't relax, not even for a second. 'I promise.'

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It's late Friday night by the time Dan returns, his face creased with tiredness but his smile triumphant as he recounts the series of presentations that he and his team have given, the fantastic responses they've had and his excited, tentative hopes for the future.

'Well done, baby,' I tell him and mean it.

'Well done *us*,' he says to me. 'Thank you for sitting up and listening to me prattle on, thank you for being here to take care of her.'

'Team work makes the dream work,' I mumble.

'It does, definitely, and I want to make sure you don't have to give up on things you want to do and achieve as well. I know you're worrying about not being able to afford to go back to work.'

'I am,' I say, though it pales into insignificance compared to recent events. It seems far away now, a problem that belongs to a simpler version of me, before I met Rebecca, before the police came to our house. Though, of course, I can't tell Dan this. Not yet.

'Tell me about your week anyway,' he says.

I laugh, 'You know you've only been gone for five days.' That's all it is. All the time it's taken to plunge me into yet even more shit.

'Okay, tell me about your five days,' he says, smiling.

'Well, we've played on the playmat, drunk a lot of milk.'

'And she's still taking the bottle no problem?'

'Yes,' I say, not adding what a relief it is and the dark swell of guilt that brings.

'That's great,' he says, 'and it means I can do some of the heavy lifting now without needing you on hand.'

'On that note,' I say, my heart hammering at the thought of yet another lie, 'I wondered if you might watch her tomorrow.'

'Of course, you have plans?'

'Yes, um, Janine, from playgroup, has a spare pass for a spa day.'

‘That sounds nice.’

‘Yes, that’s what I thought.’

‘Fantastic. You go. I’m looking forward to hanging out with the little one anyway.’

‘Great,’ I say brightly, the dishonesty sticking in my throat.

‘Can I go and look at her?’ he asks, like an excited puppy. I feel my heart melt at his eager face. He has dark circles under his eyes, as I probably do too, but there hasn’t been one moment since her birth when I’ve doubted his commitment to her, to me. And our life.

‘Of course,’ I say softly.

I wait five minutes, then I head up the stairs and stand at the nursery door watching him, watching her. It is a picture-perfect moment. A tableau worthy of catalogue families the world over. My handsome, hardworking, caring husband. My beautiful, perfect, healthy newborn daughter. Me looking in at them, a person of interest with no checkable alibi in what may well be a missing person case.

He turns to me, smiles. ‘She’s perfect, isn’t she?’

‘Yes,’ I say softly. She stirs and I press a finger to my lips.

Dan edges out of the room, pushing the door to and taking me in his arms. He buries his face in my hair. ‘I missed you both so much,’ he murmurs.

‘We missed you too,’ I say.

REBECCA

Now

‘I just don’t see what good her coming here will do.’

‘I didn’t want to talk about it on the phone,’ Rebecca says for what feels like the millionth time. ‘I feel like Ali will respond better to me in person.’

‘You hardly know her.’ Rebecca doesn’t reply. The last thing she needs right now is an argument, though she is sure it’s coming; there’s been an air of tension ever since her phone call from Ali on Thursday. They both have a sort of cabin fever, she supposes, improved slightly by a few days apart, but those days seem a distant memory now as they continue to have this same circular conversation. Rebecca can feel herself getting more and more frustrated by it.

‘I mean,’ her friend goes on, ‘what can she possibly know?’

‘I have no idea, but clearly she knows a lot more than I’ve told her.’

‘You shouldn’t have told her anything at all. You shouldn’t have even spoken to her.’

‘Do you think that I don’t know that?’ Her words are met with a frown and cross, folded arms. ‘I was lonely,’ she says, lowering her voice.

‘I know, God I know. I would happily have swapped with you though.’

‘Yes, you’ve said.’

‘Oh, and what? You don’t believe me?’

Rebecca sinks onto the sofa. ‘I just don’t want to play “who had it worse” one-upmanship, that’s all.’

‘Right.’

‘Look, she’s coming so that’s that.’

‘Persistent, isn’t she?’

‘She’s just trying to be a good friend. She’s loyal, you surely understand that?’

‘I do.’

Rebecca takes her hand, presses the small fingers between hers. ‘I *said* she reminded me a bit of you.’

‘Well, she can’t possibly be as wonderful as I am.’ It is said with a smile, but also a tinge of something else. Jealousy? Rebecca shakes the thought away and smiles back at her.

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I kiss Charlie on her plump, slightly damp cheek. 'She's very warm,' I say to Dan with a frown.

'It's boiling in here; have you got the heating set to tropical again?'

'Oh.' I grin. 'Maybe. I'm cold.'

'You're always cold.' He wraps an arm around my shoulders. 'Take your big coat, I put it on the peg by the front door.'

'Thank you,' I say, this simple kindness making me feel awful. It is undeserved and for a moment I wish he was different, difficult, inconsiderate, anything to make me feel like less of a shit.

'Where are you meeting Janine?'

'The train station.'

'Do you want us to drop you?'

'No, no need.'

'You sure?'

I nod. 'The walk will warm me up.'

'There is that.' He smiles. 'Grab a coffee on the way.'

'I will. Thanks.'

The walk *does* warm me up and I find I probably didn't need the coat after all. I end up carrying it, a silly feather-down-filled thing that is like an oversized sleeping bag and is now flung over my arm. In the inside pocket is my phone and the envelope with my name and address scrawled on the front. Inside that, a Post-it note with an address in Sussex.

I buy a return ticket, settle onto the first of two trains and watch the suburbs fly by outside. My phone rings. Withheld number.

'Hello?'

'Mrs Cooper?' The wretched policewoman. I close my eyes. Press my forehead to the glass window of the train. Pleased that at least it is quiet, just me in the carriage so far.

'Yes?'

‘I was wondering if you might have a chance to nip to the station.’

‘What for?’

‘We’d like to take your fingerprints,’ she says, the words pounding in my heart, making cortisol spike in my bloodstream. My heart flutter. Fight or flight. I try to keep my breathing steady, my voice even. ‘Is that really necessary?’

‘It’s just to eliminate you from our enquiries.’

‘So you have something to match them against, then?’

She pauses as if weighing up what to tell me. ‘We do.’ She relents; seemingly that small nugget of information isn’t so precious I can’t be told.

‘Can I ask what?’

‘You can ask.’

‘But you’re not going to tell me?’

‘No.’

‘They won’t match mine,’ I say, ‘the fingerprints.’

‘Then you have nothing to worry about.’

‘I’m not worried,’ I lie. Feeling like I am fifteen again and have been caught smoking outside the school gates with Izzy. Terrified of my mother’s disappointed face and an imminent grounding. I have *always* hated getting into trouble.

‘Great, so you’ll come in today?’

‘I can’t today, I’m on my way to Sussex,’ I say before I think not to.

‘Oh?’

‘Yes,’ I say, amazed at how steady my voice is in sharp contrast with my wobbly, frenetic pulse. ‘I’m meeting a friend, for a spa day.’

‘Anywhere nice?’

‘Yes, thank you, but I won’t be back until this evening.’

‘Your husband has your daughter?’

‘Yes.’ My heart thump thump thumps. Because I do not want her trespassing into my home in my absence. Upsetting the careful deception there. I am hoping against hope that by the end of today at least, I’ll be able to tell Dan what is going on. I know that I am going to have to say something, and fast. I’m hoping against hope that this nefarious, clandestine meeting will shed enough light on the situation to allow me that. Or, my mind murmurs, are you walking into a trap?

No. Despite everything that has happened, as soon as I heard Rebecca’s voice I had felt it again, that connection. That mutual understanding. I trust

her, or I wouldn't be on this train, my mind racing ahead to the inevitable damage limitation I'll need to perform on my marriage later today.

'Tomorrow then,' the detective says.

'Sunday?'

'Yes.'

I sigh, to let her know it's outrageous, and it is. The whole idea of me as a suspect for any kind of legal wrongdoing is preposterous. Or is it?

'I'll be at the station between ten and three; your cooperation would be appreciated.'

'Okay.'

'I'm sure, Mrs Cooper, that you will be as pleased to be crossed off our list as we will be to do the crossing.' The words are right and ought to be soothing but they are not, pregnant as they are with an underlying menace.

She knows, I think, that I am lying but, I remind myself, it's unlikely she knows what about.

I shut my eyes. The space where my forehead is pressed to the glass, at first cool, is now hot and sticky. I pull away, look back out at the bland green of England passing me by out there and say, 'Absolutely.' Glad to be rid of her. Glad to slide my phone back into the thick, puffy pocket of my ridiculous winter coat.

According to Maps, a bus will take me almost to the end of the road I have written on the pale pink Post-it in my pocket and, as always right now, money is an issue. I look longingly at the taxi rank as I pass it by. One day, perhaps a day sooner than we'd hoped, Dan and I won't have to worry about every penny. I had not realised how the constant money worries had affected me growing up, how much, I suppose, the material things have come to matter to me. But I know I want better for Charlie than I had. Two parents at least, is a step up. I push away thoughts of the ways in which this trip, these past few days, the lies that seem to fall from me into an insurmountable pile are jeopardising that for her. For me and Dan. The disrespect my dishonesty brings to our marriage. Because it does, of course.

If it were him lying to me, my heart would break.

The bus takes eight minutes to arrive. I stand, waiting, glad of the ugly sleeping-bag coat now, nervous about the upcoming reunion with Rebecca, watching the minutes tick by on a computerised sign at a wooden bus stop that looks far too old-fashioned for such new-fangled things.

As I head through this unfamiliar town I think how long it has been since I have been anywhere. I wish for a moment that I *was* headed to a spa with a new uncomplicated friend. I feel a pang for it like homesickness. A pang for me a month ago, two, three. A wish that I'd not taken a walk that day, that I hadn't sat next to Rebecca and felt that zing of familiarity that I so rarely get. That reminded me of Izzy and what it had been like to have a best friend.

Wishing, of course, doesn't make things so.

I realise as we whizz past the road I need that I have missed my stop. I get off at the next one and trace my way back.

A nice street but fairly secluded. We'd been a good few stops away from hitting the town centre and I find that actually the address I'd been given is what I would call semi-rural. Three houses in a semicircle but spread far apart from each other. It is a gorgeous farmhouse, which I'd say has recently been modernised, plus it's big and fairly grand.

No doorbell. Instead, taking a deep breath, I thump the heavy, black iron knocker with a lion's face roaring out of it.

REBECCA

Now

‘The house is tidy at least.’

‘It’s not a visit from the Queen, for goodness’ sake.’

Rebecca can hear all kinds of things in her friend’s voice. That hint of jealousy again, a reminder of years gone past. It makes her feel as if she can’t breathe.

‘You know I hate mess.’

‘Which is why we have a cleaner, though you seem dead set on doing her job for her.’

Rebecca gives a tight smile. She needs tidy spaces, and had spent months carefully planning and overseeing the renovation here. ‘I made it perfect here,’ she says now. ‘For us.’

A sigh. ‘I know and I appreciate it. I really do.’

‘Thank you,’ she says. ‘It’s how we wanted it. It’s everything you asked for.’ She can hear the resentment in her words and hates it. The constant niggling. This, she thinks, is not how it was supposed to be.

‘I know. Sorry. I’m just tired.’

Rebecca smiles. ‘But you had a nice time away?’

‘It was a bit lonely,’ is the response.

Rebecca bites down a million hard retorts. Keeps in the anger which she feels growing at an increasing pace. Loneliness is something she’s all too familiar with. Even now, with a newborn, sometimes in the middle of the night when it’s just her and the baby it can feel like there’s no one else in the world.

Luckily she’s saved from replying, because right then comes the knock at

the door.

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‘Ali, you made it.’ Her voice is low, breathless, very different to the clipped, hard tones of last time – ‘*Do I know you?*’ she’d said, eyebrow arched. The memory brings a flush of rage and indignation. I avert my eyes, flicking a glance over her shoulder.

‘Yes,’ I mumble through gritted teeth, ‘I guess I did.’

For a moment she just smiles at me, our eyes meet again and despite all of the anger and confusion I’ve felt towards her I find I smile back.

‘Gosh, come in, come in. It’s cold out there.’

‘Winter is in the air,’ I agree. Words I’ve been speaking to random strangers, shopkeepers and Dan for the past week. The language of England, where small talk almost always centres on the weather.

‘Come through,’ she says and I follow her. Her feet are socked, her clothes are casual. Jeans, a heavy-knit jumper. She is slimmer than I have seen her before, not just her stomach but the rest of her as well; I suppose I must be too. In fact, I noticed the other day as I stepped out of the shower that I looked sharper. My face had become quite round through my pregnancy, soft and full. Now I have cheekbones again and my collarbones stick out. I am, I think, thinner than I was before I became pregnant. I felt a sort of background triumph followed by a sinking feeling because, did it matter? When I was at home ninety per cent of the time now anyway.

In the living room there is a Moses basket not dissimilar to mine. Rebecca sees my eyes rest on it. ‘The baby is sleeping upstairs.’

‘All went well?’

‘All went well, yes.’

‘You, uh, went for the elective Caesarean?’

‘That’s right, very hassle free. I stayed in for a few days and was mostly back to normal within the week. How have you recovered?’ she asks and I’m taken back to when we first met, which feels like a lifetime ago now.

‘Took a while to get over it.’ The understatement of this is still jarring to

me now, all these weeks later. If I stop, even for a second, and contemplate giving birth, I feel panic rise in my chest, my body clenching with remembered pain.

She nods and the strangeness of this situation washes over me. This ordinary conversation we should have been having weeks ago in far happier circumstances. That we are having now, too late and in the middle of a mess I've somehow forced myself into the centre of without meaning to.

A door on the other side of the room opens and I jump, my pulse picking up, heart rate spiking. A small woman with pale blonde hair and large, bright blue eyes comes in. I look from her to Rebecca. She is the woman from the photo in Rebecca's bedroom at Alpine Close.

'Ali,' she says, 'I'd like you to meet Maddie.'

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PART THREE

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MADDIE

2015

His words slur and tumble into each other like dominoes cascading. He lunges forward and she sidesteps, aware now that she too is far more drunk than she'd realised. His hand reaches out and lands with a crash on the small table in the corner of the bedroom. Along its top is her make-up, small pots and tubs of shimmering blushers, eye shadows and smooth, creamy foundations.

It has only been, what? Two days since she arrived at his invitation, after she'd said she was having a tough time at home? He'd seemed so nice, so charming. Good-looking, funny, clever . . . 'You're being a bitch,' he says, lifting his hand and slamming it down, making one of the pots jump and drop to the floor. Thin glittery powder wafts up around them.

'You're off your head,' she tells him, more bravado in her voice than she feels, the vodka making her brave or stupid. Probably stupid, she thinks, as he lunges forwards again, grabbing her arm. Squeezing so hard it makes her gasp, bringing tears to her eyes. 'You're hurting me,' she says, her voice barely a whisper.

'You're hurting me,' he throws back, high and mocking.

'Please,' she says, hating the sound of it, hating herself. He pulls her towards him so his rancid, alcohol-pungent breath is warm and rank in her face. 'Bitch.' Flecks of saliva fly from his mouth to her face. This moment blurs with old, painfully familiar memories.

She raises her knee up hard between his legs, feeling it connect immediately, feeling his entire body tense, watching his eyes widen as he topples forward and passes out in a heap on the floor.

She kneels next to him, listens to his jagged breath. Then she gets to work, grabbing a suitcase from under his bed that doesn't belong to her, flinging her few possessions into it. She pulls on trainers, at odds with the glittering cocktail dress she still has on, picking up her high heels and shoving them in the case, taking his long wool overcoat that completely swamps her, shoving her phone and purse into the deep pocket. She's glad of it as she heads down the stairs and out onto the street; it's summer but the night air is cool. It always is here, the seaside town she grew up in, ridiculously close to the school her parents sent her away to and still never managed to visit.

Just the thought of them makes her feel even worse. It's 3 a.m.; she can't bear the thought of going back to their house even though they won't be there. She hates it most when it is dark and her mind plays tricks on her.

Besides, they'll find out; the housekeeper will be in in the morning and no doubt report straight back. She can't go there, can't admit to yet another failure, can't bear to see her mother roll her eyes or her father make his lips thin and disapproving. She gets her phone out and hits dial.

Answer machine. 'Bex. It's . . . it's me – Maddie. God. Sorry to phone so late, or early. I'm in trouble. Call me, please.'

REBECCA

2015

Rebecca places her phone back down and presses the balls of her hands to her eyes. She feels a headache building along with a million thoughts. The most pressing one being that she doesn't want to call Maddie back and that in itself cuts like a knife.

Her phone beeps and she jumps, grabbing for it, expecting Maddie, but it's Josh.

I'm sure you're super-busy, but my results were actually pretty good – I suspect that means that yours are off the charts? Celebrate with me tonight? I'll buy the bubbles . . .

She reads the message once, twice. Allows her mind to wander, a day-dream of responding with *Um – yes please!*, an image of her grabbing her bag, checking her lipply in the hallway mirror, going and drinking that champagne, lassoing that man that she wants – really, really wants. It's October, the nights are starting to draw in. There's a pub between her flat and Josh's shared house that has an open fire. In another life, another trajectory, she and Josh might sit, watching the flames leap and jump, sipping drinks, high on their own success and full of hope for a future they might just share.

The phone rings. Maddie.

Her heart sinks as she answers. 'Hey.'

'Did you get my messages, where have you been?' She can hear the tears in Maddie's voice, imagines her small face, pinched and frightened. She can also hear the sharp accusation.

'I've only just woken up,' she says, which is almost true. She'd been

awake for about twenty minutes. Enough time to open her results and allow herself a moment of triumph before she'd clicked on her voicemail and listened to Maddie's voice.

'I'm in such a bad place,' she says.

Rebecca shuts her eyes again, the phone pressed to her ear, starting to heat up now as though Maddie's words are burning her.

'Sorry to hear that,' Rebecca mumbles. 'Is it the new medication?' Maddie seems to be put on a different prescription every week. Each drug with awful side effects and, as far as Rebecca can see, very little benefit.

'No. I've stopped taking everything.' Rebecca's eyes snap open at that. 'Everything?' Her mind is whirring. Maddie has pills that help her sleep, the only ones that Rebecca strongly feels her friend needs. She is prone to long periods of time when she hardly sleeps at all. When that happens, she becomes manic and when she becomes manic . . .

'Yes. The whole lot.' She sounds triumphant now, the misery of seconds ago giving way to an unnatural high instead.

'Are you sleeping?' Rebecca demands.

'I don't know. I don't think so, not really.'

'When are your parents home?'

A laugh, a sharp cackle devoid of humour. 'Fuck knows, I left there, like, two days ago.'

'What do you mean, you left? To go where?' Rebecca's voice is rising now, worry making her sound frantic.

'I met a guy,' Maddie says with a sigh. 'Michael. And for a minute, Bex, it was great.'

'But?'

'We fought.'

'Are you hurt?' Rebecca says, knowing this dance all too well and wishing she didn't.

There is a silence then that stretches out. Rebecca knows that Maddie is just waiting for her to fill it, that eventually she'll have to.

It gets so long it starts to feel loud. She hears herself say, 'Why don't I come and see you?'

'That would be great. Thank you, Bex, I'm on the pier.' The relief in her voice is tangible and Rebecca feels the usual gnawing guilt. 'See you soon.' She is gone before Rebecca can say she didn't mean right now.

She re-reads the message from Josh. Eventually she types back, *Off to see*

my friend in Sussex, so sorry, another time?

Sure! he comes back with brightly. But, Rebecca thinks, she won't be taking him up on the offer anytime soon, and she doubts he'll keep asking. This is at least the fifth time she's blown him off. Every time she is close to saying yes, she finds her memories sliding back to Oliver. How it had felt to lose her head and her heart. The danger that led to the awful, tragic, unforeseeable outcome, Maddie's late-night voicemails a stark reminder of all the damage she'd done.

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ALI

Now

‘You’re Maddie?’

She nods. ‘Yes.’

‘I thought . . . I thought Maddie was your baby,’ I say to Rebecca, though I realise now that I had no reason to think this. Is this what I do? Make connections where there are none?

‘The baby’s name is James, which was my father’s middle name. A boy,’ Rebecca tells me, a smile flashing across her face, faint and strained.

‘I don’t understand. I saw you arguing with a man who came to my house; he asked after Maddie. Joshua Hall.’

‘He came to your house?’ Maddie’s head whips round to exchange a look with Rebecca.

‘He said he wanted to know where Maddie was.’ My voice is rising. I shake my head as though by moving the thoughts around this whole thing will make sense. It doesn’t.

‘Ali . . .’ Rebecca’s voice, cool, calm, collected. Exactly as I remembered her, how I’d thought she was. Right now, though, it is jarring.

‘He’s missing,’ I say, my voice louder, higher. ‘Joshua Hall is missing. The police think I’m involved.’

They exchange another look, Rebecca and this woman . . . Maddie. Not the baby. Rebecca’s baby is a boy. Not baby Maddie, the playmate I’d imagined for Charlie. Not what I’d imagined at all.

‘Missing?’ Rebecca asks, her tone bewildered. ‘Maddie?’

The little, pretty blonde woman shakes her head. ‘I don’t know . . .’

‘Ali, sit down.’ Rebecca’s voice is firm and despite the fact she really has

no authority over me, no right to tell me what to do, I sink into the chair.

‘Maddie, go and put some coffee on.’

‘But . . .’

‘Now.’ Rebecca levels her gaze at her friend. She is in charge, I think. Of me, of Maddie. Of everything. I suddenly realise that no one knows where I am. It hadn’t occurred to me for a moment that I might be in danger, but now the thought crosses my mind, the old feeling of being watched that I’d convinced myself was all in my head, which turned out to be true. I *was* being watched, by Joshua Hall. A man who entered my house without permission. A man who is now missing. Who the police are extremely concerned about. Now I am here with two women, one of whom has deceived me again and again, the other one a stranger who hadn’t looked that startled when I’d said a man was missing.

My breathing is laboured and uneven. I find I can’t quite catch my breath.

‘Ali. Ali.’ Rebecca’s voice sounds distant and far away. ‘Ali.’ She takes my hands in hers. ‘Look at me. Look at me.’

I do, our eyes meeting, my breath still jagged and out of reach. ‘I can’t breathe,’ I manage to gasp.

‘You can, I promise. Breathe with me, we’ll do it together – in for three and out for three. In – one . . . two . . . three. Out – one . . . two . . . three . . .’

We carry on like this, I don’t know how long for, but eventually I calm down, my chest eases, the prickly feeling of pins and needles in my heart leaves me.

‘Panic attack,’ Maddie says. My eyes snap to her and she smiles, not unkindly, putting a full tray on the table. ‘I’ve had a few.’

‘Who *are* you?’ I ask.

Rebecca picks up a cup from the table and hands it to me. ‘Drink this, take a moment and I’ll explain.’

MADDIE

2015

Maddie looks in the small compact mirror in her bag. Her eyes are glassy and tinged with broken red veins. They are dark-ringed, purple smudges sitting in the soft, delicate parts underneath her bright blue irises. The colour of bruises clashing. She is attractive nonetheless, she knows that, gets told often enough as though she should be eternally grateful for her genetic luck. She pulls her legs up underneath the coat, the wind whipping off the sea and making her hair jump up around her. She can smell her own body, fetid and bitter. She can still smell him, lingering on her skin. She pushes her head down onto her knees, reliving the awful argument that had culminated in her own violence. Is she just as bad? She's never sure. She just knows that all of her relationships seem to follow this quick, sharp pattern. Her temper had been a hot topic of conversation when she'd been locked away, deemed a danger to herself if no one else. 'Why,' asked the psychiatrist, a stern-faced woman who looked like she was grimacing every time she smiled, 'do you take drugs?'

'I don't,' had been her tart response, not pointing out that with every day spent in the hellish hospital, her narcotic consumption seemed to grow and expand. The same psychiatrist who admonished her 'partying' scribbled prescriptions for everything that ailed Maddie. For her feelings, which she was told over and over weren't quite right, and as she thinks about her knee connecting with Michael's groin and the swell of triumph she felt as a result, she can probably agree.

'Hey.'

Maddie looks up; there is her friend, her saviour, the only person in the

world who has ever understood. She is holding her hand out and Maddie takes it whilst Rebecca holds her at arm's length, studying Maddie's face and body, her eyes searching for obvious damage. 'Are you hurt?'

'No,' she says, though her arm aches where his hard, strong fingers had dug in, and her ribs are sore from yesterday, when he punched her so hard in her side that she's quite sure something is broken. 'Not badly. I kneed him in the bollocks.'

'Good. He sounds like a dick.'

'Yes.'

Rebecca sighs, pulling Maddie to her, hugging her tight. Maddie lets herself sink into her friend's arms. She'd been furious when Rebecca hadn't answered, then sad as she thought perhaps she never would. Now, her resentment fades.

'Let's go to your place.'

'Mum and Dad's?' Maddie clarifies.

'Yes, are they there?'

'No. They're on holiday, with Tim.' She tries to keep her voice light but even saying her brother's name makes her feel sore and bruised in a way that is far worse than the hands that so recently clenched the top of her arm.

'You didn't want to go?'

'No,' Maddie says, not needing to expand. Rebecca knows about Tim. She's the only person outside of their family who does. And as her mum has stated endlessly that Maddie made the whole thing up, her family don't really count.

'Okay, well, that's probably good, that they aren't here?'

'Yes, they'll be back tomorrow though.'

REBECCA

2015

She knows what Maddie is going to ask. Knows her friend as well as she knows herself. They get into the house. A sprawling, beautiful mansion, colder inside than it is out today. Rebecca has never liked the place, always felt it was too sterile, not like somewhere people actually live, and, a lot of the time, the house did stand empty.

‘How long have they been gone?’ she asks Maddie.

‘A few days, but they’d only just got back from the last jaunt. I’d say they’ve been gone more than they’ve been home for at least three months.’

‘You’ve been here alone?’

‘Yes, well, Michael’s been here on and off, and some of his friends. We’ve had some parties but mostly it’s just been me. I was hoping staying with him might work out,’ she says and Rebecca feels a stab of guilt. Maddie has been out of hospital now for almost four years and she’s had plenty of false starts, most involving ill thought-out, toxic relationships. She always seems to end up back here and, if Rebecca doesn’t like it, she can only imagine how awful it must be for Maddie.

‘I’m so sorry I haven’t visited for a while.’

Maddie sighs. ‘I know you’ve had exams and I’m not exactly down the road, am I?’

‘No,’ Rebecca says. ‘But still.’

‘It would be better if I was closer.’

‘Yes, I suppose it would.’ The question is coming, of course it is.

Maddie sits up, turning to face Rebecca, putting their faces barely inches apart.

‘I want to move to London.’

‘Well, that sounds great,’ Rebecca says, the words sticking in her throat like lumpy uncooked rice, she is unsure why. It’s what they’d talked about, what they’d always planned to do. Be neighbours, live on the same road – that was the dream, once upon a time. But now Rebecca has a life separate from Maddie. She has friends, her course, work to do. Her dad. ‘Does that mean I can come and stay with you, Bex?’

‘I mean, it’s my dad’s flat, I’d have to check.’ Though she doesn’t really.

‘Just for a bit till I get on my feet again.’

‘Of course,’ she says. ‘Of course you can.’ Because she owes Maddie and this is the least she can do.

ALI

Now

The coffee is welcome though I'm not sure the caffeine does much to actually soothe me – I find as I set the cup down that my hand is shaking. Rebecca's apology doesn't quite register although I am glad to hear a crack in her voice. Perhaps I meant something to her after all.

'Where *is* the baby?' I ask Rebecca, realising as soon as I do that I've asked and she's told me.

'Sleeping.' She gives me a small smile. 'Something he prefers to do during daytime hours, sadly. Is Charlie good at night?'

He, she had said; James, after her father. A boy. 'Yes,' I manage, 'very.'

'They all seem to be different,' she says with a sigh.

'I suppose they are.'

'I found it very tough going,' she says, 'especially the first few nights, like I've been tired before, but never like that.'

I smile faintly. 'I know exactly what you mean.'

'At least I was a bit more prepared after our midnight chats. Thank you for those.'

'They helped me too,' I tell her, and they had.

'Thank you, too,' Rebecca says, 'for coming here, for trusting me.'

'I'm starting to regret it, to be honest.'

'Don't, please.'

'Was that man, Joshua, your husband?'

'Not exactly,' Rebecca says.

REBECCA

2015

‘Are you nervous?’

‘Yes, very.’ She gives Joshua a quick smile. A big day for them both, the first day of their respective pupillages. Her dad had offered her a space at his chambers which she’d turned down, not because she wouldn’t have loved the chance to work with him, but she wanted to know she could make her own way. When she’d told him this, trying desperately not to make him feel rejected, he’d been genuinely delighted. Smiling his soft smile and saying, ‘That makes me even more proud of you.’ Now, as her stomach fizzes and twists like a nest of vipers, she is half wishing she’d taken him up on his offer.

‘Are you?’ she asks Joshua.

He shrugs. ‘Nah, cool as a cucumber.’ Grinning his crooked grin.

‘Really?’

‘God no, I’m shitting it.’ They both laugh. ‘Another coffee?’

‘No, I don’t think my nervous system can handle it,’ she says.

‘Mine neither to be honest.’

‘It’s been nice though, to see you.’

‘It’s been *ages*,’ he says, and it has been. Maddie has been living with her the past three months, seeing off the summer, welcoming in the autumn. She was back to her very best self and they’d had, to Rebecca’s surprise, a lot of fun. Maddie was like a tourist in London and Rebecca had taken her everywhere: museums, open-topped buses, the theatre, trendy bars with graffitied walls, restaurants that served entire meals on wooden chopping boards accompanied by elaborate drinks in Kilner jars.

‘I know, sorry. Like I said, my friend has sort of, well, she *has* moved in.’

‘That’s nice,’ he says.

‘Yes, do you know, it has been.’

‘You sound surprised,’ he says with a laugh.

‘Yeah, no, I mean, I didn’t mean it like that.’ But she’s smiling back. ‘She, uh, had a few problems at the end of school,’ Rebecca says; a massive understatement. Omitting to tell him that these problems were her fault. That when Maddie had asked to come and stay, Rebecca didn’t feel like she had any choice but to say yes.

‘Oh, sorry to hear that.’

Rebecca waves a hand. ‘Yeah, it wasn’t great, but actually she’s doing really well, we’ve had a fantastic summer.’

‘Amazing. Bring her to my party on Friday!’

‘Oh really, would that be alright?’ she says, relief flooding her. She’d been dreading telling Maddie, had been contemplating just not going rather than leaving her at home alone on a Friday night.

‘Yes, of course. Then you’ve got no excuse not to come.’ Is there a dig in those words? A reminder that every invitation had been turned down? She catches his eye and he smiles his warm smile. Even if there is something behind what he said, she figures it’s only because he wants to see her. Which is good, isn’t it? She’s not allowed herself to even contemplate him, as though punitive measures could save her from her past. But now Maddie seems okay, *they* are okay, their friendship finally back on a solid footing. Maybe it’s time Rebecca started going for a few more frivolous things, like a boyfriend. Maddie herself has pointed out numerous times that Rebecca needs to have more fun, and since Maddie’s been there she has to admit life has been more exciting. She’ll need to get her head down once the pupillage starts, but maybe, just maybe, there will be room for a relationship. A relationship with Joshua?

She’ll go home and tell Maddie about Josh. To ask her opinion and perhaps, Rebecca acknowledges to herself, her permission to some degree. Maddie had saved her from something awful with Oliver. Something Rebecca tried desperately hard not to think about. She’d loved him, she thought, in that cloying teenage way where everything feels unreal and heightened.

She’d believed he felt the same way about her, which is what made his betrayal so much worse. She could still feel it now, the absolute devastation.

Made worse later when there were police everywhere, blue lights making Maddie look like a ghoul, small body scrunched in a tight little ball in the corner. Rebecca turning to the men in uniform, wide-eyed, shock making her heart pound. She'd looked out the open window, over the balcony, small groups of teenagers littering the lawn, and she knew if she walked further forwards, leaned over, she'd see him . . . then the police had searched the room, pulling out a carefully wrapped package from Rebecca's bag. The bag she'd brought to the party where she'd blacked out. Waking up to see Maddie and Oliver fighting on the balcony seconds before . . . well . . . The police saying to Rebecca, 'Is this yours?' Rebecca opening her mouth, fear making the words difficult. Maddie's voice cutting between her and the officers. 'It's mine.'

She squeezes her eyes shut now, pushing the memory away. She inhales, exhales, counting as she does so. Then she turns the key in the lock, plasters a smile to her face and calls out, 'Hey!'

MADDIE

2015

She's sitting frozen on the sofa of this beautiful flat in this wonderful city where she feels safe and at home. Her peace shattered by an awful, terrible conversation with her mother.

Rebecca comes in grinning from ear to ear, the smile fading as she takes in Maddie's expression.

'Maddie, what's the matter?'

'It's Dad,' she says, 'he's had a heart attack.'

'Oh my God.' Rebecca puts her bag down on the floor by the coffee table and heads over, sinking next to Maddie, taking her hand. 'Is he . . . how is he?'

'Mum says they think he'll be fine.' Her voice is a whisper.

'Well, that's good, isn't it?'

'Yes. I mean, she said it was my fault.'

'What? Why would she say that?'

'I called them, yesterday. I, um . . . my allowance, I was hoping they'd put it up. Dad started to have a go at me about missing Tim's thirtieth. I told him I never wanted to see Tim again, which I've said a million times.'

'Which is fair enough,' Rebecca says, but Maddie knows her friend isn't really able to imagine the full horror of that situation. Tim had started bullying Maddie when she was just ten years old, culminating in an attack where he pushed her down the stairs, leaving her injured and mentally bereft. When she'd told her mother what had happened, her mother had called her a liar and six months later Maddie had been sent to Oakwood.

'He said, could I not think of him and Mum – but they never thought of

me, Bex, did they?’

‘No, they didn’t and you haven’t caused anyone to have a heart attack, for goodness’ sake. Come here.’ Maddie lets Rebecca engulf her, feeling the comfort she always does around her best friend. ‘It’s okay now, Maddie. You’re safe, okay?’

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ALI

Now

‘He is . . . was . . . no, I guess officially still is, Maddie’s husband.’

Maddie nods, the corners of her mouth turned down. ‘That’s true. For now.’ A phone rings loud and shrill. A landline, I can’t remember the last time I heard such a thing. Rebecca smiles at me. ‘Reception out here can be tricky. Maddie, would you?’

She goes, and I hear the faint murmur of her voice from another room.

I frown. Rebecca sighs. ‘The baby was going to be Maddie’s. I was merely a surrogate.’

‘What?’

‘Well.’ Rebecca leans her head to one side. ‘That’s not quite true. I mean, the baby is mine biologically. Maddie asked me to help.’

‘Joshua is the baby’s father, though?’ My voice is high, incredulous.

‘Yes, biologically.’

‘Biologically.’ I laugh but it is humourless, a thin, hysterical sound. ‘That man is missing. The police clearly think it’s suspicious and they must have cause, mustn’t they? They think I’m involved,’ I tell Rebecca. ‘The police have said I am a person of interest.’

‘They’ll know soon enough that’s not the case.’

‘Will they? I have to go and give them my fingerprints.’

‘Ali, you weren’t there when he went missing, were you? I’m sure you have nothing to worry about.’

Maddie, this woman I don’t know, who, it seems, is at the centre of all this, comes back into the room. ‘Sales call,’ she murmurs. Dan was right, of course, this was a mess best left well alone.

‘So, you had Maddie’s baby? But it’s your baby?’ I shake my head. ‘None of this makes any sense.’

‘I was pregnant,’ Maddie says now. ‘Josh and I, we . . . well, we had problems, he . . . he was abusive.’ Her eyes flick to mine then back down again. ‘We fought, he pushed me. I lost the baby.’

‘I’m sorry,’ I say, though my voice is flat, any sympathy I would have shown in ordinary circumstances eclipsed by the strangeness of the whole situation. The lies, the baby, the missing man.

‘Joshua said it was just as well, we shouldn’t have even tried for a child anyway. He said I’d be a terrible mother.’ Her eyes fill with tears, her lip quivering. ‘I was devastated, but agreed. All that side, the physical side of our relationship, well . . . it wasn’t going to happen anyway. We’d, uh . . . that pregnancy, the first one, was through IVF. We had a few issues, trying to conceive. I won’t bore you with the details but I can tell you I had longed for that child and when he said no to us trying again, I . . . I was heartbroken.’

‘Even though he was abusive?’ I ask.

‘Even though.’ She swallows thickly. ‘During IVF we froze Joshua’s sperm and he signed all kinds of waivers, basically consenting to various procedures for ten years. They, uh, included surrogacy.’

I look from Rebecca to Maddie and back to Rebecca as I piece it together. ‘You . . . used his sample? Without him knowing?’ I ask, aghast. ‘You . . . you’re a lawyer?’

‘Barrister. Yes. A huge risk, ethically murky.’ She rubs a hand over her face and, I think, underneath her careful, well-applied make-up there is a tightness to the set of her jaw, the corners of her mouth, which turn up now in a quick, weary smile.

‘And legally?’

Rebecca’s face pales, the hint of a smile dropped, and she chews the corner of her lip. ‘The paperwork was sent to his email address for electronic signature. It’s all above board on paper.’

‘On paper?’

‘I opened the email,’ says Maddie.

‘My God. This is . . . mad. I was worried about you,’ I say to Rebecca, tears stinging my eyes, making them hot and itchy. ‘I thought we were friends.’

‘We were. God, we were. It’s all my fault, obviously,’ Rebecca says. ‘Be-

ing pregnant, being away from Maddie at that time, having to stop working. I was lonely, then we got talking and . . . we clicked, didn't we?"

'I thought so,' I half whisper.

'It was unfair of me. I knew I was going to be leaving, knew I wouldn't be raising the baby there, and not by myself. Maddie was getting herself together to leave Joshua, but carrying on as normal so he wouldn't suspect anything and start digging around. Obviously he couldn't find out what we were planning.'

'It's mad,' I tell her again. A word I don't use lightly. A word I try not to use at all, having had it directed at me in the worst possible scenarios. 'I can't believe you got away with it.'

'Neither can I,' she says. 'I spent the whole pregnancy worried; no one could know, not from here, not for now. We wanted to make sure Joshua never found out and that Maddie was free. But, for a minute, when I met you, I started imagining that we'd have our babies at the same time, that they'd be friends. That everything about my situation was normal. I guess I got sucked up in the fantasy of it all.'

I wipe a hand over my face, trying to absorb this. I don't feel frightened any more. I feel angry.

'Then what the hell has happened to Joshua?'

'That, I'm not sure about. Though we were aware he had become suspicious.'

'Suspicious how?'

'He found some receipts,' Maddie pipes up, 'for baby things I'd bought and a train ticket to Rebecca's place.'

We are interrupted by a familiar sort of cry. 'The baby,' Rebecca murmurs. 'Maddie, would you?'

Maddie nods, standing.

When she is gone I say to Rebecca, 'Why would you do this? For her?'

She sighs. 'Lots of reasons, but the main one is that I owed her.'

'Owed her? Enough to give her a baby illegally?' Rebecca opens her mouth to protest, but I interrupt her, 'Sorry, I mean in "ethically murky" circumstances.'

Rebecca flinches at the hardness in my voice. 'Maddie and I have known each other for years, we were at boarding school together. My father was a widower, my mother dead. When my nanny moved to be near her own daughter, he didn't know what to do with me so he sent me away. Maddie

had some trouble with her parents, which is putting it lightly. But let's just say we were both adrift and became close.'

I think of my own bewildered mother, left to care for me while my father swanned off to find himself. Thinking how lonely I felt at times, how surplus to requirements, always wondering if her life would be better without me in it. But how would I have felt if she'd sent me away? Despite myself, I feel a twinge of sympathy for Rebecca.

'Right,' I manage, and Rebecca smiles that strained smile again. Beneath her eyes are purple smudges.

'It's difficult to explain what it was like for us, finding each other, becoming friends. Anyway.' She waves a hand. 'There was an incident at a party when we were both still at school, a . . . a police investigation. Drugs, of all the predictable stupidity.' She shakes her head. 'It was something silly and regrettable, linked to a boy I'd met and, well . . . I was stupid, but I was already heading towards being a lawyer, it's what my father had planned for me, there was no room for me to deviate from that. A criminal record, even a minor one, would have impacted those plans. Maddie took the blame for me.'

MADDIE

2015

‘Are you sure I look alright?’ Maddie peers at herself in the mirror, eyes narrowed, face scrunched up.

Rebecca smiles. ‘If by alright you mean absolutely gorgeous, then – yes, you look alright.’ And she does, she knows she does, in a small black dress, demure kitten heels.

‘So do you,’ Maddie says, turning around and pulling her friend in close. ‘Thank you so much for inviting me.’

‘Of course,’ Rebecca says, ‘and besides, Joshua invited you, it’s his party after all.’

‘Joshua, eh?’ Maddie pulls back, raising an eyebrow at Rebecca.

Rebecca laughs, ‘I’ve already told you, it’s nothing like that.’

Maddie smiles, not quite believing Rebecca but clinging on to it anyway. The truth is, she needs her friend right now. She should have come to London sooner, should have known that as soon as she was with Rebecca again, everything would be fine. But what she doesn’t want is Rebecca falling in love, that would spell trouble. ‘I’m looking forward to meeting him and all of your friends, even if I am unemployed and they’re all swot barristers in training.’

‘I said you’d been away for the past year and were at mine deciding what to do next, which is true enough.’

‘I guess.’

But she feels so nervous. The thought of meeting all of Rebecca’s super--clever friends. What would she say to them when they asked what she did after school? *Oh, got locked up in a psych ward and tried to stop waking*

every ten minutes during the night because I could see a dead boy's eyes staring at me.

'Come on.'

They walk through London; Maddie as always is enchanted by every aspect of the city. She loves it here, the hustle and bustle, the anonymity in the midst of a crowd. There was so much to see and do. 'God, the Thames is magnificent, isn't it!'

Rebecca laughs, 'I suppose it is!'

'I love it here,' says Maddie. 'Where I grew up is so dull in comparison.'

'It's pretty there though.'

Maddie wrinkles her nose. 'Who wants pretty when you can have fun?'

Rebecca grins. 'I think you brought the fun along with you.'

'Really?' Maddie says, pleased at the comment.

'Really, it's been a great summer.'

'The best,' Maddie says.

They arrive at the house and a handsome man answers the door, his face made even more gorgeous by a burgeoning smile as he sees Rebecca, who thrusts a bottle of good champagne out to him. 'I bought this.'

'Thank you. Come in, come in.'

They step over the threshold. 'This is my friend Maddie.'

He turns warm eyes to her and puts his hand out to shake. Maddie smiles at him and he takes their coats, hanging them on an overloaded peg in the hallway and walking them out into a large open-plan kitchen with bifold doors which are open. He looks, she thinks, almost exactly how Oliver would have done if he'd made it to this age.

REBECCA

2015

The garden is lit with rows of fairy lights and Rebecca is pleased to see heaters dotted about.

Joshua keeps up a steady stream of chatter and Rebecca finds herself, as always, soothed by his voice. On the long breakfast bar there are filled plastic glasses. He points to everything, 'White wine, red, Prosecco, beer and cider.'

'Wow, this is super organised!' Rebecca tells him.

'Well, you know Hannah, she likes to make sure all fun is organised.'

'Is Hannah your girlfriend?' Maddie asks. Rebecca's eyes snap to her face but Maddie is laser-focused on Josh.

He laughs, 'No, she's my sister and also my super-controlling flatmate.'

'You're single then?' Maddie presses.

Joshua nods and Rebecca can now see redness creeping up his neck. 'I'm surprised,' Maddie says.

She is flirting with him, Rebecca thinks. She is flirting with this man I am half in love with. Her heart pounds, her hands dampen, not-quite-forgotten resentments bubble to the surface. She should say something, tell Maddie. But she is distracted by Hannah and Rose and all of her friends from university who she hasn't seen all summer. She gets swept up from group to group and sees Maddie talking to Lee McCormick who is a bit of a prick. In normal circumstances she probably would have said something to her friend, but it means that Maddie isn't talking to Josh and Rebecca feels relieved, knowing that she'll need to say something to him herself, sooner rather than later.

The party winds down, people leave. Rebecca has a gentle buzz and feels her whole body relaxing. The tension of the past few weeks, the hard and onerous grind of her pupillage, the constant worrying about Maddie, who seems alright now, but for how long? Plus, she still isn't working and although money isn't an issue for her friend, who has a hefty trust fund, surely boredom is bad for the mind?

Finally, it is just her, Joshua and Rose, who is asleep on the sofa. In the garden she can hear Maddie's laugh, occasionally catching glimpses of the ends of her and Lee's cigarettes.

'Has Hannah gone to bed?' Rebecca asks Josh.

'Yep, lightweight.' He smiles then adds, 'To be fair, I think this is the latest I've been up all summer.'

'Is it?'

'Yes, I spent most of it working, or at least trying to work so I didn't feel overwhelmed when my placement started.'

'Did it work?'

'Nope, I'm terrified every morning – you?'

'Actually I've been pleasantly surprised.'

'Pfft,' he says, but he's smiling. She has one of the plastic wine glasses in her hand, it's almost empty and she's about to take a sip when she thinks, he's going to kiss me, and finds herself holding the glass and her breath, waiting, waiting, and then . . .

A piercing scream from outside.

She doesn't know which one of them jumps up first, but she spills the remnants of the wine, the vague thought crossing her mind that it will stain if they don't tend to it immediately.

Then they are both outside.

Maddie is flat on her back on the damp grass, Lee on top of her, Maddie struggling.

Josh moves so fast he is a blur; he yanks the man off Maddie and starts hitting him. Once, twice, again. Maddie is screaming again now, but for Josh to stop, as is Rebecca. It is Rebecca's voice that ends it. The two men stand, nose to nose, Lee glaring at Josh, Josh glaring right back. The cold night air seems to swirl around them all. Rebecca goes to Maddie, kneeling beside her, feeling wet blades of grass press against her bare knees.

'Are you okay?' Her voice is a whisper.

‘He . . . he pushed me down,’ Maddie manages.

Rebecca stands, spinning round to look at Lee. At Joshua. Lee’s face is a bloody mess, one eye already swelling, making it appear smaller. The flesh looks like tenderised meat. Rebecca feels a swell of nausea. Joshua looks . . . deranged, she thinks.

She hates violence in any form, even if the person on the receiving end deserves it. She holds out a hand out to Maddie. ‘Can you stand?’

When her friend nods, Rebecca pulls Maddie to her feet, then walks over to Josh, placing a hand on his arm. It snaps him out of whatever dark reverie he is in, but he turns to her with a snarl and, she thinks, he even looks different. She takes a step back and his face falls, the fury immediately softening. ‘Rebecca,’ he says. Just that one word. Just her name and she thinks, he is back, from whatever place he was in that made him beat his friend to a pulp.

He turns back to Lee, angry again, but Lee has some sense and is turning around now, staggering but walking away. Josh takes a step towards him and again Rebecca places a hand on his arm. ‘Don’t,’ is all she says, and that at least stills him, though she can feel the pent-up rage in the rigidity of his muscles.

As Lee disappears towards the back of the garden and the gate leading to the street, Josh finally relaxes and turns to Maddie, his mouth set in a grim line. ‘Are you alright?’

She nods.

‘Did he . . .?’

‘No, he would have though.’ Her voice is small. ‘You saved me!’

ALI

Now

Rebecca's voice is little more than a whisper as she tells me what Maddie did her for as a teenager and I hear in it regret, pain. In the short time I'd known Rebecca one of the things I'd liked about her was her bluntness. Honest, I'd thought. Like Izzy but without the bitchiness. Had I completely misread her? I didn't think so, which means that whatever happened that night, the sacrifice Maddie made must have left its mark, to make her agree to lie and essentially steal a man's sperm.

As if reading my thoughts, Rebecca tells me, 'It was the wrong thing to do, but it's what we did. What *I* did.'

Maddie comes back into the room, a baby boy, bigger than Charlie, wrapped in her arms. She puts him down on a playmat and Rebecca smiles warmly at him.

Maddie leans over, gripping Rebecca's hand, squeezing it and letting go. 'I was already in trouble ninety per cent of the time anyway, plus I was still seventeen. It would have been worse for you,' she says to her with a sort of crooked grin. To me she says, 'I owned up, quickly, before Bex had a chance to, she didn't actually ask me to do it. The bags were searched by the police. I said it was mine. I was sent to a secure unit.'

'Like prison?'

'Not exactly, more like a place for disturbed children, "delinquents" whose parents had money,' she says, a hint of bitterness in her voice.

'And were you?'

'Disturbed?'

'Yes.'

She laughs, 'Boarding school is basically care for rich people – for some parents anyway.' I wince a little at this, 'poor little rich girl' springing to mind, but keep quiet. 'Some girls loved it there and thrived, most went home in the holidays to loving families.' She shrugs. 'I was sent away from home at eleven and hardly ever went back. I was sad about it, I guess, but at least it kept me away from my abusive bastard of a brother. He was my mother's favourite, could do no wrong, and my dad, well, he was good at keeping the status quo. Unlike me.' She sighs. 'But I wasn't dangerous like the school made out, even if my parents were quick to agree with them. I think they probably saw the secure unit as a new way to brush aside their problems. Certainly my mum used the drugs charge to try to convince my dad that was why I'd lied about Tim – "Look how dishonest and unstable she is." It fit their narrative, but no, I wasn't dangerous to anyone perhaps other than myself.'

'She wasn't,' Rebecca says quickly. 'As I said, it was me who had broken the law. Not on purpose, I'd picked up my boyfriend's wallet, put it in my bag, not realising what was in it, but still, it was Maddie who took the blame. And the punishment. Something I will always be grateful to her for. Surely you can understand why, for a friend like that, one who needed my help, I didn't think twice.'

'Why didn't you just tell the truth, say the drugs were your boyfriend's?' It's not really the point, but the thought escapes before I can stop it.

'That . . . that wasn't possible.' Rebecca's eyes flick away from mine.

'And you . . . you couldn't have your own baby?' I ask Maddie, softer this time.

'After what Josh did to me, the baby I was carrying then . . .' Her hand clenches to her stomach, her eyes down. 'After that, it just didn't happen. I was . . . damaged.'

'Is this on record?' I ask. Part of me wants to comfort her, to say how terribly sorry I am that she lost a child and in such horrific circumstances. But I don't know this woman and I need to find a way to separate myself from this situation, from both of these women with their murky pasts and even murkier present.

She's shaking her head. 'I wish it were. I wish I'd had the guts to go to the police, to go and get help. I wish I'd left him there and then.'

'I wish you'd told me,' Rebecca says, her eyes filling with tears as she contemplates her friend. I imagine them then, all those years ago. Imagine a

bond that strong.

‘We had drifted apart a bit,’ Rebecca tells me. ‘Maddie married Josh, I became a lawyer, we were in touch but didn’t see each other often. Then one night, Maddie came to see me, she was bruised, messed up, she told me she had been pregnant but had lost the baby, almost a year ago at that point. She told me what was really going on with Josh, how awful it had been.’

I look at Maddie. ‘I’m sorry,’ I murmur and she nods, head hung low.

‘I wanted that baby, I was desperate to try again.’ Maddie’s voice is small and thin.

Rebecca says, ‘I said to Maddie when she showed up and told me all of this that she should leave him, get away, but then we started thinking, *we* would be able to raise a child, give it a good life even. Both of us had had our fair share of losses growing up, but maybe we could right some of that now, forge a family unit of our own. I said I’d do whatever would make her happy. We agreed that I’d carry the baby and we’d use my eggs, so to the clinic I looked like a willing surrogate and it was all done privately where we had to tick boxes but discretion was also valued. Maddie would stay with Joshua whilst I carried the baby, which would give me time to sell up, get this house in order, and then we’d leave together.’

‘You were going to give up your own career, just like that?’ I ask her, feeling the weight of this sacrifice, the enormity of it.

Rebecca shrugs. ‘Not for ever perhaps. I knew that eventually I’d probably work again. I have my own practice, after all, and figured I’d become a silent partner for now.’

‘But now this, now he’s missing. He came to my house. He . . .’ I swallow. ‘He must have seen me following you, so he must have had suspicions.’

‘Yes,’ she agrees. ‘He came to see me, wanting to know where Maddie was.’ She shakes her head. ‘I figured as soon as we were gone that would be that. The paperwork is tight, everything is done.’

‘He must have found out,’ I tell her, ‘what you two have done.’

‘Yes,’ she says, ‘I suppose he must.’ He, this man, the father of her baby? Maddie’s baby? Or Rebecca’s? This whole thing is messed up and yet, in a way, I’m touched, I suppose, by the loyalty these two women feel for each other. That unshakable bond.

‘What happened?’ I ask. ‘With Joshua . . . Where is he?’ The words trail off.

‘I honestly don’t know,’ Rebecca says. ‘But I’m going to do everything I

can to find out and quickly.'

'He is a dangerous, unstable man,' Maddie says. 'I can only apologise; we never wanted you to be dragged into this.'

'You have to go to the police,' I say, 'explain what you did – it must be relevant.'

'I know,' Rebecca says. 'You're right, of course you are, and we will, but can I ask one favour?'

'What?'

'Just give us a few days?'

'Why?'

'Let me see if I can find him first, please.'

'I've been lying to *my* husband about this. He said it was obsessive, that I was unhinged, and he was probably right.' I laugh in a sort of manic way that does little to dispel the statement I just made. 'I was worried about you,' I tell Rebecca. Not adding the rest, that I was hurt too, and raw and bruised from having a baby. Lonely, contemplating my own future, looking for the one person who'd seemed to understand briefly the weight of impending motherhood.

'I'm sorry,' Rebecca says, her eyes shining with unshed tears. 'I should never have met up with you, struck up a friendship.'

'Why did you?'

'I was lonely and I liked you.' Which is all it takes for me to agree to their terms.

MADDIE

2015

Maddie spends the rest of the weekend ensconced in Rebecca's flat, the two of them hidden away from the world, and it feels to her like they could be back at Oakwood, ignoring the other girls in their dorm, in a bubble of two. They order in food, watch re-runs of *Friends* and neither of them get dressed. By Sunday it's as if it never happened, but Maddie knows only too well how things can fester. She often lies awake, thinking about that terrible night all those years ago. The panic, the nausea, the cold. She always remembers that; she was absolutely freezing. Standing there half-crazed on the balcony, knowing that, below on the ground, lay Oliver. The boy she'd been sure she loved, the boy she would have done anything for. The boy that nearly smashed this friendship apart.

Rebecca had been drunk, really off-her-head-level out of it. Something she never normally did. Maddie had watched her friend with a growing sense of unease. Something was up, it was in her mumbled words, in the sharp-eyed, hard glares she threw at Maddie.

She knows, she had thought. She knows.

She stands now, heading to the bathroom in this gorgeous flat where she has felt safe and at home this summer. Where she has felt rescued. She hadn't slept well last night though, not at all; she'd dreamed of being chased, then eventually in the cold light of morning, memories pressed in with the dreams.

Oliver; she never forgets and often relives the horror of seeing him fly backwards. It was like watching a film in slow motion, until the terrible crunch of his body smashing to the ground below. Next came the police

search. Every kid at the party was required to comply as part of the investigation, to rule out foul play. They'd found the drugs straight away.

Rebecca had stared open-mouthed at the officer and Maddie could see the implications, and also her chance to make things better.

'That's my bag,' said Maddie, stepping forward.

The drug charges were unavoidable; though Maddie's parents, along with Rebecca's father, who'd been dragged into the sorry mess, were always suspicious, they never got the full story. They saw to it that Maddie spent her 'sentence' in psychiatric care rather than prison and her mother used it as a fresh opportunity to tell anyone who would listen that Maddie was bad news.

She was a minor, it should have been a pretty forgettable offence, but a boy had died. Oliver's tox screen had shown up large quantities of the same drugs found in the bag. People had seen them together at the party; it wasn't rocket science to trace the drugs back to them.

Maddie's world was turned upside down, she was locked up, locked away, and Rebecca was the only person who came, who kept her just about tethered to the outside world. On that ward Maddie had grieved for Oliver, for herself, for the loss of an innocence that for her was always so fragile, because Tim had stamped that out, hadn't he? She wondered so many times if her mother was right – was she bad? Certainly trouble followed her wherever she went, a black cloud hovering on the edges.

But it worked, taking the blame. Rebecca forgave her. And she owed her.

REBECCA

2015

On Sunday, Rebecca decides it's time to stop hiding from the world and turns her phone on. Missed call alerts from Josh flood in. She steps away from whichever hypnotic TV show they'd been watching and calls him back.

'Josh?'

'Rebecca, finally! I've been trying to call . . . I . . .'

 Josh seems uncharacteristically lost for words then settles on, 'Hey.'

'Hey yourself,' Rebecca says, squeezing her eyes shut and seeing him, tense and solid with rage. Male anger scares her. But, this is Josh, he isn't like that – is he? Though she is hardly the best judge of character.

'How is she?' Josh asks and it takes her a second to remember it is now, not then, and that he is talking about Maddie and Lee. Maddie is here in her flat. She has not been taken away in handcuffs, fear widening her eyes.

'She's okay. Thank you. You got there in time.'

'I'm glad to hear it. That guy . . . honestly.'

'Not the first time he's pissed you off?'

'Let's just say he can't handle his booze but insists on drinking way too much of it.' He sighs. 'I've given him the benefit of the doubt one too many times, so I feel partly responsible that he was even there.' Rebecca softens. Josh is a good guy; she is sure of it. She's grown up since Oliver, has better instincts.

'You can't blame yourself. You didn't attack Maddie, *he* did.'

'No, but, it was *my* house, *my* party.'

'Still.'

‘You don’t blame me?’

‘Of course not. Nor does Maddie,’ she adds quickly, ‘and she’s fine, honestly.’ Rebecca stifles a yawn, surprised at how tired she is from doing nothing.

‘I’m glad,’ he says, voice low and familiar. ‘I’d hate it if you did.’

She hangs up the phone and realises the bubbly feeling she’s always had when she thinks about him is back after a brief hiatus.

‘Was that Josh?’ Maddie asks.

‘Yes, seeing if you were okay.’

She sighs. ‘My hero.’ Her face is soft and grinning. Rebecca doesn’t like it, not at all, but she forces herself to smile back.

‘He saved the day alright.’

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ALI

Now

I feel exhausted by the time I leave Rebecca's. Exhausted, frightened, confused and most of all I wish I'd just stayed the hell out of it. I step onto the train, busier now than when I arrived. I pull my phone out to check the time and see that it is, in fact, absolutely dead. I settle down for the journey, rooting round in my bag for a charging lead. I finally find one then realise the sockets on the train need a plug as well. In my haste to get out of the house, thrilled at the prospect of not being weighed down by baby paraphernalia, I have forgotten my portable battery. Thinking of Charlie now, in light of what I've just heard, brings tears to my eyes. I feel a swell of sympathy for Maddie, how awful it must be to lose a child, and in such a traumatic way, and for Rebecca, who despite appearing to be a rational person has become embroiled in a madcap plan that will surely blow up in both their faces. I realise I don't really know her that well at all. She presented a version of herself to me that doesn't exist. The woman she wanted to be, the life she wanted to have. But the truth is, she wasn't that person. She isn't.

Dan will be worried by now; it's been hours since I got in touch. He'll worry more if he can't get hold of me and it's an hour until I change trains. When I arrive at the transit station I hurry off to find a Starbucks with charging points, hurriedly buying a 'seasonal' pumpkin latte, adding cream so sweet it sticks in my throat.

My phone gets to two bars of life. The message buttons flash. I read texts from Dan, increasing in their intensity as the day has gone on. The last one just says, *Are you okay? Call me.*

I'm about to do so, head leaning low so as not to pull the cable free, when

my voicemail beeps. It'll be Dan; I'll listen quickly, gauge his tone.

'Ali, there was a message on my mobile, I missed it somehow, but, listen, it's from that guy, the one the police said broke in here. I recognised his name – Joshua.' My blood runs cold. A missing person has called my husband. I imagine him then, making the call. Before or after he'd accosted me in my living room? Is it a clue in an active . . . what . . . kidnapping case?

'It was really strange actually; he said, whatever you do, don't trust Maddie, and a whole load of other stuff. Something about Rebecca being swept up in her madness. I don't know who Maddie is, do you? Anyway, call me, are you okay? I'm assuming your phone's dead and no charger?'

I sit, the smell of my pumpkin latte overpowering now. The cream and sugar that I'd been up for just a second ago sickening me just at the thought.

Don't trust Maddie.

I call home.

'Hey, my God, hey.' The concern shows in his voice.

'I'm so sorry. I *did* run out of battery.'

'I figured, your portable charger thing is here on the kitchen side.'

'I meant to pack it.'

He laughs, more relaxed now he knows I'm okay. If only he knew. 'Ah well. Where are you?'

'At Reading,' I tell him. 'I stopped at Starbucks to charge up. Is Charlie okay? Are you? Sorry I'm so late.'

'We're both fine. We've had a great day, though, not gonna lie, one of us may be looking forward to bedtime and a cheeky beer.'

I glance at the clock on the wall: seven thirty. I'd have had her down by now, but maybe we'll get a lie-in; you never know.

'How was your day?' he asks.

I squeeze my eyes shut. 'It . . . it was a lot.'

'Oh, you were meant to be having fun!' His voice is light and the guilt washes over me.

'I know. But, look, can we talk when I get home?'

'You're scaring me now.' Voice still light but that hint of worry creeping back in. I hate myself for making him worry, and he doesn't know the half of it yet.

'Don't be scared, there's no need. I'm fine. I promise. I just don't want to go into it now, here. Let me get in, yeah?'

'Okay. About an hour and a half?'

‘Just over.’

‘See you then, babe. Love you.’

‘You too.’

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MADDIE

2015

By Wednesday it's as if the weekend never happened. Rebecca is back at work, heading out each morning to chambers, her lifestyle shown up in stark contrast to Maddie's, who is often asleep when Rebecca leaves.

One lunchtime, the landline goes and Maddie picks up. 'Hello?'

'Rebecca?'

'No, it's Maddie. Josh?'

'Oh yes hi, is this not her mobile?'

'No, landline.'

'Ah, both saved under her name.'

'How are you anyway?' she asks this man who looks exactly how she thinks Oliver would have eventually. She finds her heart picking up speed, her hands dampening.

'Okay, tired with work.'

'Poor you. Rebecca is too.'

'It's a lot,' he admits. Then, 'I wanted to ask you how you were anyway, after Lee.'

'I'm okay, thank you.'

'I'm so sorry, he's such a dick.'

'No need to be sorry. Besides, you saved me.'

'Well, I don't know about that.'

'I do,' she says firmly, 'and you did. Come over,' she says quickly, 'when you finish, I'll cook.'

'Oh you don't need . . .'

'Please,' she says. 'To say thank you.' And wonders at her own intentions

as soon as the words are out.

‘Yes, okay, thanks, that would be nice.’

She hangs up. Rebecca will be late this evening; she’d already said that. Maddie saw the way she looked at Josh too. Remembers only too well what Rebecca’s last entanglement had cost them. How her friend had pulled further and further away from Maddie until all she was left with were sighs and eye rolls. She didn’t want that to happen again. Besides, she liked Josh, even more so since the Lee incident. And she’d asked Rebecca outright, ‘Are you into him?’

No, she tells herself as she thinks about what to cook and what to wear. She’s doing nothing wrong. If anything she’s protecting their special friendship, just like she always has.

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REBECCA

2015

Rebecca unlocks the door and is immediately greeted by the low murmur of conversation. She leans her bag by the coat rack, wriggling out of her good wool coat which keeps her warm but not always dry. She catches sight of herself in the hallway mirror, hair bedraggled from the thin drizzle that accompanied her journey home, this morning's freshly applied mascara starting to smudge. She rubs a finger beneath each eye, steps out of her low, sensible but surprisingly uncomfortable court shoes and breathes a sigh of relief.

In the living room, she pauses for a moment, taking in the scene she's walked in on. Maddie, dressed for once, in a tight jumper dress, black tights and fluffy black bootee slippers, hair washed and sparkling blonde, make-up minimal but effective. Sitting alongside Josh, who is in a suit. He, like her, must have come from chambers.

He stands as she comes in, his face flushing, or did she imagine that? 'Bex,' he says. 'Maddie said you'd be back soon.'

'Oh?'

Maddie stands, putting herself next to Josh. Rebecca sees the hand she places on his arm, notes the fact that he doesn't pull away, instead beaming down at her. He must be – what – a whole foot taller? Rebecca is up to his shoulder at least, probably slightly above.

'I called the landline by mistake, Maddie invited me over.'

'He was so sweet, asking how I was, checking I was okay,' Maddie says brightly. She punctuates this by placing the other hand on his arm and squeezing.

Rebecca forces a smile. 'That *is* sweet,' she says.

Maddie waves at the bottle on the table and Rebecca sees they've made a good dent in one of her bottles of red. 'Get you a glass?' Maddie asks.

'No,' Rebecca manages, 'but thanks. I'm knackered and have a stack of paperwork to get through.'

'Me too,' says Josh, who is looking from one to the other and is, if Rebecca isn't mistaken, quite awkward while doing so. 'I should go,' he says.

'You don't need to,' Rebecca says, not meaning it. She wants him to leave now and preferably take Maddie with him.

'No, I do. You know what it's like,' he says, to which Rebecca nods; she does, of course. Yet he'd still found the time to come by, at Maddie's invitation, because she was there to pick up the phone. She is always there, taking Rebecca's food, drink, space. And now here she is, taking Josh from her too.

ALI

Now

My phone rings, startling me. Darkness has crept in outside. It's an unknown number – Rebecca perhaps? I look at it. Do I want to talk to her again? This is probably a good place to sever all ties.

'Hello?' I pick up just before it rings out.

'Mrs Cooper, hello.'

The detective. Great.

'Oh, it's you,' I say before I can stop myself.

'It is, yes. Is now a convenient time to talk?'

'It's as good as any other,' I say, my voice sulky. I adjust my tone. 'I'm on the train, on the way home.'

'From the spa?'

I close my eyes. I'd spoken to her just this morning. Feeding her the same lie I'd fed Dan. The fat piles of untruth seem to expand and grow endlessly.

'Right.' My voice is low.

'We found Mr Hall.'

'You make that sound like bad news.'

'I'm afraid it is very bad news. Mr Hall is dead.'

'Dead?' My heart hammers in my chest.

'We believe he was murdered.'

A silence. The chug of the train is steady beneath my body, it is dark outside and the suburbs whip by in a stream of streetlights and station names I recognise but have never been to.

Missing. Murdered. A man who had followed me and my baby daughter into our little house. No, that wasn't right. He'd let himself in. An abuser,

Maddie had said, a terrible wife-beating monster. Joshua's voicemail had said she couldn't be trusted, but then he would say that, wouldn't he? Though she had stolen his sperm. Conspired with Rebecca to do so. They'd be in trouble for it, of course. I run through various scenarios in my mind but it's no good. My head hurts, I'm exhausted, now I'm frightened.

'Mrs Cooper?'

'Sorry,' I say, for what exactly, I am unsure. I think of the voicemail. She'll need to hear it. It's important, of course it is. 'Are you sure?' I ask.

'Yes.'

'It couldn't have been an accident?' My mind whirs through various scenarios, settling on the possibility of self-defence. That could be it, couldn't it? But whose defence? Maddie's? Rebecca's? Had they sat there and lied to me all afternoon?

'He suffered a hard blow to the back of the head.'

'Could he have fallen?'

'Mr Hall was most definitely hit from behind.'

'Oh,' I manage.

'What do you know, Mrs Cooper?' Suspicion makes her voice sharper.

'I . . . I'm not sure.'

'Whatever it is, it's important you tell me, not least considering your precarious position in this investigation.'

'I know,' I say, my voice higher and shriller than I'd like. I force it down to a normal pitch. 'Look, it's late, I'm not home, can you give me until the morning?' I sound like I'm pleading, which I suppose I am. There is a pause as I hold my breath.

'Alright, I'll give you until the morning. If you don't come to me, I'll be coming to you.'

'I understand.'

REBECCA

2018

After six long and gruelling months, where cancer shrinks her father to a shadow of his former self, Martin James Dalston finally dies. Throughout his illness, he had remained in good spirits, assuring Rebecca that watching her grow up into a woman he was proud of was reward enough for him in this life. She feels it in the dark night-time hours when she is sad and angry and lonely. Furious at the unfairness of having to say goodbye to him in her mid-twenties.

Rebecca is successful and thriving in her own right. She has worked extremely hard to achieve what she has and is considered an expert in her field, switching early from criminal law to family law just as she'd planned. Mainly, she works on divorces. High-profile ones where lots of money is at stake. She is a good listener and her clients appreciate that. As well as the lucrative divorces, she takes on some pro bono work. During her time as a criminal lawyer, she saw people on the merry-go-round of incarceration, stories that started to go wrong at a young age, when a good court decision could have made all the difference. She tried to fight for small justices for her clients: a mother re-directed from prison to rehabilitation, a stricken teenager up for petty offences put into education. She thought often of Maddie, whose parents kept her out of the system with clever law and money. The fact that it should have been her, that Maddie saved her from that fate, is something for which she'll always be grateful. The cases she won were a kind of penance for that.

She loves her friend as much as ever, but from a distance now as their lives take different paths. Though, if she is being honest, it was more about

Josh. Rebecca attended the wedding, of course she did. Maddie had pronounced that she was more like family to her than her own parents, her own brother, and how could Rebecca say no.

She had managed to make it through the wedding day, smiling, saying the right things. Josh kind of paled into the background, sort of bewildered. Or perhaps she was just imagining things, projecting her own awkwardness onto him. The whole day, she had felt out of place and on edge, trying desperately to mask her broken heart.

She had washed her envy back with good champagne, a toast to her friend's future happiness, a speech about how wonderful Maddie was. She'd done well, her voice warm and genuine. When she'd got in late that night, she'd cried her eyes out.

Then there was the honeymoon, with Maddie updating social media with beautiful photos that made Rebecca feel at once happy for her friend and sad for herself. She loyally liked as many photos as she could bear, then muted them. Weeks became months and stretched into years, Rebecca and Maddie speaking occasionally on the phone but nothing like they used to. She thinks it must have been three months since their last conversation.

She feels an unexpected spike of joy as she looks up now and sees her friend heading towards her, face solemn as she comes and stands right next to Rebecca, linking her arm through hers, and for the first time since he died, Rebecca is able to cry. The rest of the day passes in a numb kind of blur. Rebecca chokes on tears as she reads the eulogy, makes small talk with her father's colleagues and finally Maddie helps her usher out the last people. Shuts the door at Alpine Close and cooks dinner for them both.

'Where's Josh?' Rebecca asks finally as they sit down to eat.

'Away as usual.' Maddie sighs.

'Oh?'

'He's still in corporate law. One of his clients has accounts everywhere, though sometimes I swear he's just avoiding coming home.'

'Really?' Rebecca asks.

'I don't know, maybe.' She smiles. 'Or maybe I'm just paranoid.'

'That sort of work is very demanding.'

'It is, yes, and it keeps us well enough.'

'Does he like it?' she asks, genuinely interested. Josh had been dead set on practising law that made a difference once upon a time. She knows from talking to Maddie that it was her who'd pushed him into the more lucrative

world of finance.

‘I don’t know, but I do know he’s always stressed out.’ Her face falls and Rebecca murmurs, ‘I’m sorry.’

‘Oh no, don’t be, and honestly it’s fine overall.’ She flashes her brilliant bright smile and Rebecca doesn’t push it. Doesn’t have the energy to do so today.

‘How about you, Bex?’

‘How about me?’

‘No one special?’

‘Oh, I see. No, not yet.’ The real truth is she is desperately lonely. She finds herself on Saturday mornings watching the mum-and-baby groups in her local coffee shop, ear-wiggling on their easy, intense conversations. Those women joined by a common experience that she doesn’t have, may never have. There are options, she knows that. She’s started looking into sperm donors, single-parent adoption. But she knows in her heart that she wants someone to share it all with, a partner with whom to share the highs and lows of parenthood. She’s not sure she could raise a child alone.

The two women sit side by side, not talking much more, but Rebecca is immensely comforted by Maddie’s presence and reassured that, despite the recent distance, their bond remains strong.

It is almost three years later when Rebecca wakes with a start at 2 a.m. to her doorbell going and finds Maddie at her door, hysterical and inconsolable.

ALI

Now

By the time I step off the train it's pitch black and a thin drizzle has started. I'm looking around wearily for a cab, regretting turning down Dan's offer to come and collect me, when I hear a beep. My husband, waving like a wally, lopsided grin firmly in place.

Inside the car it's warm. Charlie is snoring quietly in the back.

'I figured once it started raining you'd probably change your mind.'

'You were quite right,' I say. 'Thank you.'

'Ah, no problem. She's bathed, fed and in her sleepsuit, so if we're proper parent ninja about it we should be able to get her from the car to bed no hassle, and I've made a curry.'

'You made it?' I ask. Neither of us are adventurous cooks, but Dan has a tried-and-tested few recipes which work well. Curry isn't one of them.

'Well, I browned off chicken, added a sauce.'

'Okay, phew.'

'Oi.' But he's grinning.

'Can I listen to that message?' I ask, hating to interrupt the happy banter but knowing that I have to.

'Yeah.' His face grows serious.

I pick up his phone and dial into his messages.

'Hi, I'm sorry to call you. I, er, your name is listed alongside your wife's. I don't know her. I mean, I know *of* her, obviously. God, I'm the weirdo who was in your house . . . don't hang up though, please. I'm not actually a weirdo, I just . . . it's my wife that I'm concerned about. Maybe your wife knows her? Madeleine Hall? Or her friend Rebecca, Rebecca Dalston. I saw

your wife talking to Rebecca on her doorstep, then again, outside her house. I, er, think maybe she, your wife, was watching her? And my wife, Madeleine – Maddie – is missing.’ His voice breaks at that point. He sounds upset, distressed. But then aren’t abusers always master actors? I mean, they’d have to be, wouldn’t they? Certainly *he* would. Barrister by day, abuser by night.

‘Sorry. She has a history of instability and, well, we were trying for a baby, over a year ago. We tried everything but it didn’t happen and I don’t think she ever recovered. Then . . . it seems she may have found something out about er, me and her friend. The other woman I mentioned – Rebecca. I don’t know, look, it’s . . . it’s a mess. Anyway, she said we’d talk about it, that she’d tell me everything. She cooked us both a lovely dinner and that’s the last thing I remember. I think she drugged me and, when I came to, she wasn’t there, I haven’t seen her since. She’s been gone for three months, I’ve no idea where, and I’ve been trying to trace her. Just to make sure she’s okay. I found some receipts linked to her personal bank account, a lot of receipts, in fact, for baby things, and also tickets to Meadsvale, where you live, and where Rebecca lives. I figured that’s what she was doing. Going to see Rebecca. Then I saw your wife and she had a baby and that, well, that scared me, made me think about the receipts and I . . . I followed her. I’m sorry, it’s not normal behaviour, I know, but I’m frantic, I suppose. When I went to your house I thought she was in and had left the door open, I called out then went in, she turned up seconds later.’ He pauses, inhales. If he is lying then he is giving an Oscar-worthy performance, and there’s something else in his voice, something I recognise all too well. *Fear*. ‘My wife, Maddie, as I said can be . . . anyway. She has a history of self-harm, terrible things, awful, and, uh, I said I wanted a divorce. Neither of us were happy. But she was fragile, even more so when we couldn’t have kids. I suppose for me it was a relief. But not for her. Oh God. Sorry. I’m giving you a speech, my life story, and you don’t know me. But really I wanted to warn you, or your wife, whoever it is who’s involved with her. Maddie is . . . troubled, maybe even dangerous. She started spreading rumours at my work, things that could get me fired, or worse, and like I said, she spiked my drink, I’m sure of it. I should have done something about it sooner, but hindsight is a wonderful thing and it’s hard to describe how madness can start to seem normal when you’re living in it. Just . . . be careful. She’s not what she seems. Please call me.’ He gives his number. Then he’s gone. I

hang up, my eyes flicking to my reflection in the car window. I look ashen, pale-faced. I find I am gripping the phone so hard its edges are digging into my hand. Trying for a baby, he'd said. No mention of her being pregnant.

'Who the hell is Maddie?' Dan asks and I burst into tears.

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MADDIE

Fifteen months ago

Maddie feels . . . relief, she thinks. All the hurt, all the anger that has been building up inside her for so long seems finally to have abated, if only momentarily. She can't sleep, doubts she'll even close her eyes before the sun rises, peeking round the curtains in this beautiful room in this house where she feels, finally, safe.

Josh won't be awake for hours yet, if he wakes at all. That thought sends a tremor through her body. Fear, yes, and something else too because it would be a solution of sorts. She won't let her mind go there yet though; that would be an absolute last resort. She left her house hours ago, got the train to London where she'd sat watching the Thames, still and unbothered as throngs of people passed her by in the city that never seems to sleep. The city where a grown woman with a broken heart and a bruised soul could watch them go about their business and not be noticed at all.

It is the last place she remembers being truly happy. The last place she'd felt hope and excitement. One summer where, just for a second, anything seemed possible. She pulls the duvet up around herself now; it smells faintly of Rebecca, the same perfume she's worn for all the years Maddie has known her. The perfume her mother wore.

If Maddie could go back, would she change things? Would she have left Josh alone, stepped aside as soon as she realised that it wasn't her he wanted, not really? She'd thought she would lose them both, if they got together, but she's felt Rebecca pulling away anyway these last few years. And now, she might lose her for ever; the first person who'd loved her, cared about her. And, Maddie has realised, she cannot let that happen. She

saved their friendship once and she will do whatever it takes to do it again.

She thinks about what she has left behind: her husband, but also the idea of what her life would be, what it should be. She had tried, goodness knows she had, to make it work. She'd smiled, been there for Josh, encouraged him in his career, kept the house spick and span and, she'd told herself, once they filled it with children, she'd have a proper role. They'd be a team and he'd respect her, even if he never quite loved her. But after months of trying, each disappointment a knife to the heart, they'd learned children weren't meant to be, at least not for Maddie. The finality of it was a death knell to their already strained relationship. She'd thought on the day he'd muttered, 'Maybe it's for the best,' that things couldn't get any worse.

And then she'd read the message, worked out the dates and where he'd been. The thought of it now makes her face heat up and her skin feel like it's being prickled by tiny pins and needles. The stab of guilt she had had from spiking his drink fades away. He deserves it, she thinks, just like he deserves the suspicion of his colleagues, though she hadn't meant to bad-mouth him. Had, as usual, drunk more than she should have. An evening that had started so well, her looking pretty on his arm, cocktail dress sparkling. The rest of the night, like so many before it and so many since, is mostly a blur. She recalls snippets of conversation with another wife in the toilets. But, in fairness, he'd started it; he'd betrayed her, then he'd rejected her. It was he who had declared war, she just took up the challenge.

No, she thinks, there was no easier, softer way here. It was how it had to be and though she doesn't have an exact plan, she has implemented the first step, and she's glad she's here. Glad she's taken the necessary action to protect the friendship that means more to her than anything in the world.

She shuts her eyes and wishes that her mind would stop the chatter, endless intrusive thoughts spinning around and around in there until eventually the sun comes up and the day begins. She takes a deep breath and heads downstairs.

REBECCA

Fifteen months ago

‘What’s the matter?’ Maddie looks awful, Rebecca thinks, her usually shiny blonde hair sitting in lank, slightly damp-looking tendrils around her face. Her eyes are puffy, her face red, her skin looks dry and she is too thin.

‘Can I come in?’ Her voice is small, the words jagged and hurt.

‘Of course. Sorry . . . I haven’t tidied,’ Rebecca says, as if that matters. It’s the middle of the night. She had been asleep, a deep, dreamless sleep for once, exhausted by the paperwork she had hunched over for hours, glancing occasionally at her computer where emails ping at all hours. Desperate clients with their desperate pleas.

She takes Maddie through to the kitchen where there are documents spread wildly across the kitchen table. A place she never eats at, usually grabbing something on the go or, at best, microwaving a ready meal, grabbing a bowl of cereal. She collects the papers, stuffing them back into the box file resting on one of the chairs and takes it through to her downstairs office.

‘Tea?’ she says, her voice loud and jarring in the stillness of the small dark hours, in the strangeness of this situation yet to be explained.

‘Please,’ Maddie says, then, ‘Sorry. You have work tomorrow?’

‘Yes. But it’s fine. I’m working from here, court on Friday.’

‘Family law now?’

‘Yes.’

‘You’re like, a star barrister?’

Rebecca smiles tightly. ‘I’ve been involved in some big cases in the past, yes. Nowadays not so much.’ Her picture had appeared on a double-page spread in *The Times* once and she’d been startled by the image. She had

looked older than she was, she thought, sharp cheekbones, sharp elbows, briefcase clutched to her chest. Face serious.

‘Your dad would have been so proud.’

She smiles a real smile at that as the kettle bubbles to an end. ‘Yes, I’m glad he got to see me set up.’

‘Me too.’

Rebecca places a mug of tea in front of Maddie. ‘I added sugar.’

‘Thanks.’

The two women sit facing each other. Rebecca takes a sip of her tea, finding the hotness of it reviving even if her taste buds aren’t quite awake yet. It crosses her mind that really they ought to have a packet of Marlboro lights; sharing cigarettes between them like they had when they were girls up on the roof of Oakwood.

‘No relationship?’

‘Would be hard-pushed to find the time,’ Rebecca manages.

Maddie snorts, ‘I know that, I’m married to one of you, remember?’

‘Yes,’ she says because – how could she forget?

‘How is he?’ she asks, soft, tentative, because she’s assuming all isn’t well in paradise or else why would Maddie be here, knocking on Rebecca’s door?

It starts as a quiver in her lip, then the tears come. Awful, heart-wrecking sobs.

Rebecca listens to Maddie describe a man she hardly recognises. But she has seen a flare of his temper once, that night when he’d ‘rescued’ Maddie from Lee; she’d seen her friend’s face when Maddie had murmured, ‘He’s always stressed,’ the day of her father’s funeral. That was real and, justified or not, it had unsettled her then.

‘When did it start, Maddie?’

‘Which bit?’

‘The . . . physical stuff . . .’ Rebecca finds it hard to say the words. To put out there exactly what Josh is, what he has done.

‘It started then. We’ve had . . . problems for years, and looking back he was so . . . bossy, and I always felt he thought he knew best. You know?’

‘Coercive control,’ Rebecca says.

‘What?’

‘It’s a form of abuse, often precedes physical abuse, though not always. I

see it a lot, in my job. Hard to prove.'

'Well, exactly. But, he's bigger than me and . . . well . . .'

'God, Maddie. I had no idea,' she says uselessly, her words feeling too small to be of any comfort in the face of this horror.

'Why would you? We don't see much of you.'

'I'm sorry,' she says, tears prickling her eyes as she thinks of Maddie lying in a hospital bed. Forlorn and alone. Or, not alone, worse than alone. She's seen enough abusive relationships in the course of her work to understand how they work. The levels of fear needed to sustain them. She knows that may have been the first time Josh got physical, but that there would have been plenty of red flags before that. Ones Maddie wouldn't have wanted to see or believe.

'So, how was it, before that?'

'I mean; we have always argued. A lot.' Her voice is small.

'Always?' Rebecca thinks of their wedding day, the eventual celebration, where Josh had looked stressed, but what groom wasn't? And he was simultaneously seeing out his training; a tough slog even without a wedding to plan, as she herself knew. But Maddie had radiated happiness, that had been real alright. The shine of it had hit Rebecca hard, her jealousy rearing its ugly head in response. *Why not me?* it had whispered. *Why not me in a white dress looking dreamily at the man of my dreams?*

'What's happened now? To bring you here?'

'Another argument,' Maddie says with a sigh.

'Where is he?' Rebecca has rarely spoken his name over the years and feels if she says it now, she might just choke.

'At home. I said I was going to a yoga retreat.'

'In the middle of the night?'

'I left yesterday afternoon. It took me a while to get here.'

Rebecca races through the journey in her head. It shouldn't have taken Maddie that long, though that, of course, isn't the point. Rebecca imagines her, shoving a few things in the small backpack she'd been carrying when she arrived, opening the door, sneaking out.

'Stay here. We'll figure it out in the morning,' she says, standing and walking round to her friend, pulling her close and squeezing her. 'It will be okay, I promise.'

'Thank you.'

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ALI

Now

I feel something close to relief that I won't have to lie any more. Dan carries Charlie in, the thin drizzle now full-on rain. He dashes for the front door, coming back to open the passenger side and reaching a hand in for me. Considerate as always. 'Come on,' he says as rain snakes its way down his face.

Inside, he removes our daughter from the car seat, carrying her upstairs. I head through to the kitchen, looking at the bottle of wine on the side and opting instead to put the kettle on. My head is foggy enough already without alcohol.

'Hey.' Dan comes in.

'Hey yourself. I'm having tea, do you want one?'

'Give me chamomile, I don't want to be up all night,' he says with a lion-style yawn that would be funny if I had it in me to laugh. I don't tell him that sleep will probably be out of reach once I've finished speaking.

I put the mug in front of him, sit down opposite and say, 'That man, the intruder, the one who called you.'

'Joshua?'

'Yes.' I nod and my thoughts slip around in my mind. I am also tired, I realise. Weary, bone-achingly exhausted. 'He's dead.'

'Oh my God, what happened?'

'He was murdered.'

'Murdered. Shit.' He reaches for his mug, realises it's far too hot to drink and pulls his hand back.

'Do you want an ice cube?'

‘What?’

‘In the tea?’

‘Oh. No. I’ll wait.’ I nod. He adds. ‘Thanks.’

I take a sip of *my* tea, always too milky for anyone else but ready for me to drink straight away. I have two sugars in it still. Though, when I am at other people’s houses I never do. Always worrying what they will think. Always worrying about the wrong things. As if it matters really if people think I’m common.

‘When?’ Dan asks.

‘Sorry?’ I say, distracted by my own tired thoughts.

‘When was he – Joshua – murdered?’

‘I’m not sure, but he went missing three days ago.’ Is that all it’s been? It feels like a lifetime of carrying around this awful thing, this tainted, impossible secret like a stone in my shoe.

‘Oh my God. But, I don’t understand . . . what does it have to do with us?’

‘I am, or I was, a suspect of sorts . . .’

‘Fuck.’ His face twists. ‘What the hell, why?’

‘He came here; he’d been following me. The next day he turns up missing, then dead.’ I shrug.

‘That’s not such a strong reason,’ he says and I am relieved he doesn’t ask me if I did it. If he’d asked that, would there be any hope for us at all?

‘Did you know his wife, Maddie?’

‘No. Not exactly.’ I drain the last of my milky tea, take a deep breath and tell him everything from the start.

‘*Why*, Ali, why was it so important to you, that relationship with Rebecca?’

‘It was . . . the first time, since all the stuff with Izzy, I felt like I had a friend.’

‘You have friends, had friends when I met you.’

No.’ I shake my head. ‘I had acquaintances, colleagues, people I could blend in with. But Izzy, well, she was my *best* friend, Dan, and what she did to me was horrible, but I miss her.’

He runs a hand over his face.

I try again to explain. ‘I was upset about Max, obviously, my feelings were really hurt, but we weren’t suited, it would have ended anyway. And it led to better things – I got you and Charlie. The best things to ever happen to me.’

‘Ali, that stuff happened a long time ago now. I get that it was painful, but . . .’ He shrugs, his face set in hard, angry lines. ‘Shit happens.’

‘I know, and I know I should have let it go. I tried really hard to. When I met Rebecca I felt like I finally had; we clicked and I realised how much I’d missed that, a close female friend, you know, especially one in exactly the same situation as me. We had fun, laughed. Then Charlie came along and I felt lonely in a different way and I got obsessed, like you said. I can see it now.’

‘Jesus Christ, Ali. Rebecca and Izzy have nothing to do with each other.’

‘I know, but then I saw her. Izzy. And she was so nice and that was somehow worse than if she hadn’t been.’

‘You didn’t mention it.’

‘No. I’m sorry.’

He sighs. ‘All of this, Ali, all of this keeping things from me. We’re supposed to be a team.’

‘I’m sorry,’ I say again, hoping that he knows it’s true.

‘So, you found Rebecca in the end? And this Maddie?’

‘Yes.’

‘They . . .’ Dan’s face twists. ‘They stole his sperm?’

I’ve just finished telling Dan the sordid tale, disgust now blending with the anger on his face.

‘Yes.’

‘And got away with it?’

I nod. ‘For now, I guess. It’s not all above board, of course, but Rebecca made sure the paperwork will check out.’

‘And this guy, Joshua, he didn’t know?’

‘No . . . at least, not at first,’ I tell him. ‘They think he suspected something.’

‘She risked her livelihood and her reputation.’ He shakes his head as though rattling the thoughts around might put them in some logical sequence. ‘So this Rebecca’s there now, in Sussex, with Maddie?’

‘Yes.’ I nod. ‘Joshua was abusive, for years. He wore her down, controlled what she did, hit her. She says he pushed her down the stairs when she was pregnant.’

‘In his message he said she’d never been pregnant. They were trying, is what he said.’

‘Abusers lie all the time, Dan.’

‘Lots of people lie,’ he says and I avert my gaze guiltily. ‘You only have Maddie’s word for that, and Joshua, a man who has now turned up murdered, explicitly said she’s not to be trusted.’

‘But he could have been lying! Women flee those sort of situations all the time and don’t want to be found.’

‘Okay, let’s say he wasn’t worried. Even if that is true, the fact is he was looking for her, right?’

‘Right.’

‘And now he’s dead.’

‘Oh God, do you think Maddie killed him?’

‘I don’t know, Ali, I don’t even know the woman. But if this Joshua found her and he is abusive like she says . . . maybe it was self-defence? Either way, you need to stay away from her – and Rebecca. What if she knew? What if she’s helping Maddie cover it up?’

‘Rebecca wouldn’t do that,’ I say, uncertainly. Because how well do I really know this woman? Not at all, as it turns out.

‘How could you possibly be sure of that? She’s lied to you about everything else. Just promise me you won’t have anything more to do with them.’

I should agree, leave the police to sort out this sordid mess and hope that I can be kept out of it, but I can’t – I have to know what Rebecca knows. And I can’t keep lying to Dan.

‘Please, Dan, just let me talk to her. See how she reacts when she hears Joshua’s dead.’ Dan grimaces and I know I need to ramp it up a notch. ‘If Maddie did kill him, and Rebecca doesn’t know, then she’s alone in the house with a murderer. Even if it was self-defence, we don’t know what that does to a person. And there’s the baby to think of.’

Dan glances at the monitor, thinking of our own helpless baby sleeping soundly upstairs, and I know I have him.

‘Fine. Call her,’ Dan says. I pick up my phone, scroll to her number.

‘No answer,’ I tell him. ‘I’ll text her, say it’s urgent.’ I fire off the message, then stare helplessly at my phone as it remains stubbornly silent.

‘Ali,’ Dan says, more gently now. ‘There’s nothing more you can do. It’s time to call the police.’

I nod, heart pounding, palms sweating.

I ring DI Gerard’s number but yet again get voicemail. I leave her a

garbled message.

‘Oh God,’ I manage, the sound like a small, agonised croak. I run a hand across my face.

Dan stands up, pulling a bottle of rum out from the back of the cupboard, pouring two small glasses’ worth and sliding one across to me.

‘Should we?’ I say, staring at the dark liquid.

‘I’m going to, and if you don’t want it I’ll have yours too.’

He is not much of a drinker, Dan. He likes a few beers with his friends. I take the glass, down it in one and watch as he does the same, flinching slightly.

Warmth spreads through me immediately. But it does little to dispel the growing panic. What if Maddie really did kill Joshua? Have I unwittingly aided and abetted a murderer?

‘I didn’t like her,’ I say.

‘Rebecca?’ His eyebrows raise in surprise.

I laugh, surprised that I have it in me. ‘No, obviously I liked her. Hence the stalking.’ That brings a flicker of a smile to his face, which he tries and fails to suppress. ‘It’s okay,’ I say, ‘I do realise my behaviour hasn’t been the . . . sanest.’

‘Well,’ he says, ‘they say having a baby can unbalance you.’ He doesn’t exactly smile, but I feel like maybe his anger is dissipating slightly. ‘You didn’t like Maddie?’ he clarifies.

‘No, and I figured perhaps it was just because I was jealous, you know. Rebecca’s *actual* best friend and all that.’

‘Now you think otherwise?’

I shrug. ‘I don’t know, it was just a feeling.’

He stands up, taking my glass and his to the sink, pausing to kiss me on the top of my head as he goes. ‘You’ve always been a good judge of character, Ali.’

‘Have I?’ I ask him, surprised.

He laughs. ‘God, of course. I mean, look at the job you do.’

‘What – firefighting volatile housing situations?’

‘Yes,’ he says, serious now. ‘And you’re brilliant at it, you often have to judge situations based on gut feeling, Al.’

I do, I suppose. ‘Shame I’m not a better judge when it comes to friends.’

‘Rebecca sounded okay. How were you to know she was embroiled in . . . this?’

‘Murder, you mean?’

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REBECCA

Fifteen months ago

She settles Maddie in one of the four bedrooms in this house that is far too big for Rebecca, but which she can't bring herself to leave because it was where her dad had lived. She didn't consider herself sentimental, but she supposed she was really. No one would guess it, she had a reputation amongst colleagues and clients alike for being firm but fair. She also had a reputation for being something of an enigma. She wasn't really close to anyone. That much was true.

She opens WhatsApp on her phone. Scrolls through and finds his number. She clicks on it, opening a chat from two years ago.

A single message next to his face grinning in a circle; did Maddie take the picture? she wonders. Probably. At the time he'd sent the message it had been a picture of him on his wedding day. Rebecca had recognised the suit and it had solidified her decision not to respond.

The message just reads, *Are we going to talk about it?*

No, was the answer she gave him through her silence.

Now her heart thunders with the dishonesty of it – should she wake Maddie now, and say . . . what? I saw him, Maddie, at a conference. We had a drink in the bar, not just us, us and plenty of others too.

That was true, until the others slipped away, the crowd thinning out until it had just been her and Josh left.

They'd talked about anything, everything and nothing of too much substance, until he'd said, 'I was sorry to hear about your dad.'

'Thank you.'

'Sorry I didn't come.' The words hung between them then. Her chance to

say, 'It's okay, Maddie came on your behalf.' The chance for one or the other of them to acknowledge the elephant in the room. *His wife. Her best friend.*

She didn't mention Maddie though; instead she said, 'It's okay.'

'It's not,' he'd said. 'It was selfish. I just couldn't bear to see you.'

'Oh.' His words were like a stab to the heart she'd spent so long hardening. 'Right.'

'Not because I didn't want to.' By then his voice was low, and her blood thrummed with the glasses of good wine and not enough food, and she heard something in his tone that mirrored her own feelings. 'Quite the opposite in fact.'

When he leaned forward to kiss her, she could have stopped him. She absolutely should have stopped him, but she didn't want to and as they pressed together she felt the absolute rightness of it.

They paid the tab, headed up to his room and he took her to bed.

It was, without question, the best night of her life. But waking up bleary-eyed alongside him, watching his beautiful face in slumber, a glint on his hand, his wedding band catching the light of the rising sun outside, made her feel sick. Physically, emotionally.

She dressed in silence, crept out, leaving in bare feet, her shoes in her hand. In her room she cried while she packed. Messaged colleagues who would be expecting her to say that she needed to leave early. She'd gone home via the chemist where she paid almost £50 for the morning after pill and saw the faint smirk of the chemist as she handed the package over.

She'd considered not taking it at all. A child born out of a tenderness like that, how could that be a bad thing? *Because he is not yours*, her conscience whispered. He is your best friend's husband.

She archives the chat, blocks his number. And finally slips into a fitful sleep.

MADDIE

Fifteen months ago

It is like coming home, she thinks. Not the house, she doesn't care about places much at all, but being here with Rebecca. Her soulmate. The most important person in her life. She'd lost sight of that for a while, been blinded by Josh with his bright hair, brighter smile, and . . . he'd rescued her. That was a fact. He'd pulled Lee McCormick off her and in that moment stolen Maddie's heart.

But they'd never quite gelled, not really, not in the way she'd hoped they would, and she'd seen that look on his face every time he talked about Rebecca. Had felt her presence beneath every argument where fists flew and hard words were volleyed back and forth. And if the thought of losing Josh pained her, the thought of losing Rebecca was completely and utterly unacceptable.

ALI

Now

I wake up at 3 a.m., immediately rolling over and searching for Charlie's crib, but I'm not in her room, I'm in ours. Now that she sleeps for a good six to seven hours there's no need for me to be in there.

It's my phone.

I hit the green button, pressing it to my ear, sliding out of the bed and into the hallway.

'Ali?' Rebecca. A whisper, breathless.

'Hang on,' I murmur. Dan has slept through the noise. I'd told him to put earplugs in, I guess they worked.

It's cold on the landing and my legs come to life with goosebumps. I head downstairs and grab a pair of tracksuit bottoms that are drying on the radiator or ailer. They are also cold but better than bare legs.

'Ali?'

'Yes, sorry,' I say, though obviously I have nothing to apologise for; it makes me wince, my own subservience even in a situation like this where I am clearly not in the wrong. 'Did you get my message?'

'Yes, what's happened, is there news?'

'You don't know?' I ask.

'Know what?'

'Joshua is dead.'

'Oh my God.' Her voice breaks on the last word, thick with emotion.

'You really didn't know?' I say, believing it.

'Of course I didn't know.' A pause and then, 'You can't think I had anything to do with it?'

‘I don’t know what to think.’

‘Josh.’ Her voice catches on his name and I hear pain in it. Despite what has happened, what he did to her friend, I think she cared for him. ‘He called your husband?’

‘He did.’ I tell her the gist of it. She doesn’t say anything and I wonder if she’s still there. ‘Rebecca?’

‘Yes.’ Her voice is a low whisper. ‘He was violent towards her – Maddie.’

‘How far do you think he pushed her?’

‘What do you mean?’

‘If she’d seen him, maybe they argued?’

‘You’re saying . . . No, she would have told me.’

‘Maybe she was scared to.’

‘I know her, she’s my friend.’ But I can hear her voice wavering.

‘He also said something else. That they’d been trying for a baby, but that Maddie never got pregnant. Not that she lost the baby.’

‘Well, he’d hardly want to tell anyone he’d effectively killed his own child, would he?’

‘You said you knew him too once, what was he like?’

‘He was . . .’ I hear Rebecca’s voice catch, a clearing of the throat. ‘He was kind, at least I thought he was. But abusers are good at hiding their true nature.’

‘Yes, probably, I don’t know,’ I say, squeezing my eyes shut. ‘Rebecca, he mentioned something else, you and him . . .?’

A silence that stretches. I fill it, the words coming out fast because I have to ask. ‘Could Maddie have found out?’

‘I . . . I don’t see how.’

‘But it happened?’

‘It happened,’ she says, adding quickly, ‘I’m ashamed of it.’

‘I’m not judging,’ I tell her, because I’m not. We’re way past that, into much scarier territory now. ‘Look, I think she’s involved,’ I say, putting it out there. Extremely aware that Rebecca isn’t telling me, *Nope, nuh huh, no way*. That Rebecca is considering and not dismissing the possibility. ‘She needs to go to the police. That would be the best thing. I’m speaking to the detective –’ I glance at the clock – ‘in just a few hours now. Tell Maddie to come and see her here. DI Gerard. If she’s innocent, or if it was self-defence, she can come and get it cleared up.’

‘She might have nothing to do with it.’

‘Have you been with her the whole time?’

‘No, she went away for a few days, just before you and I spoke. James isn’t sleeping, she was getting stressed out about it all, I told her to go, take a breather.’ Rebecca’s voice is a strained whisper.

‘Where?’

‘She stayed in a hotel just on the outskirts of Meadsvale.’

‘Why there, why not your house?’

‘There’s no furniture in it, she wanted to go into London, look round some galleries, and Meadsvale is handy for the train line.’

‘He was found round here, Rebecca. It’s Meadsvale police who are investigating this. That seems like a hell of a coincidence. How was she, when she got back?’

‘I . . . I don’t know really. Normal, she seemed normal. I had told her to contact Josh to let him know she was safe.’

‘Even if she contacted him on your say so, whatever else happened isn’t your fault.’

‘God though. Do you really think she might have done this?’

‘I’m sure that women in her situation must break under the pressure all the time.’

‘Shit.’

‘You must know she can’t run from this?’

‘I know.’ She pauses.

‘Are you okay?’ I ask, heart hammering. I believe in Rebecca’s innocence, I realise.

‘I’m okay, but I’ve got to go, I don’t want to wake her.’

REBECCA

Now

Rebecca hangs up the phone and sets it down on the side table in the living room, staring at it absent-mindedly. She loves that table, she had found it in a charity shop when she and her dad had been spending the weekend here. Originally it was rough, dark wood, full of scratches and blemishes. Her dad had thought she was mad for buying it, even at a ridiculously low price. But she'd sanded it, smoothing out its pockmarked surface and revealing the beauty beneath. Even her dad had been impressed. 'If ever you fall out of love with law,' he'd told her, 'interior design might be your calling.'

She'd have been good at it too, would have enjoyed it immensely, and often thought throughout her twenties that perhaps when she had children she'd retrain. The law was a demanding beast, wanting long hours and silent phones. The thought crosses her mind that she doesn't need to worry about it now. Not really. She has more money than she'll ever need and she has her son who, God knows, she loves more than she's ever loved anything. When Maddie told her how devastated she was about the baby she lost, that all she wanted was another chance, Rebecca had been more open to the possibility than she should have, her own loneliness, her own longing for a child making the words come out of her mouth before she thought it through. 'I could carry the baby. He'd never have to know.' Because the sample was there in the clinic. He'd signed a ten-year consent form which Maddie had managed to find a copy of, and once Rebecca had read over it the plan had started to form in earnest. The idea of a baby became possible. She had felt terrible that night when Maddie had come to her, wracked with guilt about not being there for her friend, even worse, for sleeping with the

enemy. Her best friend's husband, and her abuser. But as the days passed she'd realised she could make amends of sorts, for everything. For the time Maddie had spent imprisoned at that awful place, for the impact that had had on her life afterwards. The incarceration, Rebecca thinks, stunted Maddie's development. At a time when Rebecca was leaving school, heading off to university and growing up, Maddie had been left there.

What she hadn't fully anticipated before they embarked upon this, though, was the overwhelming love she'd feel for this baby. More than she had ever had for Maddie, or anyone.

They'd decided the most important thing was that Josh must never know. Which meant Maddie acting as if everything was fine and Rebecca keeping a low profile.

Now . . . this, Josh. Oh God, Josh. Grief pushes into her throat and she clamps a hand to her mouth. This is a nightmare, so much worse than the theft of Josh's sperm. This is his life. She sits staring at the mobile as if it has just scorched her face with the news, feeling her sense of unease growing.

'Penny for them?'

She jumps so hard her feet lift up, connecting with the table, a sharp pain spreading across the top of her right foot, and she swears softly under her breath. Maddie giggles. 'Oops.' Rebecca looks at her standing there, grinning as if she hasn't got a care in the world, whilst Rebecca is utterly weighed down with suspicion, fear and mistrust. The possibility that Maddie may have killed Josh has now taken root in her mind and it's all she can think about as she looks at her serene, unruffled expression.

'Why are you up?' Rebecca hisses.

'Why are you?'

'Is the baby awake?' she asks Maddie, ignoring the question.

Maddie flumps down on the sofa alongside Rebecca. 'Nope, thank goodness, the little bugger is snoring away.' *Little bugger*. Rebecca lets it go. Maddie has always utilised colourful and often childish language. But she hadn't taken it seriously. Now it makes her think. For someone so desperate for a child, Maddie hadn't exactly taken to looking after one all that readily.

'Were you talking?' Maddie asks her.

'To myself,' Rebecca murmurs. Heart thumping. 'I was trying to make lists of things I need to do in regards to Alpine Close.'

'Couldn't you just write it down?' Maddie's eyes are narrowed. Rebecca

feels as if she is under surveillance, under suspicion. It is so difficult, to lie to someone who has seen you grow up. Her eye twitches.

‘Okay, I was calling Ali back,’ she says.

‘Oh. Your own personal stalker!’

‘Josh is dead,’ Rebecca says, her heart pounding.

Maddie blinks once, twice. Then her face crumples.

‘Maddie,’ Rebecca says, her voice a whisper, ‘what have you done?’

‘I . . . I’m so sorry, Bex. I . . . I was so frightened,’ Maddie tells her, wide eyes shining with sudden tears.

She is, Rebecca thinks, a wonderful actress. And once the thought is there, she can’t unthink it.

‘You killed him?’ she says, but she already knows this is the case. Who else could it have been? Because it wasn’t her.

‘He found out too much, Bex. He knew stuff. He was inches away from finding out everything and then what would we have done? What would he have done?’

‘So you thought you’d get rid of him?’ Her voice is high, incredulous.

‘No,’ Maddie almost yells. ‘God, no, of course not. What do you think I am?’ Her voice is aghast, appalled.

Rebecca had said to Maddie at the time, did it have to be Josh’s sample, surely someone else would be better? An anonymous sperm donor? No, Maddie had said, it was the closest she’d get to the baby she’d lost, and Rebecca hadn’t fought too hard, not really, because part of her thought it made sense. Her and Josh’s child. The baby she herself had dreamed of.

Rebecca closes her eyes for a moment, pressing the balls of her hands into them. When she opens them again the room looks fuzzy. She thinks of Joshua, livid at Lee that night, all those years ago, yanking him off Maddie, his face twisted in rage. ‘I hate bullies,’ he had said, and yet look what he had turned into. A fleeting thought crosses her mind, of all the times she herself has wanted to shake Maddie in frustration. Especially at school when she’d caused drama after drama. But no. No one deserves violence and never from someone almost twice your size. This was Maddie, her friend. But . . .

‘Tell me what happened.’

‘I went to meet him. To beg him to leave it alone.’

‘Where?’

‘What?’

‘Where did you meet him?’

‘Meadsvale, a park not far from Alpine Close. When I told you I needed a break.’

Rebecca had been annoyed by it, but also secretly pleased to have James to herself for a few days. Maddie, it turned out, got bored of the baby pretty fast.

‘Did you even go to a hotel?’

‘Yes, I checked into Hill House.’

‘Is there a record of you staying there?’

Maddie flushes.

‘Maddie?’

‘I . . . I used your name, because I had your credit card.’ She adds hastily, ‘And I didn’t know how it would end.’

Rebecca closes her eyes. Forces herself to inhale and exhale.

‘So you met in the park?’

‘Yes, and we walked out into the woods. He said he knew something was wrong, and he had all these receipts, for things I’d bought.’

‘So what?’

‘He also had the email.’

‘What, from the clinic?’ They’d sent over consent forms; Maddie had intercepted the messages, assured Rebecca they were deleted and he’d never see them.

Maddie nods.

‘How?’

‘I don’t know, I think perhaps there must be a follow-up generic thing and it reignited the old thread.’

‘Shit.’

‘I know. You would have been struck off, Bex.’

‘I would have coped, Maddie.’

‘But then . . . then he said awful things.’

‘What things?’

She shakes her head, ‘Just stuff, and my head was . . . God, I don’t know. We were arguing. Like always, he grabbed my arm, then he . . . he walked off, walked away from me, said he’d had it with my . . . my madness . . .’ Her breathing is jagged, her thin chest shuddering with each breath. ‘I . . . I saw red. I don’t even remember properly, but I . . . I picked up a rock and I ran and then . . . I hit him in the head. The blood, Bex, there was so much,

he fell and I . . . I just kept going.'

'Did you mean to kill him?'

'I don't know what I meant to do.'

'And the receipts? The email?'

'I collected the receipts and I opened his phone and deleted the email.' So she'd been calm enough to do that. Rebecca's heart is thudding. She is quite certain, based on this and what Ali has told her, that Maddie knew about her and Josh. But Maddie hasn't mentioned that and that makes Rebecca feel even more ill at ease, even more panicked than she already is. And she *is* panicked because this . . . this is a gigantic, awful mess.

'You need to go to the police, Maddie. Tell them it was self-defence. I'll back you up.'

'You promise?'

Maddie's damp eyes search her friend's and Rebecca feels an agonising pang. 'Promise,' she whispers. A promise to look after Maddie, to protect her as she has always done. Only now, now she has James and things are different. 'The longer you leave going and handing yourself in, the worse this will get.'

'Because your silly friend will be going in herself and spilling everything.'

'What do you think she has to spill?' Rebecca asks.

Maddie shrugs. 'God only knows.'

'She said she'd give us a chance to do it first.'

'Right,' Maddie says, her tone dismissive.

'Please, Maddie.' Her voice sounds desperate even to her own ears.

Maddie looks at her, and Rebecca looks right back into those chilly blue eyes that are assessing her with a calculated look. No, not calculated, she doesn't want to think that. There is a chance that Maddie will get off, if she says she acted in self-defence against her abuser. Rebecca's mind is whirring as to how she'd spin it if she was Maddie's lawyer. Years of trauma pushed her to this, she'd say. But then, Maddie had carefully taken the paperwork, collected the receipts, opened Josh's phone and deleted the email trail. Now, other things are sliding into place too. Things about Maddie's story that don't quite make sense. That never did. Not least the extraordinary and definitely legally dubious thing they had done together. That had produced the miracle of Rebecca's life. That she is unwilling to jeopardise for anything, even Maddie.

'I'll go to the police first thing,' Maddie says as if it's as easy as that. But

Rebecca is tentatively pleased.

‘Thank you. Do you want me to come too?’ she asks reluctantly because she doesn’t want to leave the baby.

‘No, you look after James.’ Maddie forces a smile.

‘Thanks, Maddie,’ Rebecca says, adding, ‘Take my car.’ Her neat little Porsche which Maddie loves and Rebecca doesn’t let her drive.

Maddie squeals, her sudden delight utterly jarring in the circumstances. ‘No way.’

‘Way. I know it’s not an easy thing to have to do and I appreciate you doing it.’

‘No, not easy,’ Maddie says, her face changing from excited glee to sad and downtrodden in seconds. It makes Rebecca think of casting videos for films where famous actors are asked to show ‘range’. She pushes the thought away.

‘Thank you,’ she manages instead.

‘Of course, Bex, you’re right, I know you are. I’m sure it will be fine, once I explain.’

Rebecca nods, though she can’t help wondering how Maddie can be so blasé about death. And not just any death, one which she is responsible for. The death of her husband, a man she had once claimed to love.

A bellow comes down the stairs and Rebecca jumps up. ‘I’ll go,’ she says, as if it’s ever Maddie who sees to his needs.

‘Okay, cool. I’m going to try to get a bit more sleep but I’ll head off first thing, alright?’

‘Yes.’

Maddie grabs her as she passes, pulling Rebecca in close. ‘Love you,’ she murmurs.

Rebecca says it back, but in the small dark hours of this strange night she finds the words catch in her throat.

Rebecca had heard time and time again how difficult the nights were and, certainly, Maddie found getting up to feed James absolutely unbearable. Rebecca, though, loved it. She’s suffered for years with a kind of insomnia. She generally had no trouble getting to sleep but would often ping wide awake and find herself unable to doze off again. Now she finds herself following the baby’s lead as he wakes, eats and goes back to sleep, drifting off herself almost straight away. Is this what contentment looks like?

They have been up for the early morning feed and he has settled again. She thinks about Josh, the baby's father. Tears sting her eyes, threatening to spill. She still loves him. *Loved*, she thinks. Because the main feeling mingled in with fear and revulsion is excruciating, agonising grief.

Her name. Maddie checked in in her name. She had used her credit card. She had gone to meet Josh without telling Rebecca any of it. The baby, who came to life via an IVF clinic, was made using his sperm. Sperm they had stolen and put in her body. Oh God.

She has a terrible sense of foreboding and regret for her part in this turn of events. She is so used to stepping in, helping Maddie, and she'd done so again with little thought for the impact it would have on her son who, she realises in this moment, matters a lot more than her friend. She winds James, patting his warm, soft back, murmuring sweet sing-song words to him. Resting him in the crib. She lies down on the bed, her brain whirring. She could be eighteen again, Maddie curled into a tight ball, Rebecca standing, looking over the balcony at Oliver, his neck twisted, his leg at an impossible angle. Not moving an inch. The sounds of the party dwindling below as people ran out of the French doors and the screaming started.

Joshua had come to her. Come to see Rebecca, had pleaded with her, 'Please, Bex, I want to divorce her, yes, but I want her to be alright as well. I'm worried.'

'Leave me alone,' she'd told him, heart thudding, his presence awakening all kinds of feelings. She was raw then anyway. The baby was in Sussex with Maddie and Rebecca felt like she was missing a limb. 'Leave me alone,' she'd said to Josh; the last words she would ever say to him.

She opens the archived chat between her and Joshua, closes it again. During her pregnancy, she'd looked at his LinkedIn, which was always busy, his Facebook, far less so. He was occasionally tagged in pictures. One of him and Maddie appeared when Rebecca was almost eight months pregnant. They were at a dinner table with other couples, all well dressed, clearly plenty of money. Maddie was beautiful, petite and delicate in a short gold dress, resting back into Josh, her face beaming. A smile, Rebecca supposed, could hide a hundred different kinds of hurt. She should know. Hers had hidden years of almost unbearable loneliness. Loneliness she had managed to stay one step ahead of, head buried in case files, court documents.

For the first time ever, Rebecca had found herself bored with nowhere to escape to, and worse still, she was actively trying not to bump into people

from her day-to-day life. Workwise that was fine, most of them didn't live that far out. But locally she knew most people to nod to. She took to wearing ridiculous sunglasses and hats, knowing if she did see anyone she knew better her belly itself would be a disguise of sorts, because nobody expected her to be pregnant. Herself included. She drove across town and took long walks every day in the park where she'd met Ali, sitting like her mirror image, panting in the heavy heat. She knew she should walk away and told herself after that first meeting that she'd do just that. But as their friendship blossomed, so too did her fantasy life. One where she was married to her university sweetheart, carrying his child and bursting with hope for their happy future. The domestic bliss had felt so real it was like she could touch it.

When she was with Ali, she was a version of herself that wasn't real, but it was one she would very much like to be.

She was careful to keep their friendship over that side of town and she thought she recognised in her new friend a similar sort of longing as her own, though Ali's, she now realises, was different to hers. They became close quickly, and Rebecca was surprised at how much she wanted to see her, how much she enjoyed speaking to her. But she had always known it had to be temporary. When her baby arrived, that would be the end of this friendship, this fantasy version of Rebecca. The end of Ali's new BFF.

She got the text from Ali and she looked at the picture of Ali's beautiful little daughter and felt real joy at her arrival and then real pain, because she would never meet that baby, would never see Ali again.

But that's not how it worked out. Ali has in fact opened a wasps' nest of truths. Ones Rebecca finds hard to consider, though she knows she must. She forces her mind to go blank, listening to James's soft, even breath until eventually they both drift off to sleep.

ALI

Now

DI Gerard stares at me, lips pursed, eyes narrowed, her face a perfect example of subdued rage. Or an attempt to subdue rage. A failing one because I can clearly see how pissed off she is. I've told her the whole story, played her Joshua's voice message.

Dan says, 'We've just had a baby, and we don't have a lot of family. Ali had some issues, a bout of depression a few years ago . . .'

'I behaved terribly,' I say. 'As Dan says, I haven't exactly been myself, but there's no excuse. I'm extremely embarrassed.'

DI Gerard frowns at me, so I add quickly, 'I'm only telling you all this to give you some context. I don't think Rebecca is in any way to blame for . . . the man's death.'

'A death that most likely Josh's wife, who we've been trying to locate, by the way, knows something about.'

'I understand that,' I say. 'I only found out she existed yesterday.'

'And you believed her story, of domestic abuse?'

I shrug. 'I had no reason not to.'

'And you think she had something to do with Mr Hall's death.' DI Gerard says it as a statement, not a question, but I answer anyway.

'I . . . I don't know. Maybe it was self-defence?'

'The person who did this to Joshua Hall hit him repeatedly from behind, which does not indicate self-defence.' My blood runs cold. 'Do you believe me when I say whoever did it is of concern, regardless of their reasons?'

'Yes,' I say, voice small, 'I believe you.' And I do. If it wasn't self-defence, then that means Joshua was murdered in cold blood. Did Maddie fi-

nally snap? And, if she knows about Rebecca and Joshua, does that mean Rebecca is in danger too?

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REBECCA

Now

James sleeps right through. And Rebecca finds her eyes opening at 8 a.m., stinging and tired, but she is awake and more rested than she ought to be.

The baby is gurgling, kicking his chubby little legs and offering her a gummy grin.

‘Hello, baby boy,’ she says and he makes more noise.

She picks him up, heading downstairs to change him, feed him, kick-start the day. There is a note on the table – *I’ve gone to do the right thing!* And she feels a swell of relief.

She pulls out her phone, firing off a text to Maddie. *Well done*, she types. *You’ll feel better for it. I’m here for you.*

Though, honestly, she is pleased that Maddie has gone alone. Pleased that she needn’t deal with the awfulness of a heart-wrenching confession that she is now starting to doubt. Would Maddie go if she was guilty of murder – premeditated, not manslaughter? But, another voice whispers, you know murder doesn’t scare her.

James has his milk and lies on his mat, rolling back and forth, pausing to stare up at the mirrored toys dangling above his head.

Rebecca opens emails on her phone. She scrolls through them, getting the number to the clinic. She calls, heart thumping.

‘Hello?’

‘Hi, it’s Madeleine Hall here.’

‘Maddie,’ the receptionist says warmly, ‘how are you three getting along?’

You three. Rebecca, Maddie, Josh. She the benevolent friend helping out a couple in need.

‘We’re fine, thank you,’ she lies. It will only be a matter of time before they find out there what has happened.

‘How can I help?’

‘The report on my . . . issue.’

‘Issue?’

‘It was quite clear, wasn’t it, in the results of my test – I can’t get pregnant.’

‘No, I’m afraid not, you don’t produce eggs. Are you okay? We did say these feelings might come up.’

‘Yeah, no, I’m fine. I mean, there’s no way I could ever have been pregnant, is there?’

‘No, I’m sorry, Madeleine.’

‘Oh, it’s okay. We have our son now after all, don’t we?’

‘You do, and we are all delighted that things worked out.’

‘Thanks,’ Rebecca manages. ‘Me too.’

Maddie had never been pregnant. It wasn’t possible. That means Josh was telling the truth – about that, at least.

She picks up her phone again and dials Anita, her old housekeeper who she’s reconnected with since moving to Sussex and who’d made it clear she was up for babysitting duties anytime. Anita cheerfully agrees to have the baby for the day.

Then Rebecca calls Ali.

‘Hey.’ Ali’s voice is surprisingly warm considering the drama Rebecca has brought to her door.

‘Hey, how are you? What’s happening there?’

‘We’ve just left the police station.’ Her words come out in a sigh, Rebecca can almost feel the exhaustion. And she’s sorry for it. Ali is a decent person; their friendship really had been such a highlight at the end of Rebecca’s pregnancy. She’d dealt with the whole thing appallingly of course, but perhaps once this was all done and dusted they might be friends? Though as it stands in this moment she can’t imagine what done and dusted might look like.

‘How did it go?’

‘It was fairly brutal.’

‘Maddie left to go and see them this morning.’

‘Did she?’ I hear the surprise in Ali’s voice. ‘But Rebecca, the police, they said . . . they said it can’t have been self-defence.’

Her heart stops, the suspicions that have been building, the ones she so desperately wanted to ignore, suddenly taking on solid form.

‘She murdered him, didn’t she?’ Rebecca’s voice is a whisper, as if muting the sound might take some of the horror from her words.

‘I . . . I think she did, yes.’ A pause, then, ‘If there was a history of abuse, perhaps she sort of snapped . . .’

‘She lied to me about being pregnant, Ali. I checked. What if she was lying about everything?’ Rebecca’s voice is no longer a whisper, panic taking over.

‘Oh, God. I don’t even know what to say to that.’ Ali is silent for a moment on the other end of the phone. ‘But I am sorry. For your loss. You knew him well, I guess – Josh?’

‘I did, yes.’ Tears clog her voice as images of him sneak up on her unbidden. She squeezes her eyes shut. Now is not the time. The grief can come later. Now she needs to solve this puzzle.

‘The baby, he *is* yours, isn’t he?’

‘Yes.’ She opens her eyes, watches him merrily playing away, his mouth making cooing sounds, limbs flailing around. ‘He is mine. Biologically and legally as a surrogate in the UK. I don’t have to hand him over to anyone else.’

‘That bit at least should be easy enough then, no custody battles?’

‘No, I don’t foresee anything like that.’ Rebecca had had the good sense to make the paperwork so that she ultimately had parental responsibility. She and Maddie had been in the process of drafting various agreements about future plans, but Maddie in true Maddie style had dithered and now that would go firmly in Rebecca’s favour. She is the only living person with parental responsibility because James’s father has been murdered.

A shiver snakes down her spine.

‘Rebecca, what are you doing now?’

‘I’ve got a few errands to run. What about you? Are you alright?’

‘I’m fine. It’s you I’m worried about, honestly. Listen, if Maddie killed Joshua on purpose, if she planned it, and she knows about you and him . . .’

‘You think she might hurt me too.’

‘Yes. Maybe. I don’t know. Just . . . please be careful, Rebecca.’

Rebecca can hear the concern in Ali’s voice, but she can’t believe that Maddie would ever hurt her. Not after everything they’ve been through.

‘I promise I will. And, look . . . I’m so sorry, about everything.’

‘It’s okay. Well, it’s not okay, not at all, but it’s not entirely your fault. Plus, if I hadn’t been so persistent I wouldn’t have got involved in the first place.’

‘I’m glad you were. Persistent, I mean.’

‘Me too.’ There’s a short pause before Ali speaks again, ‘I imagined them being best friends, you know.’

‘The babies?’ Rebecca finds herself smiling at that.

‘Yes.’

‘Maybe they still could be? Though I’d completely understand if that was the last thing you wanted.’

‘Crazy as it sounds, I think I would like that.’

‘So would I.’ Rebecca says. She is still smiling when she hangs up the phone.

Rebecca drops the baby off to Anita, who asks, ‘Is everything okay?’

She almost says yes. Instead, catching the look of concern in Anita’s eyes, the woman who practically raised her, she says, ‘No, not really.’

‘Anything to do with Maddie?’ Anita had never been a fan, any more than her dad had been. ‘She’s troubled,’ they’d both told her years ago and they were right but, as so many of Maddie’s issues had been due to Rebecca, what could she do?

‘Yes.’ Her shoulders slump and she says to Anita, ‘You never liked her, did you?’

‘Madeleine? Not particularly, no. I felt sorry for her though. Her parents were strange people.’

‘Her brother was awful, a violent bully, he attacked Maddie and abused her, numerous times, for years, and when she told her mother, her mother stuck up for him.’

Anita makes a clucking sound at that. ‘Terrible.’

‘Yes, and very damaging.’

‘I imagine so.’

‘I don’t think she’s very well,’ Rebecca tells Anita. ‘I . . . I think she’s done something awful.’

‘Oh, Rebecca, what has she done?’

Rebecca swipes a tear away. Her phone buzzes again – the detective. She’ll call her back soon. ‘I have to go and find her, sort some things out.’

‘I’d like to know what’s been happening; you know you can talk to me,

pet.'

So Rebecca does, ushered in and sitting at Anita's kitchen table. Hands wrapped round a mug of tea that turns cold while she gives a garbled, abbreviated version of all that has transpired, the horror of everything that has happened apparent in her words. 'She killed Josh.' When she's finished, Anita is looking at her wide-eyed. 'You must think I'm mad,' Rebecca says.

'I think you were lonely,' Anita says carefully.

'I was; I knew I was.' Then, 'She covered for me, Anita – that bag, back then, it was mine.'

'You were taking drugs?'

'No, but I had a boyfriend who was; it was me who picked up his wallet, which was stuffed with drugs. I didn't know, I just put it in with my stuff.'

'Goodness me.'

'I know; it was a terrible thing to do – to let Maddie do. She knew I wouldn't be able to go into law if I had a criminal record. She . . . she sacrificed herself for me.'

'That's as may be, but you were young then. You're both adults now. She has made her choices.'

'I know.'

'Do you believe Maddie? About the abuse with her husband?'

'Yes,' she says. Then, 'No . . . I don't know. It turns out she's been lying about a lot of things. She knew stuff she hadn't told me, I think she knew about me and Josh.'

'But she didn't tell you?'

'No. Plus, she said she'd been pregnant, that Josh . . . that he pushed her down a flight of stairs and she lost the baby, but I've since found out, she couldn't conceive. So if she lied about that . . .'

'What else is she lying about?'

'Right.'

'In that case, you probably need to contact your friend.'

'Ali?' Rebecca frowns. 'Oh God, do you think *she's* in danger?'

'It sounds like Maddie knew about you and Josh and it was you she chose, that relationship she tried to protect. From what you're saying, she may even have committed a murder to do so.'

'Oh my God,' Rebecca says again, mentally chastising herself for not having considered this after Ali's own warning. 'I was going to head down there, go and see the police.'

‘You should, but check on her along the way.’

She leaves Anita’s with the phone pressed to her ear. It goes to voicemail, Ali’s warm voice saying, ‘Chances are I’m napping because Charlie is, so leave a message!’ It makes Rebecca smile briefly; she can just imagine Ali recording it.

‘Ali, It’s Rebecca. I don’t think Maddie is going to the police. I’ve thought about a few things and . . . well, it’s worrying. Look, I’m going to come to yours shortly just in case she turns up there or anything. So call me, and I’ll see you when I get there.’

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ALI

Now

Charlie is snuffling softly but not fully awake yet, so I reckon I've probably got enough time to shower. I stand under the hot water and feel some of the tension of the last few days, weeks and months slip away with the soapy water. I get out, head into my room and glance at the clock, surprised that Charlie hasn't woken yet. I'd expected to find her at least gurgling and looking for her next feed. I decide to risk giving my hair a quick blowdry and by the time I'm finished it's definitely been too long, going on two hours.

I head into her room murmuring, 'Hello, sleepyhead.' And my heart feels like it leaps from my chest to my throat when I find myself looking at an empty cot.

Oh my God, oh my God, oh my God.

My legs feel like cotton wool, as if they might buckle beneath me at any moment, and I flick my hand out, grabbing the doorframe for balance. 'Charlie,' I mean to shout, but it comes out like a pathetic squeak.

I get downstairs, open the door to our main living area and there she is, the snuffled sound of her as she drinks from a bottle of milk. I look up to meet cool, blue eyes. Maddie grins at me. 'I think she was hungry, woke up so nicely too. Not like that awful child of Josh's. He wakes up screaming his head off. Bet Rebecca didn't mention that, did she?'

'W . . . what are you doing here?'

'Feeding your daughter, duh,' she says as if I'm very very stupid. I take in the entire scene: Maddie, on my sofa; Charlie balanced in the crook of her arm, drinking. One of Maddie's hands is holding the bottle. The other is

hanging out limply from beneath my daughter's tiny, beautiful, innocent head, holding a long knife.

'How did you get in here?' My heart beats a thousand times a second. I am surprised at how calm my voice is.

'I broke your kitchen windows, let myself in through the back door.' She shrugs. 'Cut my arm a bit too.' She pulls the bottle out of Charlie's mouth and the baby roars with annoyance, the sound making me flinch. Maddie shows me her bare lower arm. There are jagged lines of blood on it. I think back to the paper cut I'd got all those months ago, whilst I was massive and frightened. Not like I'm frightened now. Now is like living through a horror movie of your own worst nightmare. Then, I was scared of Charlie. When I didn't even know her name. Scared I might not love her enough. It seems foolish now as I watch her, this tiny scrap that will always be a part of me. I feel with absolute certainty that a life where a child is lost will always be altered irrevocably and in a way I may not be able to withstand.

'Please don't hurt her,' I say, horrified at the desperation in my voice.

Maddie sighs, looks at the baby frowning and shoves the bottle back into her mouth far too roughly. I take a few steps forward and she flicks the knife upwards. It catches the faint winter light streaming in through the window and sort of twinkles. I sink down to the floor now, my legs finally giving way, unable to bear the weight of this any more than my mind or heart can.

'Don't make me,' Maddie says, her voice thick and malicious. Charlie has latched on to the bottle again and is at least quiet, though as soon as she's finished drinking she'll need to be winded and I dread to think how that manoeuvre will be done. I press my hands to my mouth, holding in a scream, and force myself to slow down my breathing, letting the air come in and out, hot against my fingers.

Maddie watches me with a bemused smile on her face while Charlie drinks and the sound of her sucking is like a terrible metronome, counting down the seconds until my whole world implodes.

ALI

Now

‘Maddie, please give me my baby.’

‘No.’

‘What are you hoping to achieve?’ I ask, tears making my words thick and craggy.

‘I want Rebecca to not be cross at me.’

‘Okay,’ I say, my mind whirring at the madness of that statement. That right now, her worry isn’t prison but the loss of her friend. ‘I get that; I do, I know how it feels,’ I say.

‘I’m not cross at you.’ A voice cuts between us, and Maddie’s eyes dart from me to over my shoulder. I look around. Rebecca. Oh, thank goodness.

‘Hi, Maddie.’ Rebecca smiles her warm, bright smile. It is jarring and wrong. Utterly out of sync with this insane situation.

‘You came down here for *her*,’ Maddie says, her words sharp and pointed.

‘I came down here to see you.’ Still that smile, broad and unwavering. ‘I was worried about you.’

Maddie makes a snorting sound that could be a laugh or a grunt. It’s hard to tell which. In my back garden I see people dressed in black, several of them moving around, signalling to each other with hand movements. I see the glint of a weapon. The police. Armed. I pull my eyes back to Maddie, lest she follow my gaze and see them too, but her focus is on Rebecca, who takes a step forward, says, ‘Come on, Maddie, let’s get going.’ Her arms reach out for her friend. I’m surprised to see Maddie standing.

‘Going?’ asks Maddie.

‘Yes. We need to go, just you and me, like we’d always planned. Like it al-

ways should have been.'

'Where will we go, Bex?' she says and if she wasn't holding my baby and a knife, the sad, desperate pleading in her voice might move me. As it stands, I've never wanted someone hurt or, better still, eradicated as I do right now, looking at her. I find myself bargaining with a God I don't believe in, *Please let Charlie be okay*. Please let this end, and I will do my absolute best to be grateful for the wonderful things I have. The wonderful life which will be nothing without her, my daughter.

'Somewhere far away, we'll take James and just drive, okay?'

'Really?'

'Yes, of course. Give me her baby, I'll hand her back to Ali, then we can get going.'

Everything then happens in a few swift motions, so quick and so unexpected.

Maddie steps towards Rebecca, holding Charlie out, the knife dangling. Then Charlie is in Rebecca's arms, screaming. Maddie sort of jumps and then she gasps an awful, awful sound. Rebecca thrusts once, twice, then there is a moment of stillness, shattered only by my daughter's loud, belching sobs. A trail of red, slick and gushing, a river of it, falls between the two women.

'Charlie!' I shout. Rebecca turns, holding Charlie out to me; I stumble forwards, grabbing for my daughter, pressing her to me.

'Rebecca,' Maddie says, eyes wide, shocked. 'Rebecca.' She sinks to her knees then falls face forward. The red flows, it is hers, it is coming from her. She is bleeding profusely. She is bleeding to death on our living-room floor. But I don't care. I have my baby who I'm holding, whispering to.

Rebecca says, 'She was going to stab me. I'm sure she was,' voice thick with shock. Then there is a burst of activity, police are everywhere. Someone takes Rebecca by the hand and she turns her shocked face towards them, the knife slipping from her grip to the floor.

Epilogue

REBECCA

Now

Rebecca and Ali walk round the lake, eyes firmly on the toddlers who are dead set on pushing ahead and seemingly blind to all and every danger the world has to offer.

‘If we weren’t here,’ Ali says, ‘you know they’d just walk into the water.’

Rebecca sighs. ‘They would. Toddlers are like awkward drunk people, aren’t they?’

Ali laughs, Rebecca grins. ‘Remember that terrible show, *Out of Control Britain* or something, used to be on in the middle of the night, all about the horrors of English town centres at the weekends?’

‘I do actually, yes.’

‘Well, that’s them.’ She gestures at James who is now known as Jam after Charlie couldn’t pronounce it properly, and Charlie, who though the smaller of the two, is definitely in charge.

‘It is.’

The two women swap a smile. They walk here once a week, every Saturday morning. Ali works three days a week; on two of those days, Anita has both James and Charlie, and on the third, Ali’s mum has her granddaughter. Rebecca didn’t sell the house in the end, nor the practice where she’d gone back to her old job. It had been hard at first amid the newspaper stories and the gossip. But both women are okay now. They’ve helped each other move on. Rebecca from Maddie, Ali from Max and Izzy. A new future stretches out before them.

‘So, tell me about your date,’ Ali says.

Rebecca does, with a groan. She is, she supposes, putting herself out there.

She likes her life now. Loves being a mum, loves having Anita around, but she would like a more personal relationship. Even if her track record hasn't been great. If nothing else, her adventures on Bumble and Tinder make for good anecdotes to share with Ali.

She misses Maddie and feels a terrible sadness when she thinks of her friend. She lost her way, but for many years Rebecca had relied on her, loved her and considered her family.

It's why, that night, all those many, many years ago when Oliver had told her about his feelings for Maddie, Rebecca had been so appalled.

'We didn't want to hurt you,' he'd told Rebecca, 'Maddie especially, she loves you.'

Rebecca had stared at him open-mouthed. 'Nothing has happened yet,' he'd assured her, as if that mattered, but he'd told her they both had feelings. Maddie had spent the whole conversation looking at her feet, avoiding Rebecca's eyes. Rebecca had gotten drunk then, blindingly, appallingly drunk. She'd passed out, she supposed. On the bed. When she'd woken up, the two of them were out on the balcony and it was obvious what they were talking about. It had felt like being punched in the face hearing Maddie say, 'I feel the same way about you, but Rebecca is my best friend.' *I feel the same way!*

She'd seen red, been absolutely furious. Jumped up from the bed and headed out to the balcony, unheard and unseen, her hands springing out in front of her before she had a chance to even consider it.

He'd gone fast, straight away, plummeting backwards. She'd leaned over, watched him go. Then she'd turned to Maddie.

Maddie had been upset, of course, and angry. At least to start with. But Rebecca pointed out that, really, it had been Maddie's fault. She had betrayed her; she'd made Rebecca do this. Rebecca – the only person who believed her about Tim, who loved her more than her parents ever did.

She'd apologised then, Maddie, who so loved Rebecca, who relied on her so much. She was, after all, the closest thing to family Maddie had ever had. 'This,' Rebecca had said to her, 'is on you. You may as well have pushed him and if anyone asks, that's what I'll say.' She had collected their things, her bag, forgetting what she'd put in there. The package she'd picked up earlier from Oliver that she'd hassled and hassled him to get for her even though he didn't want to. He used drugs occasionally, recreationally, but he was always wary of larger amounts. She sold drugs to the other

girls at school, not because she needed the money but for the sheer thrill of it and as a test to see how they reacted, who was strong enough to dabble, who got dragged down. Maddie had tried to make her stop, and she was going to, but the truth was, Rebecca liked the power; plus, she was angry – at her father for sending her there, at the other girls who'd not exactly welcomed Rebecca with open arms. She enjoyed seeing them brought down by their pathetic addictions, their need to fit in.

Maddie had sobbed, begged for Rebecca's forgiveness. Rebecca had said she just wasn't sure she could give it. She'd seen Maddie's lips tremble and felt sorry for her, though the pain of the betrayal still stung. And, she pointed out, look, look what it had driven her to do.

'I'll make it up to you,' Maddie promised. Rebecca had nodded as Maddie sank to the floor, arms gripping her legs, pulling herself into a tight little ball. Sounds were coming from downstairs now and Rebecca realised time was running out, they had only seconds. She whispered furiously to her friend, '*Oliver fell.*' Over time Rebecca came almost to believe it herself. A terrible accident had occurred, nothing more. Though sometimes she'd come to in the middle of the night, sure she was lying on that bed, listening to the devastating details of her best friend's betrayal. She'd see Oliver sobbing and apologising, as if that could help. She'd almost feel herself step forward, plant her hands on his chest and . . . push.

Maddie got to make it up to her sooner rather than later, absolving herself of guilt by taking the fall for Rebecca. It had proved to Rebecca that Maddie was loyal, that she could be trusted. But it hadn't cemented them together for ever and by the time Maddie got out, things had changed; Maddie was the one in the driving seat. Guilt had eaten away at Rebecca for years when Maddie was in hospital, but now, well, she tried not to think about it. If she thought too hard about that day at Ali's house when Maddie had handed over the baby and the knife, the guilt came back. So, she didn't. It was self-defence, she told herself. Ali backed up Rebecca's story, that Maddie had stepped towards her with the knife out, that Rebecca had managed to grab it, turning it on her instead. Actually, Maddie had been holding out the baby and Rebecca had seen her chance. Maddie was a liability, a murderer. And she knew too much. Rebecca had James to consider now. She couldn't allow Maddie to jeopardise that, could she?

No point dwelling on the past. Maddie had ruined everything, after all, made such a big mess of things. She had been losing it and Rebecca had no

doubt that she'd have done something to ruin James's future. To ruin Rebecca's. She did what any other mother would and protected her child. And everything had worked out okay. She even has a new best friend. Having Ali makes the pain of losing Maddie bearable, welcome even. Ali shares lots of traits with Maddie, their vulnerability, for one, but Ali is less screwed up; she's far less likely to go rogue. Dan, however, might be a problem. He's wary of Rebecca, even though she pointedly and repeatedly shows him her best self. Still, she isn't going to let a man come between her and Ali; if Dan doesn't butt out of their friendship Rebecca will find a way to make him. She's resourceful like that.

'Penny for them?' Ali says now.

'I was just thinking, we ought to do a big double birthday party this year – can you believe they'll be two?'

'I know! It'll probably feel like no time at all that we're planning their eighteenth.'

Rebecca smiles warmly at her friend. Yes, no matter what happens, Ali is a friend for life.

Acknowledgements

Always, always thanks to my husband Andrew, for everything.

Thanks to Lucy Dauman for approaching me with this project and making edits so effortless. Your insight and creativity has made me a better writer and this book has been a blast to work on.

To Hattie Grunewald for having my back and being there for all the tricky conversations, especially (but not limited to) ones about the functionality of nursing bras and their aesthetic outcomes.

Thank you to Isabel Martin for assisting with edits and lots of the admin. Thanks too to Jill Cole for thorough copy edits and Sarah Bance for proofreading. And thank you to the wider team at Headline; so much work goes into getting a book from first draft to the shelf and I'm really grateful to you all. I've always been fairly lucky with covers but this one is exceptionally lovely – thank you to Lisa Horton for doing such a brilliant job.

Thank you Criminal Minds for the sanity, pep talks, the (far too dodge to write here) jokes and the general support.

Lots of love and gratitude to both of my sons. Like Ali in *The Due Date* I remember the early, confusing and often lonely days of motherhood, especially first time round when I was young and unsure, but watching you two grow and thrive is one of life's blessings. It helped loads that you were both exceptionally cute babies.

Last but not least, thanks to the readers who picked this book up. I hope you had as much fun reading *The Due Date* as I did writing it.

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